

boobad
nikki

arnica butler

BAD NIKKI

A HOTWIFE NOVEL

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

The clip began with a smear of walls and lights, blazing across the screen to the soundtrack of already started parley between the low baritone of Tony's voice, and a string of soft, shy giggles from Nikki.

The camera settled on her. Too-bright sunlight glared from a foot-wide gap in the blackout curtains, the patterns of the Holiday Inn's new decor, cast in a dystopian glow, appeared on the bedspread. A patch of carpet, the bamboo-styled wallpaper behind her. That it was a clone of the room Jack was sitting in made it disturbingly close and yet so far out of his reach.

She was seated with her legs crossed, a form-fitting t-shirt and tight jeans covering her body while revealing its lithe curves. Lightly make-upped, freshly showered, only a trace of tiredness dulling the usual brightness of her eyes.

Commentary ceased from Tony as the camera moved jaggedly toward her, zeroing in on her face. In Nikki's eyes, a guilty glint and some hesitation.

"Tony, I don't know -"

"I know," Tony said authoritatively, just as his big shovel of hand moved into the frame, beneath Nikki's chin to tilt it upward. The frame shrank in scope, narrowing in on Nikki's mouth. More jiggling, a nervous giggle.

You know what you're doing, right?

Nikki whispered these words. They coiled into Jack's mind, where he pulled them apart for every nuance, wringing from them every delicious insinuation, as he watched her lips move to say them.

"I know," Tony's voice began, "*exactly* what I'm doin,' little girl."

And then hundreds of long, excruciating seconds of silence, as a tube of lipstick, held boorishly in Tony's thick fingers, appeared in the unsteady scene. Tony spread the peachy red butter slowly over Nikki's lips.

"There." Tony's voice. "Now, blow him a kiss."

Nikki's lips, now garishly red, trembled with a little hesitancy. Her lower lip began to retract slightly, wandering up to her front teeth, but in an abrupt shift, her lips puckered into an air kiss, and Tony's baritone rumbled the first part of a word.

Then the frame froze.

The end.

No message.

Sent from Nikki's phone.

Time out, as the dispatchers would say: 731 hrs.

*

There was no problem getting the room for another night. After waiting, his cock aching and rigid, for another message from Nikki (or anything, anything at all), he dragged himself to the shower and tried to focus on the tasks at hand. He jerked off violently, replaying the video over and over again in his mind to try and purge it – not from his memory, but from constant circulation in his thoughts.

It worked long enough to get him on the phone, booking the room for another night, arranging for Nikki's parents to stop by and check on the

kids. He opted for saying that they were having a romantic work vacation, and it was the most disingenuous of the things he had to do, strumming a chord of guilt inside him. The effect of making that call was two-pronged: he felt guilty, but the guilt concentrated the delicious taste of the forbidden.

It was a too-bright day, and the sunlight cast a strange light on the whole idea. Doubts filed in as the time ticked away, and he combated them by watching the video again, obsessively.

Were they really doing this?

Or more importantly - was Nikki really doing this? Was she really up for it, the way she had been the night before? With all day to consider what she was doing? Most of him wanted her to be, but tucked away in other parts of his mind was the feeling that he wouldn't be displeased if she changed her mind.

But Nikki didn't seem to be changing her mind as time went on.

I have another picture for you

Nikki: 1103 hrs.

Jack stared at her text. A throb of molten longing, liquidly arousing, was pouring through him from chest to balls. His heart jump-started and rattled away as he stared at the messenger app, waiting for more.

Was Nikki doing this deliberately? And if she was, how did she *know*, how did she tap into, so precisely, the exact vein of his fantasy that clawed inside of him with the sharpest teeth? Thinking about it - about the dark, hazy, fearsome "something" that was growing inside of Nikki - flicked a spray of sheer terror into the tempest of his mind.

Exasperated, he answered her baiting text at 1115.

Send it to me

He waited. No dots from Nikki. She was probably in the middle of class. Sitting in a classroom, her hair up in her tidy ponytail, likely with her legs crossed and her round bottom jutting a little toward the back of the chair. Avoiding eye contact with Tony, who was watching her squirm in her chair, thinking about her sore pussy.

It's really REALLY NSFW

I'm deleting it after I send it.

So I had to make sure you're there.

Are you ready?

His hands were actually shaking as he held the phone. Nikki sent the messages line by line, one by one, dragging it out. Finally, a long pause punctuated the incoming messages, long enough that he decided to nudge her.

I'm ready

You have to delete it

I promise

There was a lengthy pause. Jack was on the bed, clutching a pillow, staring at his phone like a madman. His mouth had gone dry and sweat was welling up on the back of his neck. A picture so NSFW that Nikki wanted him to delete it... his imagination ran wild.

Shoot...I have to find the right time

Lots of eyes right now

Jack's chest burned slowly.

This was a completely plausible reason for what she was doing, and yet he couldn't help but layer a different narrative over it: Nikki was dragging these details out because she knew how much they tortured him, which meant that Nikki knew exactly what she was doing and how to press his buttons.

Or, in the moments he felt darkest: *Tony* knew exactly how to make Nikki do whatever he told her to, and so it was *Tony* who was pressing his buttons, via Nikki.

Ultimately, though, it didn't matter: the truth was that he wanted the picture more than he had wanted a cigarette when he first quit smoking, and so he spent the next few hours attempting to entertain himself and failing, waiting like a salivating pet for the picture.

Did you get the room all taken care of?

Tony is asking.

This was the text that accompanied the picture. His eyes lingered on the words, his brain processing the question, but these thoughts were a back eddy in his mind. They circulated, round and round, unanswerable for the moment, because they arrived beneath the promised picture.

The picture was being processed somewhere else, somewhere dark and primordial.

Dark skin. The lumpy, grotesque shape of a distended cock, shining with saliva. Tight, dark pubic curls, the aftermath of a blow-job glistening in the

thicket. And in a smeared and uneven line, a ring of red goop, like dirt marking the water line of a filthy bath, a few inches from the base of Tony's cock.

The image itself was being beamed into his visual cortex, but his mind played a montage of remembered images over it: the lipstick tube in Tony's black fingers, smearing the red color on Nikki's pouting lips. The stretched shape of her mouth around the massive girth of his cock, her skin pulled taut and white around her mouth. Unbidden, the scent of acrid cum mingled with Nikki's pussy juices rose into Jack's nostrils, a phantom odor that had long ago left the room in the housekeeping basket.

Delete that! ;)

Room spinning, if only subtly. Vision blurred, in patches. He could feel the fierce pumps of his heart, and they felt contorted, like someone was gripping his heart in their hand and squeezing it unevenly. Finger numb and shaking. He typed.

Of course. To both

A long pause.

That's it?!!!

What does a girl have to do around here to get her husband's attention?

Jack exhaled sharply, shakily, felt a smile on his face, and then felt a wave of nausea. How stupid was he? But also: was Nikki *serious*?

You have my full attention

It's all I'm thinking about

Another long pause.

Three heart emoticons were delivered next.

And then nothing. Of course nothing, of course Nikki had class - a class that was important to her. Even that thought came with its own peculiar bite: how could anything be more salient to Nikki right now than this? The uneven terrain of sexual desire had always bothered him at some deeper level, but he had been married for a long time and pushed it away with all the other petty grievances of a marriage. Nikki liked sex, but she didn't *crave* it, or need it, or have her whole day upended by it like he did. The idea that she might be going on about her day, taking tests or sitting in a classroom and thinking about anything else scratched at the scab he'd long ago let from there.

What seemed like an eternity later, Nikki wrote again.

On a break - 5 minutes. We should be done around 430.

Tony has a shopping list for us.

OK. What is it?

Infuriatingly, Nikki didn't write back for several minutes. The dots indicating that she was typing a message bounced along the bottom of his app, then went still, then started again, an unending digital striptease that only materialized five long minutes later, brief and unsatisfying:

Tell you later

I'm so excited

Me too, he typed back. He was; this was true. And Nikki's expression of enthusiasm was definitely *good*. But Nikki had a tendency to convey her

excitement about all things via text in the exact same way: pancakes, field cricothyrotomies, new tires, cute pictures of animals, explosions, sucking chest wounds.

If anything, she was *less* excited by this than a field cruke, because she hadn't added the head explosion emoticon.

There was also the matter of the shifting, sandy ground of power and dominance that he found himself on with Tony, which made his head spin. His fantasies had never gone into the realm of very personalized detail about the man his wife would be sleeping with, about the ephemeral hierarchy that would be established in the heat of the moment.

Tony was obviously - to use the scaffolding favored by Mike - an alpha male, and there was no question in Jack's mind that Tony was the man in charge. The man who made shopping lists (a pang of unadulterated amphetamine surged inside him just touching on the *idea* of what such a list could contain), the man who told his wife to sit still while he put lipstick on her and then commanded her to suck his dick, the man who took those pictures with her camera and told her to send them to her husband.

Each of these actions could be read on the surface as humiliating, and yet Tony couldn't have pushed Jack's buttons with greater skill if Jack himself had given him the orders. The ideas were so outrageous, so filthy and primal, that Jack would never have had the gumption to suggest them to Nikki himself. Did he *want* his wife to leave a ring of lipstick on another man's cock? It wasn't an idea he'd ever thought of himself, but that didn't mean he wasn't going to put that image in his masturbation files and refer back to it for the rest of his life. His cock was hard just thinking about it again.

There was also the curious feeling he had, that Tony seemed to have a sense of his - Jack's - boundaries. Maybe Tony sensed them better than he did. It added a layer of complexity to the situation that was disturbing and titillating at the same time. Tony was, after all, shaking awake a sexual beast inside Nikki that Jack knew he couldn't have possibly dared to even nudge by the shoulder. Was it humiliating to receive what you actually wanted?

If anything, Jack felt - however reluctantly - like fanboy of Tony's. And wasn't that the consummate feature of a true alpha male? He was taking what he wanted, but he was doing it in a way that worked out for everyone's desires, even the lowly non-alpha Jack.

Jack laughed out loud, alone in the hotel room with a hard cock, because the strangest thought occurred to him, and he let it play out as a daydream in his head, with predictably hilarious results:

Mike, he would say on Monday. Guess what? That alpha male fucked my wife in front of me, but he let me in on it, too. And it was hot as fuck. I think I like the guy, to be honest. Even if he scares the shit out of me.

Mike would shake his head and click his tongue, then his mouse.

That is some real delta shit, bro.

Or something like that.

CHAPTER 2

The knock was timid, a quick succession of soft raps. Jack almost ignored it, it was so un-Nikki-like. Eighteen years of banging on doors had made Nikki into a very well-announced guest: usually she hauled on a door in a way that would wake the dead, no matter the circumstances.

He was on the edge of his bed. He had taken a second shower by then, and was sitting in his jeans and shirt, already wound up for another round of sex, or masturbation, or whatever came first. Had he actually heard the knock? Who knew? He was well into hallucinatory territory at this point.

"It's just me," Nikki said, from behind the door, in a sweet voice. "You there?"

When he opened the door, Nikki was standing in front of it with a pull-cart suitcase - no doubt packed neatly, even in the midst of all this - and the outfit he'd seen in the video. She smiled and stepped toward the room, as Jack stood there, dumbfounded, not thinking to move out of her way to let her in.

This troubled Nikki, whose expression changed rapidly. "Are you okay?" she whispered, putting her hand out to his chest. Her eyes darted to the side and she turned her head to look down the hall. Jack popped his head out to follow her gaze, but the hallway was empty.

"If you aren't...?" Nikki began, but Jack seized her by the collar of her shirt and pulled her inside. The wheely cart bounced against the door but Nikki nimbly pulled it behind her as it closed. Jack was shaking his head: no, he wasn't not okay, no that wasn't why he was standing there like an idiot. He pulled Nikki to him, wrapping his fingers into her ponytail, and kissed her

deeply on the mouth. She tasted like mint, and the chemical sweetness of a diet cola.

Nikki put her arms on his shoulders and then pulled them down between their torsos, playing her fingers over his chest. It was the choreography of *them*: this was how Nikki curled up within his embrace when she was uncertain of something and wanted to talk it out. The familiarity of it, mingled with the discomfort of their new sex life, overwhelmed Jack. He held her tightly and kissed her on the forehead, but his cock throbbed against her body where he knew she could feel it: two competing forces playing out all at once.

"Was it too much?" Nikki asked, looking up at him. She was whispering like they were in a library they weren't taking very seriously. Her eyes were on a quest for his real emotions. When she did this, she took on a birdlike, preying quality: her eyes darted like a hawk's, tracking every movement of his own, digging into his expressions the way a bird of prey would tear apart the flesh of its next meal. "Tony told me you would like it, that's the only reason... I sent it."

Her eyes stopped on his, melting through his heart as they got wet with a frustration peculiar to Nikki: she liked doing things the right way, and she got pretty wound up if she did what she thought was the right thing and it didn't actually turn out right.

He kissed her again. There would be time to deal with the issue of Tony - of Nikki doing whatever Tony told her to do - some other time.

"I haven't been able to think about anything else all day." He touched her mouth with his thumb and ran it across her lower lip. A thick, warm substance slid beneath the tip of his thumb, streaking a very pale smear of

pink onto her skin. Jack looked at it, inspecting it. "You didn't wear the red to class?"

Nikki's eyes were glued to his face. She shook her head slowly, lips frozen partly open as he had left them. Her eyes were coming alive with new emotions, all of them very heated, feral, and somewhat terrifying. Molten emotions rolled through Jack's abdomen, and his heart spasmed in his chest.

His fingers had moved down to where her shirt overlapped her jeans, and beneath it, taking the shirt with him as his fingertips glided over Nikki's silky skin. Her skin was dry and cool, no patches of heated moisture or tacky patches of bodily fluids that hadn't been rinsed away.

He put his ear next to hers. "And when exactly did Tony say he was coming by? Hmm?"

Nikki's body moved beneath his hands, squirming beneath his fingers like a stretching cat. She lifted her arms and tugged the ponytail free, letting her tresses fall down around her shoulders. "He didn't," she said. "He'll text us."

Nikki was looking at him strangely, sucking the tiniest bit of her lower lip beneath her two front teeth, letting it slip from beneath the white and poof into an arousing, freshly bitten cloud of pink flesh. She had something else to say.

"And?" Jack said, his fingers finding the smooth contours of a sports bra, or maybe something different - rough knobs of lace surprised him midway over the full teardrops of her breasts.

"And..." Nikki said, allure melding into hesitancy. "He said... you would want..." Nikki tipped her head forward and leaned it against Jack's,

watching his fingers beneath her shirt. "...to inspect me. And... um..." Nikki paused.

Jack lifted the shirt over her head, and she lifted her hands to allow him to pull it off. Her breasts were pulled tightly to her chest by a strange lacy sports bra contraption Jack was sure he'd never seen before.

"And... um?" Jack prodded, gently. He ran his fingers down the sides of her neck, down her shoulders, back to her ribcage, over the bra, and back under again, pushing it up to her sternum.

Her freed breasts burst from their confinement, contorted a little beneath the pressure of the bra. It was vaguely reminiscent of BDSM. Her nipples were puffing to life, hardening with no more than the touch of the cool air on them.

Jack watched his own fingers as he moved the tips over her flesh, circling in on the soft, even silkier skin of her aureole, feeling the inflamed, distended patches of pink, abused flesh, where someone - either him, but more likely Tony, had pinched her nipples or sucked on them until a smattering of petechiae dotted her otherwise unblemished skin.

Goosebumps rose in a wave over Nikki's skin - along her shoulders, down her arms. Jack kissed her mouth again, playing with her nipples, moving her toward the bed. Nikki was giving in to this - her nipples hardened into stiff peaks and her hips melted forward. Her skin dampened slightly with a flush of arousal, sweat evaporating before it had a chance to shine on her skin, leaving only the lingering, sweet scent, humid in the air closest to her. But she was also resisting it - she moved clunkily, pressing back a little against his momentum.

She was no match for him, though. He felt the little pop of serotonin, maybe a hit of testosterone, as Nikki stumbled in the direction he wanted her to: it was the kind of animalistic, size- and muscle-based domination that was always available to him, and yet rarely indulged in, precisely because it was so easy and its thrill - ordinarily - felt too beastly and dark to him. It was nothing to move Nikki this way or that way, even if she wanted to violently resist it. That wasn't what she was doing, but she was doing something, and the friction felt good. Overcoming it felt better.

Nikki's calves hit the bed and her momentum carried her down to the edge of it, seated, her hands falling to her sides and back to stop herself from falling fully onto the bed. She looked up at him, hair loose and eyes alive, but an indeterminate *something* behind them, not letting her give in.

This made Jack pause, scanning his brain for what the snag might be, and this was just enough time for Nikki to pull her feet up to the edge of the bed and scoot herself, in a kind of reverse crawl on her elbows and butt, propelled by her feet, toward the head of the bed.

A new expression moved in to replace the one before. Jack tried to read it - it was eager, mischievous, playful. An atypical Nikki face. She pushed her hands down on either side of her hips and pushed her breasts out, but when Jack climbed onto the bed to get at her, she scooted further back. "Tony says..." she began, smiling devilishly.

"Tony says what? What does Tony say?"

He must have gotten more of a kick of testosterone from that push than he had realized, he thought. Aggression was seeping into his bloodstream. He kept moving, pulling Nikki's wandering legs back into line so that he could straddle her as he moved up.

He was rewarded for this by a look of semi-disbelief from Nikki, her mouth falling open a little, her eyes lighting up with the sexiest glint a woman could have: a new appraisal. And because a smile lurked at the corners of her mouth, she liked whatever new thing she was appraising.

Jack reached for the button of her jeans, and Nikki watched hungrily and let him. He pulled on the waist, lifting her slightly from the bed, and the button popped open with a stroke of his thumb. The zipper crunched as it split open, revealing a pair of underwear that matched the bra: utilitarian but sexy, hinting at some planning on Nikki's part. Jack filed that tidbit away for later.

Nikki reached for his hands then and grasped them, her lips closed into a smile. "Tony says," she began, trying to scoot from him at the same time. Jack moved his legs, letting Nikki grip his hands, and pulled her legs together and then braced against her hips, trapping her.

"Yeah, what does Tony say?" he growled.

"He says you would like it if I told you that you can't fuck me yet," Nikki said, beginning seriously, but laughing toward the end. She tried twisting to her left and couldn't. She threw her head back on the pillow and huffed, which did absolutely nothing for her cause if she really wanted Jack to stop.

But too many small hits of testosterone had pinged him, and he didn't care. Tony was right, of course, but Tony wasn't here to enforce anything and so Jack was in charge.

"To hell with Tony," he told her, pulling down hard on her pants.

*

They expelled their first, harsh, post-coital breath together, at the same time, huffing from the exertion, their faces still close. Nikki's ended in a smile, her eyes wide, so Jack smiled, too. It was a sweet moment, and he lingered, his cock still inside her, the attenuating spasms of her pussy rippling against his cock, her breath ragged and growing quiet.

It was the kind of look they gave to each other, throughout their marriage, whenever the sex was unexpectedly hot.

Jack rolled away from Nikki and lay on his back, still panting heavily. He flung his arms wide, working one beneath Nikki's shoulders and throwing the other one across the bed. "Wow," he said.

Nikki rolled to rest her cheek on his shoulder and chest. He twitched when her hair tickled his armpit, and Nikki laughed: this was a known hazard, but it had been a really long time since she had triggered it.

"This is weird," Jack said, as his thoughts drifted. Nikki didn't say anything right away, so he continued. "We're doing this new thing, but -"

Nikki sat up excitedly, smiling, and shifted so that her chin was resting on his chest and she was on her stomach. " - but it's making everything between us feel like old - I mean, new, I mean... you know, like it used to be. Right?" she asked excitedly.

Her energized feet swung behind her playfully before crossing elegantly and twisting together - Nikki's ankles were very flexible and so she liked to wind her feet together an extra half-turn, which was both slightly grotesque and amusingly sexy at the same time. She also stretched her toes - which she had extraordinary maneuverability over - apart when she did this and planted them in weird ways on her calf.

"Right," Jack said, smiling with a lot of sentiment for the first time in a long time.

Nikki's legs were moving again, shifting side to side like a cat's tail. Her eyes gleamed and her fingers strummed on his chest, weaving into his sparse hair. Her gaze shifted to her own fingers. "So... I guess we should talk about tonight," she said.

In an alluring, sexy tone. Desire warping every contour of her voice.

This was a new Nikki: a Nikki who had just had an orgasm, not only thinking about sex again already, but wanting to talk about it and marinate in it, the way Jack did, the way *men* did. Nikki was never like this; she had never even been like this, even at the beginning of their marriage.

"Okay..." Jack said, and unease flicked inside him somewhere, as it probably did, he figured, for anyone whose fantasies came to life. It wasn't enough unease to make him act on it or change anything - but he sensed that events were now cascading in ways that he wouldn't be able to stop, even if he tried.

Nikki smiled smartly and looked at her fingers. "Um, so... I guess we're supposed to talk about rules, right?"

"Is this something Tony told you again?" Jack asked, because it seemed like Nikki had hesitated at first, her tongue curled behind her teeth to form the first sound in the phrase "Tony says..." but had decided better of it.

Nikki's eyes lingered on her fingers while her smile changed shape minutely, taking on an enigmatic quality. She tipped her head and looked up at him, still smiling. "Maybe," she said. "But that doesn't make it a bad idea."

Jack pressed his lips together and rolled his head side-to-side. No, it wasn't a bad idea.

"So..." she said, moving a finger over his chest. "Do you have anything you don't want me to do? With Tony?"

Jack stared at her. She seemed to be getting turned on just by talking about this, her body moving - squirming, really - along his flank, her eyes lighting up, her every gesture dripping with sexuality and suggestion.

"My mind," he said slowly - and truthfully - "is completely blank."

Nikki chewed sexily on her lip and looked at him incredulously. Though it seemed impossible, Jack could feel his circulation - which had just seconds ago returned to normal - redirecting back to his cock.

"Nothing?"

Jack's mind actually had gone blank. After all, Nikki had pretty much blown through every possible checkpoint last night.

"I just want you to, you know, only do what you're comfortable with," Jack added, a little bemused, when Nikki continued to stare at him as if she didn't believe him - or didn't want to, almost like she was waiting for a delicious morsel of food and not a rule about fucking another guy. "I have to admit, I was pretty surprised you did all that with him last night -"

"I *know*," Nikki said, her demeanor shifting again. *This* topic of conversation had her really excited, and there were echoes of her adrenaline-fueled excitement about the big, tricky, dangerous calls and about joining the tactical team in it. "But is there anything *you're* uncomfortable with?"

Jack's eyes went wide. "Does this mean there's *nothing* you wouldn't do?" he asked, dumbfounded.

Nikki laughed. "God, of course not!" she said. "Not... *nothing* I wouldn't do, I mean... where does that even take you? I've seen some *weird* shit on calls... no thanks. I just, uh... I don't know, like, part of the excitement is just... letting Tony decide what it is, you know? Tell me what to do, make me do it, and so... you know, like, just feel like I *have* to do it. Submit to him totally."

Jack's mouth was getting dry, his cock was getting hard, and he was staring openly at Nikki, who clearly read his shock - she gave almost a nod to it, physically, and half a wink - but kept talking. She seemed to be feeding off his reaction.

"It's hot, getting used like that. But I don't want to do anything that, you know, is going to not be okay with you, you know, or come back on us later. So... " she kissed his chest and looked up at him, fully aware of the effect her words were having on him, which only added fuel to the fire. "Just tell me... if there's anything... you don't want... me to do... to Tony."

She started moving down his ribcage, sliding her body along, the soft sacks of her breasts and the hardened nubs of her nipples dragging over his chest, then scraping over his thighs, and briefly over his scrotum, and she kept moving down. Jack watched her, transfixed, still striving to match the actions of the woman moving her mouth slowly down his body to the woman he knew as his wife, and getting hardly anywhere.

"Or," she said, looking now at his cock, watching it fill in violent jerks.

"That you don't want Tony to do to me..." She lightly stroked the length of

his shaft, brushing her fingers over the left side of it, making it stand at attention.

Her eyes shifted up to his, waiting for an answer, hovering above his erect cock, her lips just inches from it.

"I don't want to kiss him on the mouth," she said, and Jack was even more mystified by the fact that *saying* this seemed to get her more horny. She had something else to say, he could tell. She was waiting for him to say something, though.

He nodded. "I like that. Okay. I don't want to eat any creampie's," he added, for good measure - because he didn't.

Not yet, anyway. Or maybe more specifically - not at Tony's behest.

"I figured," Nikki said, being much more direct than ever. Her tongue left her mouth, pointed, with a mission - and she ran it neatly along the ridge of his crown, in one quick sweep. She kept looking at him with a teasing expression, into which Jack easily read that she wanted to exchange something, something was burning up inside of her and she wanted him to ask for it.

This wasn't a dynamic that had existed ever before in their marriage. Obviously, the *Tony* part was new, but the *real* new dynamic manifested in her eagerness, her awareness of the effect of her words on Jack, her desire - throbbing and pulsing beneath her skin - to deliver a taboo idea to him.

She tired quickly of waiting, which definitely *was* characteristic of Nikki: patience was not a virtue in her world, let alone something she possessed. Her warm breath lapped against the top half of his cock as she spoke:

"Do you want to know what he said? When I told him that?" she finally asked, her voice teasing.

She smiled.

Jack shuddered and nodded at the same time, hopeful that Nikki would understand that he was incapable of speaking. His mouth was hanging open, slack.

Nikki smiled and rolled herself up to her knees, displaying her body, stretching in yet another feline movement that licked Jack inside, somewhere in his torso. Her fingers were resting on his thighs, absently grazing his balls. "He said not to worry about it..." Nikki waited a beat, letting this sink in, building suspense like a pro. "... if that's the case, he'll just get my mouth all dirty right from the start."

Nikki's eyes dropped to watch his reaction as it unfolded in his cock, which throbbed and oozed a drop of cum in response. She seemed to almost be studying it, her head even tipping a little to the right, almost imperceptibly, the way it did when she was cooking up the solution to a difficult problem, choreographing her next physical moves in the few seconds preceding a challenging task. Jack figured he was the only person alive who recognized this minute gesture, it was so subtle.

Nikki assessed, smiled, and lifted her gaze to meet Jack's eyes as she moved a hand to his shaft and swept it up to the top of his dick, rolling her down-turned palm over the crown, spreading the precum over the jolting tip. "You like that," she breathed, satisfied in the way Nikki only got when she had something figured out and a plan drafted in her head for execution.

Then she moved suddenly and unexpectedly, leaning forward onto her hands, which she planted on either side of his hips. Her head went down,

and there were nanoseconds of furtive, torturous hope that her mouth would close around his cock, enveloping him in the hot, wet insides of her mouth, her tongue always busy on the underside of his shaft.

But she bounced up almost immediately: that was just a push to gather momentum. Nikki hopped rabbit-like, her legs flung out athletically to land on the floor after she pushed off the bed. She winked at him, pushing her hair from her face, her tits still bouncing as she gave a quarter-turn and strolled toward the bathroom. "But first we have to get ready," she laughed. "And go shopping." The door closed after her, and Jack heard the water running shortly thereafter.

*

Tony evidently had to return to the city and do police stuff until late in the evening, which was the ostensible reason for assigning the task of shopping to Nikki and Jack. Nikki had taken it upon herself to pare the list down to lube and "sexier lingerie," and had blushed a little when Jack had asked what else was originally on the list.

"Too crazy for me for now," she had said, and while the demons in Jack's head desperately wanted to just *know* what list was "too crazy" for a woman who had just done all the things Nikki had done, and pick a little at the qualifier "for now," he didn't pry any further. Jack was not a guy to rock the boat, especially when it was this particular kind of boat.

"Sexier lingerie" was a tough call in that part of town, where retail was confined to a vast outlet mall. They considered driving into the city or a more gentrified suburb, but without knowing when Tony would beckon them, it seemed stressful. The outlet mall had an underwear and lingerie store, but Nikki became overwhelmed as soon as they entered and the clerk

asked them if they were shopping for a special occasion, her face screwed up in bemused snarkery, her eyes lingering on their of-the-people apparel.

"It's just a special night," Nikki shot at her, flustered, and when the clerk opened her mouth to barrage Nikki with questions, she only got about two words in before Nikki smiled forcefully and deployed her no-nonsense paramedic voice.

"I sure do appreciate your help so far but we have it from here. Where will you be? Over there? I'll wave you over if I need you. Thank-you-so-much."

Nikki had been a big fan of the TV show *The Closer* and for a while had sworn by the lead character's folksy Southern sweet-acidity as the holy grail of shutting busybodies down on calls. She delivered this slapdown with a hint of muddled Southern accents in her most pixie tone, and effectively sent the clerk away with an equally acidic smile plastered on her own face.

"It works," Nikki marveled, "literally every time."

"I have not seen you at work," Jack said, nuzzling her ear, "for a long time. It's very sexy."

Nikki grinned and turned around to face him while her cheeks heated up.

"Honestly, this place is crazy and I don't know where to start," she whispered. "And I'm starving. They only had, like, ham and hard-boiled eggs for lunch." She shrugged at Jack's expression. "Cops," she explained. She leaned in closer to him. "Let's just get some sexy pajamas or something and get out of here."

Nikki's combination of girlish modesty and pragmatism in the face of such a sordid, taboo sexual encounter filled Jack with pride and slavish

adoration. "I want to rip your clothes off right now," he confessed earnestly, in a whisper.

"Well," Nikki said, almost ham-handedly, sneaking a look over her shoulder at the now-frowning clerk, who was eyeing them like she suspected them of being thieves. "Don't. *She's* a real dialer."

A "Dialer" was what they called a Karen before the internet existed.

Jack snorted appropriately and Nikki walked to a stand of robe and lingerie sets, and began leafing through them with an efficiency she usually only inflicted on her medical bag.

Jack strolled over and rested an arm on one of the branches of the clothing tree. "Why is it you don't want to just pick out, say, one of these...?" he held up a set of red lingerie, which looked good to him, as all lingerie tended to.

Nikki's arm shot out well before her eyes darted toward him, and she had snatched the lingerie out of his hands before she even turned to face him.

"Do you have any idea how many sets of this I'd have to try on?"

"I thought they had sizes..." Jack began.

It was Nikki's turn to snort. "Yeah, no. It doesn't work like that."

Jack reached for the lingerie and held it up. "How does it work? I am very interested in how it works. I would love to hear lots of details about how this -"

"I'm *hungry*," Nikki growled, in a playful but very real warning. She held up a robe - a very silky, white number, embroidered with red flowers.

"This?"

Jack sighed and set the sexy red lingerie back on the rack. *Lingerie* had never been Nikki's thing; she had been in a possession of a few choice bras and lacy underwear when they started dating, but Nikki was a practical girl who did practical things that were best done in sports bras and boy-short underwear, which had enough sex appeal for Jack by virtue of being on her body and about to come off. Occasionally, a lacy bra with no underwire made an appearance, but that was it.

He supposed he should be pleased that Nikki's entire personality had not disappeared in puff of sexy smoke in a single night.

It was also a very sexy robe, and his helpful imagination was already putting it on her and taking it off with Tony's huge black hands. "That's hot," he said, with conviction.

Nikki giggled and hopped away to the cashier, saying something about not having to try it on.

Their next stop was the pharmacy, and Nikki said she'd just pop in and get the lube. Again, her paramedic pragmatism was an asset: Nikki would buy *anything* in a pharmacy without giving a shit about it, probably because at one point or another, she had.

She pulled on the door handle and popped the door open, but paused. "So look," she said, almost uncertainly. "Tony said to get some condoms. Which seemed... hilarious, you know, given what we did last night. And so..." Nikki laughed and looked a little bashful. "I *said* so... and he was like..." Nikki looked over at Jack, a cacophony of expressions on her face. She shook her head and started to push on the door.

"Wait, wait," Jack said, reaching for her. "He was like, what?"

Nikki blushed a little. "He was like... 'nah, that ain't what them condoms for exactly,'" Nikki said, doing a great imitation of the black vernacular that Tony floated in and out of in accordance with his communicative needs: black when he was playing one hand, and standard when he was playing another.

Nikki swept a loose strand of hair away from her face and tucked it behind her ear. "I don't know what that means, but... I guess this is kind of up to you, too. I just didn't see any point if.. you know. After last night."

"So irresponsible," Jack marveled, mostly amazed that neither one of them seemed to have given it much thought, especially given their line of work.

"Totally," Nikki said, biting her lip very sexily. She stared out the windshield. "I kind of like it, though."

I kind of like it, though. Her words turned into the pulsing veins on Tony's black, unsheathed cock, and fell with the patter of dripping cum against his eardrum. He was momentarily stupefied.

Nikki looked alarmed. "Oh, no," she said. "If that's not okay -"

"No, no. No," Jack huffed, his chest tight. "No, I like it, too. It's just..."

He settled for expelling air through his teeth and shaking his head rapidly, hoping that Nikki would accept this display of how hot it was instead of words, which he didn't seem to remember any of, other than *I kind of like it, though*.

It wasn't a mind-blown emoticon, but Nikki's smile before she pushed the door open and hopped into the pharmacy was enthusiasm enough.

For now.

*

While Nikki was in the pharmacy, brazenly purchasing an enormous tube of lube (Nikki rarely did anything halfway), Jack noticed a hole-in-the-wall Thai food place at the end of the strip mall, which amazingly had a neon sign lit up declaring it open.

It was hard to trust this kind of restaurant, which typically only served lunch to the warehouse and industry crowds that flocked here during the day and abandoned the place at night, so he advised Nikki against getting overly excited about it until they confirmed that the sign was not a fib someone had forgotten to unplug.

The workers on the restaurant appeared to be authentically Thai, so while thoroughly confused about why they were there at night on what looked like a date, they halted everything they were doing to serve them a very charming dinner - once Nikki and Jack hit upon the items that they still had available. They were playing pop music in the kitchen and turned it off, replacing it with dreary Asian-sounding music, but Nikki told them to turn the pop back on, so they did. The dining lights were off and an orange lamp that was probably illegal for some bureaucratic reason shed a warm, sexy glow on the charmingly dingy interior.

A girl who claimed to be "Mint" and a jolly man who called himself "Beer" spoke the best English and calmly apologized for not having their first six choices, before proclaiming that their seventh options were indeed the very best items on the menu anyway.

Jack was prepared for them to be more like the very worst items, hence the fact that they remained in stock, but they turned out to be great. And Nikki was teetering on *hangry*, which must also have been a universal problem,

because Mint had discretely walked away and returned with a plate of spring rolls, as Beer was shooting their choices down one by one. She set it on the table at Nikki's elbow and backed away smiling, like she was leaving the cage of a lioness. "On house," she explained, grinning sweetly enough that even hangry Nikki had to smile back.

Halfway through the meal, which Jack was enjoying for its kooky qualities and the fact that they were acting like they were on a date - chatting happily, being as attractive as possible to each other, staying away from everyday topics (gross calls) - Nikki's phone vibrated on the table.

Nikki's eyes opened wide and she sucked up a noodle while looking at Jack. He wondered if her heart had started thumping as immediately, as forcefully, as his did.

She picked it up and read the message. "Tony's heading to the hotel," she said.

And then she smiled.

And re-set her chopsticks, very meticulously, in her hand, and started eating again. Her foot rubbed against his leg, and they exchanged a sweet moment of complicity.

"Better get Beer over here with the bill," Jack said, and Nikki laughed.

CHAPTER 3

Jack experienced the sequence of events leading them back to the hotel as a wild montage of images and feelings, as if an artsy director had gotten a hold of the movie of his life. Even as he lived it, the experience was disjointed, almost anachronistic: Nikki in the passenger's seat, her hair caught in the breeze of her open window, smiling at him. Nikki's eyes lighting up at a knock on the door, Nikki emerging from the bathroom, pulling the robe over one shoulder, Nikki's mouth warm and eager when she leaned in unexpectedly to kiss him as he unlocked the door. And then he found himself sitting in the chair again, Nikki's head turned slightly toward him as she walked toward the door, robe billowing a little with her fast stride, a damp and dangerous excitement in the air.

And then Jack was momentarily zoomed out of his life, an observer and not a participant: the door unlatched with a click, Nikki purred and Tony growled, maybe they said words or touched each other, Jack didn't see. Then Nikki was striding back into the room, delivering a smile to Jack – but one that already felt distant, somehow. Like she was looking through him. She stopped at the foot of the bed and turned toward Tony, her shoulder rolling sexily with her pirouette, her hands playing with the silky belt that loosely held her robe together.

And then Tony: strolling casually, his enormous bulk making an observer think briefly of the word “lumbering,” but Tony was no lumberer. Tony moved with the calculated slowness that all large men – and apex predators – employed for any activity that wasn't killing or mating. But like an apex predator, the taut firmness of muscle that rolled beneath Tony's skin left no doubt that Tony, if provoked to do so, would move very, very quickly.

“I don’t ordinarily do this kinda thing,” Tony said calmly, walking toward Nikki without giving Jack so much as a glance in his direction. Still, the words seemed directed at Jack more than they were at Nikki. But it was hard to know what "thing" Tony was referring to: fucking? Dominating other men's wives? Being a bull? He seemed to do plenty of all those things on a regular basis.

Jack inferred that Tony meant: come back for seconds (or fifths, or a twentieth helping). But whatever Tony meant, it wasn't deterring him. And he was getting straight to business.

He put his big hand to Nikki’s chest and drew a slow circle on her sternum, edging the fabric of the robe slightly each time his fingers passed by the hem. He did this a few times, until the robe parted, slipped, and the tiniest patch of pink, a sliver of her aureole, appeared from beneath it.

Tony kept talking, or maybe narrating was a more appropriate word for it. He was speaking to everyone and no-one in particular.

“I usually don’t dive in this deep right away. But I been thinking about this a long time now...” He stepped closer to Nikki, dropping his hand to the tasseled belt that held the robe together and giving it a tug along the smooth slope of her mound, so that his knuckles stroked her pussy through the fabric. The loose tie slipped apart, the fabric slipped open, and Nikki helped it fall away by shrugging her shoulders, all while Tony watched her, assessing, grinning, a wolfish glint flickering more steadily in his eyes with each passing second. “I been thinking about this *all* day.” He drew his finger down the center of Nikki’s body, which was now bared and visible to him through the parting in the ever-slipping robe. He stepped forward again, sliding his hand down, between her legs, and into her pussy, as he pulled her close to him with his free hand.

“Mmm,” Tony commented, feeling inside her. He directed his gaze to Nikki’s face, watching her expression change as he fingered her, probing the inside of her pussy almost like he had a medical concern.

He grinned and looked over Nikki’s shoulder at Jack when she gasped lightly. “You fucked her again today.” Tony grinned and looked at Nikki, then kissed her mouth wetly before studying her face again as his forearm flexed, indicating that his fingers were moving inside her in large, forceful movements. He seemed pleased with what he saw, and if Jack having fucked Nikki was a real transgression in his books, he didn’t show it.

“She’s real sore, then. Yeah, you are, aren’t you?” Tony grinned again and pushed Nikki’s hair back from her face, leaning in to kiss her earlobe while he spoke to her. Nikki reacted with a pleasing flush of her face, turning her head in such a way that it was possible to see hesitancy and enthusiasm in it all at once. A very pleasing, hot combination of emotions for Jack.

But Tony’s eyes were on Jack. His glee was evident, his enjoyment obvious – but Jack couldn’t read the other emotions that lurked there. He didn’t know if malice lurked in Tony’s eyes – or if it was real malice, the kind that was focused on *really* stealing Nikki, or the kind of malice that was confined by sex, a hot cousin to *real* malice. Jack brushed up, yet again, against the delicious sensation of real risk, and it made him shudder.

But the pleasure it promised him was more convincing, in the end, than the fear. He remained seated, watching, wondering what Tony had in store for Nikki tonight.

“I’m gonna fuck this pussy *all* night,” he said, into Nikki’s ear, and whatever Nikki did, it made him smile. “I’m gonna use you up, little girl,

just like I promised. Because I...” Tony smiled, licking Nikki’s ear along the hard ridge, “Always come through on my promises.”

Jack wasn’t sure of there was some wider implication in this statement – it seemed like there might be. Some promise that he had wrung out of Nikki, something she had promised to do for him?

It could be nothing, he thought, wiping the sweat of his palms on the arm rests. He was breathing in shallow, rapid breaths, which he tried to slow whenever her noticed them.

Tony pushed the robe off Nikki’s body – definitively, this time - and his dark hands headed right down her back to cup her buttocks. He kneaded them and kissed Nikki, sliding his finger into her crack and caressing her anus, her taint, reaching deep for her pussy. Glistening juices trailed along her skin as he drew his finger back along the sweet trough between her ass-cheeks.

“You tell me what you wanna do first, sugar,” Tony said, touching her cheek and pushing her face away from him to look at her. “Hmm? You wanna hop on and ride me? Or maybe you wanna take it slow and play with it for a while?” Tony grinned and shifted his eyes in Jack’s direction - briefly, just long enough to let Jack know he was talking to him.

His eyes were back on Nikki when he spoke.

“She a wet, sloppy, girl when she sucks my cock. She like that for you?” Tony didn’t look over, and Jack was grateful for that.

Nikki was *not*, since Tony was asking, a “wet, sloppy girl” when she, on the very rare occasions that she did anymore, sucked his cock.

Tony put his hand on Nikki's head, pushing her slowly down to her knees. Nikki reached immediately for his belt and started to free him from his pants while Tony chuckled silently and watched her, taking his shirt off at the same time. "You miss it, don't you, baby?" Tony chuckled.

Nikki started to suck Tony's cock as soon as it sprung loose. She grabbed the thick mass and pointed it toward her mouth, which Jack had only a glancing view of. He had to imagine the details by listening to the slurping, sloppy sounds that came from the other side of Nikki's head. The occasional flash of her mouth, of Tony's black skin, of the slimy, veined shape of his dick, peeked through Nikki's bobbing hair and Tony's shifting forearm. Tony moved his hand to different positions on Nikki's head as she sucked on him, tipping his own head to get views from a different angle. He had one hand on her head and the other holding his cock, guiding his dick over Nikki's lips or slapping her cheek lightly with it, all while Nikki moved her head to try and get him into her open mouth.

Tony at last looked up at Jack, and grinned. He shifted his weight to nudge Nikki a little as he turned himself, giving Jack a better view of her sucking on his dick. He held her hair above her head in a ponytail secured by his fingers, and watched, his own hips thrust forward, as he jerked her face up and down the length of his shaft. Nikki had her hands on his thighs and her fingers dug into his flesh, gripping him fiercely.

As the minutes ticked by, Nikki's enthusiasm only grew – she started to moan and suck harder and faster, and she let Tony go deeper, making her gag. Pretty soon Tony let his hand slip to the side of her face – a nominal hold of her hair, no longer needed to encourage her. Nikki was sucking furiously and enthusiastically now, completely of her own accord.

Jack was willing her to look over at him, the way she had the first time with Tony. But Nikki seemed so completely caught up in the moment that she might have forgotten about Jack entirely.

“They get like this with a big fat cock, you know that?” Tony asked, almost immediately after the preceding thought formed in Jack’s head. The timing gave off the eerie effect of making Jack feel like Tony was somewhat inside his head.

“Every time,” Tony continued. “See, she wasn’t all that into sucking it, I could tell that last night. Hesitant. But now she’s got the hang of it, now she can’t stop herself -” Tony broke his own story off to chuckle as Nikki really started to suck fast and noisily on his cock. “I did *not* expect that,” Tony said. “Not so soon, anyway.” He looked over at Jack. “I don’t usually get them sucking it like this until I’ve given more than a *few* lessons, but she a quick learner... uhn, yeah baby, slow that down a little, let me feel it way at the back there, hold it back there for a little bit.”

Absorbed by his “mentoring” of Nikki, Tony’s attention drifted from the monologue he was delivering. He pushed Nikki by the back of the head, cradling her skull in his hand and watching her face. He held her in place, his cock shoved down her throat nearly to the base. Nikki’s nostrils flared while he slid in, as she struggled to breath, but this ceased once Tony was deep in her throat. “Damn,” Tony commented, moving his fingers over Nikki’s face while she held his cock in her mouth and looked up at him, following his lead, starved for oxygen and utterly at his mercy. “She gonna learn to do all *kinds* of nasty shit, she a natural like this. Mmm.”

Jack was getting nervous about Nikki, whose eyes were watering a little at the corners. “Hey man,” he said. “You better...” he moved a shoulder in Nikki’s direction, indicating – he hoped it was obvious – that Tony should

let her breathe. Tony smiled, looking down at Nikki. "Man, she fine," he chuckled, waiting one more moment while Nikki – as submissive as Jack had ever seen or imagined her – stretched her arms up along his chest and looked at him imploringly, her mouth completely full of cock.

Tony looked up at Jack, his fingers playing in Nikki's hair, Nikki sucking noisily away. "You gotta have a system, is all. Right, baby?" His eyes shifted to Nikki, and he smiled. "She knows she just gotta tap three times and I'll stop gaggin' her. But she ain't done that yet."

Tony grinned down at her while she continued sucking, but after a few moments, Jack saw Nikki's right pointer finger tap rapidly against Tony's torso, and he slowly slid his cock from her mouth. She gasped for air as he backed himself toward the bed and sat down. Nikki followed on her knees, her mouth lunging for Tony's cock as he moved away from her. After he sat down, Nikki started bobbing in his lap, sucking him just as sloppily and wetly as Tony had promised.

Tony leaned back on his elbows and let Nikki keep sucking him, but reached for her head abruptly, before he came, lifted her by the hair until his cock was just out of reach of her tongue. Nikki strained against his grip, her hair pulling tightly at the roots, turning her scalp white, in order to try and lick him.

Tony was watching this with a cool and pleased expression, letting Nikki's head dangle from his grip by the rope of her hair. He looked up at Jack at one point and smiled. "Don't worry. I took something to keep the party going all night."

Jack just stared at his wife as she leaned toward Tony's cock, her tongue lapping desperately at the air, trying to gobble him up again. Under any

other circumstances, Jack would have been alarmed by recreational drug use – especially the cardiac implications of something that would “keep the party going all night,” but Tony’s comment barely registered in his mind, except as a light puff of relief: the way Nikki was acting, both Jack and Tony were going to have a lot on their hands this evening.

Tony allowed Nikki to get his cock back in her mouth again, and Nikki started slurping away on it while Tony’s eyes drifted down to watch her. When his jaw slacked a little and his eyes turned hard, Jack knew he was about to come. Tony wasn’t the kind of guy to give any warning to his partner, though, and so Nikki kept sucking furiously as Tony’s eyes narrowed and his muscles flexed.

Just before he came, though, he seized Nikki’s hair more tightly and wrapped one fist around the base of his cock.

Nikki's words rose to the forefront of his mind, as real as if she had said them in his ear: *if that's the case, he'll just get my mouth all dirty right from the start.*

“You want her to save it in her mouth and show it to you?” Tony asked, his face screwing up in concentration. “Ah, fuck, baby, keep doin’ it just like that.” he said to Nikki. He seemed to forget about his question for Jack and give in to the sensation of his orgasm, which was about to burst.

He groaned and his fingers gripped Nikki’s hair hard enough to make her mewl. Tony let out three yells, each one lighter than the one before, timed with the spewing of his seed, in spurts that filled Nikki’s throat.

“Save that up in the back of your throat, baby,” Tony said, his face screwed up as he spewed a fourth ejaculatory spurt into her mouth. “And then you’re

gonna go show it to him.” Tony glanced at Jack, grinning again, moving one hand around in Nikki’s hair, petting her and messing it all up.

There was a sticky flop as Nikki released Tony and his cock, still mostly rigid, fell against his thigh. “Show me how you’re gonna do it, baby... you still got it, right? Sit down on your heels, there you go. And then look up at me, that’s nice – yeah, there you go, open up your mouth and show me what a dirty mouth you got. You gonna keep that in there now, huh baby? And go show Jack, just like that.”

Tony looked up from Nikki and chuckled in Jack’s general direction. Nikki turned around and crawled over to Jack, her lips closed and her eyes in concentration mode as she kept the bitter cum in her mouth.

The Nikki who curled at his feet and looked up at him was not his wife at all. She looked like Nikki: the golden-red hair, the pretty mouth in a Cupid's bow, the sea-green eyes. But behind all of these features there was something else – mischief in her eyes, that flicker of a sentiment that Jack had never seen before in her, and so couldn’t name.

She tilted her head back, placing her hands on his knees and stroking them, a wry smile turning up the corners of her closed mouth, and then, as the mischief glimmered, she opened her mouth wide so that he could look down into it.

Past her straight, shiny white teeth, into the pink and shiny skin, past her tongue. And there it was, a pool at the back of her throat, creamy white. Tony’s second load of cum for the day.

Nikki’s eyes met Jack’s, and she smiled as she closed her mouth, and swallowed.

Jack reached for her face without thinking, and stroked her mouth with his thumb. He knew that his expression was aghast, a mixture of horror and hunger, as he did this. But Nikki either didn't register it that way, or didn't care. Or wasn't Nikki.

Something had shifted, because she just smiled and sat up on her heels, placing her hands prettily in her lap. She turned and looked over her shoulder at Tony, expectantly.

"Yeah, get on back here," Tony told her. Nikki turned and crawled toward him on her hands and knees until she was at *his* feet. Tony patted his thigh, and Nikki rose to standing before climbing onto his lap.

This was done so casually, and with such little communication between them, that – somehow even more than the puddle of cum in the back of Nikki's throat – the scene burned violently in Jack's chest. It was coordinated enough, coming easily enough to Nikki, that it made Jack question how it could be the first time that Tony ordered Nikki around like *this*.

Nikki straddled him and rolled against his body, pressing her tits forward into his chest and arching her back. Her legs were spread wide to accommodate the girth of Tony's hips, and her pussy dragged over Tony's cock, which was hard enough, again, to point at a 45-degree angle from between his legs. Nikki's pussy lips dripped along the length of his shaft as she rolled her hips forward and smuttily rocked on his lap.

Tony evidently enjoyed this, because he growled and put his hands loosely on Nikki's hips, saying, "Mmm, I *like* that."

Nikki put one hand on Tony's shoulder and reached back with the other, dropping it around her ass and through her own legs, fingers closing and

opening as she searched for Tony's cock.

There was a change in the ambiance in that moment, as Nikki rutted against Tony and swept behind her and between her legs for his dick. Tony felt it; his eyes went to Nikki's face, and for the briefest moment registered surprise.

Nikki found his dick and grasped it firmly, pulling on it like a hand brake to raise it up, pointed straight for her slick pussy. At the same time, she rolled her body up, rising from Tony's lap as high as she could, with her legs spread in an undulation that reminded Jack of a stripper.

It was momentarily so disconcerting that he felt a wave of nausea and had the idea that he was dreaming.

When Nikki lowered her body down, she held Tony's cock in her right hand and lined him up with her slit. Tony had his hands on her hips and was watching her with a new interest, one that prompted him to smile and go, "Hmm," when Nikki rocked her hips forward and back in order to drag the tip of Tony's dick through her wet pussy flesh.

Tony watched Nikki's face, and for a few moments, he did so with a bemused grin. It appeared that even Tony hadn't expected Nikki to take the reins, or if he did, he hadn't expected it quite yet. His eyebrows went skyward when Nikki sank abruptly onto his cock, and the whole big muscle rammed in to the hilt with nothing more than a wet spurt.

As Nikki began to ride him, Tony's hands recovered from his momentary confusion, and slipped into the crack of Nikki's ass and over her hips and buttocks. Nikki bounced, gaining momentum, and pretty soon she was slapping against Tony's lap, the column of black between her legs, sliding in and out with the movement of her body.

Jack didn't know where to focus his attention: the way Nikki bounced, tipping her head back, her tresses swinging horizontally across her back? The speed she was bouncing at, a shrill warble building up in her chest? The cream-streaked black between her legs, disappearing behind her pale, upside-down heart of an ass on the down stroke, to reappear - menacing and shiny with her juices - as she rose up?

Tony leaned back on one elbow, leaving one wandering hand on Nikki's body, and watched Nikki with disbelief as she rode him until she lifted her arms up and put her fingers in her own hair and started to mewl, then moan, then scream. As she came, Nikki slapped her ass hard onto Tony's lap, punctuating her own shrieks with the wet splatter of her ass on the sweat and cum that oiled Tony's thighs.

Then her body crumpled a little, as it often did when she came, and the waves of her hips grew smaller and smaller, until she was wriggling side to side, keeping Tony deep inside her as she settled on his lap.

Tony watched all of this with interest, and once Nikki was quiet, he sat back up again, grasping her hips and thighs, rearranging her on his cock and lap.

Nikki let him move her around like a limp doll, mewling softly whenever he touched a sensitive nerve.

"Damn, girl," he said to Nikki, putting a hand up to her face to hold her jaw and play with her lips with his fingers. Tony's eyes were looking over her face now, in an inspection mode, as if Tony himself couldn't understand what had gotten into her.

"I knew she'd be a wildcat," Tony said, his eyes following only after the words had time to reach Jack's ears and confuse him, again, about who

Tony was talking to. “I didn’t expect her to get on it so fast, though, gotta tell you.”

Yet again it took a beat for Jack to realize that Tony was talking to him. He was watching his wife as she wriggled sexily on Tony’s lap, purring like a cat, mewling when Tony drove his cock to some sensitive place inside her.

“You ready to go again?” Tony asked her, pushing her hair back and making her lean back a little so he could look at her face. “Hmm?”

Nikki made a series of sounds that meant almost nothing: Jack had no idea if she was answering in the affirmative or negative. Which probably didn’t matter, because Jack didn’t envision Tony giving her much of a break if she said “no.”

Instead, she mewled sexily and rolled her torso and hips against Tony, demurring.

Tony put his left hand against Nikki’s back, his forearm along her spine, and used his right hand to push her backward, until she was reclining, held up by Tony’s sheer strength. Nikki’s tits were visible to Jack then, bouncing a little as she wriggled. Tony spread his fingers wide and moved his palm possessively over Nikki’s chest, pausing to tweak a nipple or knead a breast as his fingers slid easily over her sweat.

Nikki, for her part, just moaned and let herself be played with like a doll. Her mouth was slack and her eyes either closed or focused on Tony’s abdomen. Her hands were on his biceps, squeezing.

“I gotta tell you, man,” Tony said, watching his hand moving over Nikki’s torso. “I sure as hell didn’t expect this girl to be such a dirty whore. I thought I’d have to work a long time on it. Y’all ain’t for real, that this her

first time?" Tony trailed his finger from Nikki's mouth, down to her sternum, and further, twisting his elbow to bend his arm at an angle and dip his fingers into the folds of her pussy. This made Nikki's eyes fly open and her legs twitch.

Jack's attention was hopelessly divided. When his darting eyes took in the tense, casual strength rolling beneath the dark skin of Tony's massive forearm and his flexed bicep - all that suspended the upper half of Nikki's body - he felt pangs of competitive jealousy, mild admiration, disbelief, fear. These ripples like small current beneath a monstrous ocean of feral arousal. Frighteningly graphic, taboo thoughts rose like bubbles from the bottom of a boiling pot, each one filthier than the last.

And Nikki writhed in Tony's hands, making sounds like an animal, pleading in gaspy, high-pitched mewls for more from Tony. Almost as if she could read Jack's thoughts from afar; for a dizzying moment Nikki writhed exactly as he desired, and he had the false and disorienting sense that he was controlling her with his mind. The feeling plunged him into an ice bath of terror: he couldn't stop his thoughts from becoming more depraved than he really wanted Nikki to be.

The feeling passed, though, and Tony kept stroking Nikki's clit and making her howl and squirm until the pitch of her squeals became higher and she seemed close to coming again. The man was not strained at all by supporting her dynamic weight with his one giant arm, but he shifted a little to rest his elbow on his thigh. Nikki's head tipped back until it was hanging upside-down. Her features were screwed up into the face she made when intense pleasure gripped her. When she came, her eyelids fell open and she looked right at Jack, her mouth open in a crude "o," but making no sound.

Her arms - one hand gripping Tony's thigh now, the other on his free forearm - went limp, her fingers uncurling from his flesh. The bright, intense quality in her eyes faded away, as a post-orgasmic stupor overtook her.

Tony chuckled as he wriggled the fingers embedded in her pussy flesh, making Nikki's limbs jolt, but she was too listless to do anything more than that. Her eyes were open and directed at Jack, but seemed to see nothing. He played with her for a while like this, enjoying - Jack could tell, even though he didn't narrate it - the quivering aftershocks of Nikki's orgasm as they squeezed his dick.

Tony lifted her back up to sitting again and let her resettle on his cock. He pushed her hair from her face tenderly, his personality taking another sharp lurch. He seemed to be studying Nikki's face the way a lovesick romantic partner might, which made Jack feel like someone had literally opened a can of worms in his chest: it was far too intimate in a way he didn't like. But there was not much way to do anything about it, not now.

This didn't last long, though. A sinister grin reappeared on Tony's mouth, as he touched Nikki's lips with the fingers he had dipped into her pussy.

"That's it, lick it off. That's sexy, little girl. I like a girl like Nikki," he continued, changing his audience, as he was wont to do, to Jack, without warning. "She all business, all tightly wrapped, likes to get 100% on every test. Sweet, looks like she go to church or somethin' every Sunday. And then you get her in the bedroom and she a real freak." He smiled again, his attention retreating to Nikki and what he was doing with her mouth.

"You ready for two dicks at the same time, baby? Hmm?" He was looking at Nikki now, watching her eyes. Jack could no longer see her face, only the sordid tableau of his wife's elegant back and bare ass seated on Tony's legs,

his cock still hard and curved slightly to fit between Nikki's thighs. Tony rested his hands on her hips, and then moved inward and grasped her buttocks, pulling them apart until Jack had a view of her the puckered rosette just above Tony's dick, as he stretched a pointer finger toward it and caressed the circumference.

Nikki made a noise, complaining slightly. Tony's smile and agreeable gleam dissipated in jagged stages, leaving his face stern. From tender and loving sweetheart-type, he transformed into the man Jack suspected took command of incidents and ran training exercises, a no-bullshit force field beaming from his eyes.

It was the kind of look that everybody in the world knew meant you were going to do whatever he told you to. Nikki was going to do whatever he told her to, no matter how depraved. They were all at the mercy of Tony's sexual whims, and just the thought of it infused Jack, and seemingly Nikki as well, with intense arousal.

Tony seemed to sense this, and also that letting the anticipation linger in the room for a bit would enhance everyone's high. Nikki squirmed on his lap, her complaints dribbling away, awaiting Tony's command.

"You-all get that lube I asked for?" Tony asked Nikki, looking intensely at her face again. Nikki nodded, and Jack moved his hand to the plastic bag where it was, without taking his eyes off his wife and Tony. He used one hand to open the box and shake the tube out, an occupational skill that was finally coming in handy.

Tony was touching Nikki's mouth again, smiling. "She a little afraid," he said, and his smile, in a sinister way, widened. "That's good, that's all right." His hand went to Nikki's throat, not so much closing around it as wrapping

and slithering there, massaging and threatening all at the same time.

"Scared women make my dick hard. How 'bout you, Jack?"

Tony's eyes flicked to Jack, which made Jack stir uncomfortably for a moment, trying to get a read on how much of Nikki's "fear" was actual fear, and how much of it was acceptable to her. He was lost in the wilderness, though, because *this* Nikki was not *his* Nikki at all.

"Don't do anything... don't -"

"I ain't gonna fuckin' hurt her," Tony growled, annoyed. His eyes went back to Nikki's face. "Not in no bad way," he added, with another sinister grin.

"But Nikki here obviously ain't *too* scared, are you, baby? No. Nah, because you did what I told you to, didn't you?"

The hand on her ass slipped into her crack and plunged down between her legs, swabbing some of the pussy juice dripping down his balls upward, toward Nikki's eyelet. "We gonna work up to that, anyway," Tony said, as he worked his pointer finger into Nikki's ass. She gasped, and squirmed, but ultimately resettled on his lap, as his finger disappeared to the second knuckle.

For the next few minutes, Tony played around in Nikki's ass - or at least that's what Jack assumed was happening. Not much changed, visually; they seemed to be two people, canoodling post-coitus, except that the muscles in Tony's hand moved as he pressed his finger in different directions, eliciting mewls of different kinds from Nikki when he changed position in her ass.

"You gonna like it, baby," Tony told her, smiling. "Yeah. I know girls like you. But first, you wanna go over there and give your hubby a break, huh? Suck his dick for him, baby, show 'im some love. He lettin' you get some black cock, get your brains fucked out, so make it good."

Nikki turned her head toward her left shoulder and looked behind her, meeting Jack's eyes after a flutter of her eyelashes. Tiny specks of black ran beneath her left eye, where the slutty mascara she had applied, dampened by the tears squeezed from her eye as she choked on Tony's cock, had streaked. Her lips seemed almost rubbery, the raw, used pink tinged by a faint red inflammation spreading above the long sweep of her Cupid's bow.

She poured out of Tony's lap, all liquid and soft angles, onto the floor and onto her hands and knees. The whole time, her eyes were on Jack, no particular expression behind them but the servile hunger Tony had ordered to be there. Her hair was already messy, a bent lump sticking up on one side.

Jack had already, without even realizing it, begun freeing his cock from his boxers. His shaft was thick with desire, erect with no support, shiny with the precum that had been oozing from its distended tip for nearly half an hour now.

Nikki rose onto her knees and seized him in her right hand. She opened her mouth and let her tongue protrude grotesquely, like a twerk, before her eyes shifted down to guide her to his dick. Jack followed her mouth, watching it widen, looking at her protruding tongue as she plastered it to the underside of his cock at the base and then dragged it filthily along his shaft to the top, a long, dirty lick that she finished off with a curl, as if she had just eaten ice cream.

And then she opened wide and took him between her yawning lips. Her teeth grazed the top of him briefly, and Nikki bared her teeth and retreated slightly, so that they caught on the raised outer lip of his crown while her tongue swirled around the face of his cock, darting into the eye, playful and wet.

Jack stared at her, scooting backward into the back of the chair as much out of surprise and fear as because the pleasure was almost intolerable.

Nikki never, ever sucked his cock like this.

She enveloped him next, plunging headfirst with enthusiasm, his cock disappearing into the heat of her mouth, hard palate giving way to soft, tongue busy underneath. He inhaled sharply when she kept going, her lips at the very base of his dick. He felt a spasm against his crown as she gagged slightly, but then she started sucking on him, undeterred.

He temporarily blanked the context of this blow-job - it was mind-blowing enough all by itself - but remembered that Tony was in the room with them. His eyes lifted to see what he was doing: Tony was reclined on one elbow, his legs spread, one hand on his dick, stroking it lazily. Tony's eyes were on Nikki's ass, a vague smile on his lips. Jack shifted back to Nikki in disbelief, the situation momentarily surreal again.

Tony was in motion. He sat up, looked down at his cock as he stroked it, and then moved in a quick motion that somehow seemed languid at the same time, moving in behind Nikki on his knees. "Hey man, pull that apart for me and hold it open."

Jack found himself doing just that - having to shift his weight a little to lean over Nikki's head and reach for her ass-cheeks. He didn't need any further explanation of what Tony wanted, or the why of it: the momentum of the dirtiness was carrying him along as much as it was Nikki. His cock flexed in her mouth and she made a noise, lifting her head and gasping for breath, straining to look behind her, over Jack's forearm. A pang of erotic pain pulsed in Jack's chest as his wife abandoned sucking his cock to look back at another man, coming for her ass, while Jack held her open for him.

Tony's face indicated that he was enjoying the view. He had his cock in his hand and seemed ready to jump right in, but paused instead, admiring Nikki's eyelet and her dripping pussy, ripened and burst open, below it.

Tony loomed over her, his hips close enough for him to slide inside her, but he didn't: instead, he pursed his lips and let a huge glob of spit fall slowly from his mouth. It dropped right on the center of Nikki's asshole, and Jack pulled her buttocks further apart just as Nikki herself tilted her ass up. Whatever Tony saw made him smile. He spit into her ass again, and Nikki mewled softly, the sound vibrating dangerously on Jack's cock.

Tony's started to play on her ass with his thumb. "You ain't ever had your cock in her mouth when somebody fuck her in the ass?" he asked, so casually that Jack didn't even register the filthiness of the question, and the idea didn't send so much as a frisson of fear through him. He just shook his head slowly, his eyes on Tony's fat thumb as it worked its way into her ass. Nikki was slow-sucking him now, her thoughts obviously distracted by what Tony was doing, but he was pleased, because he didn't want to come just yet. Not with that wild promise on the table.

He dropped his hand to the side of the chair and felt for the lube. Nikki was still sucking away on his cock, looking behind her at Tony when she gasped for air between long attacks, and surely had heard this conversation. She didn't seem interested in putting it to a stop.

Jack unscrewed the lube with one hand - another occupational talent - and held it toward Tony. He took it, grinning. "She a little sore," he commented, and squeezed some messily from several feet above her. It fell with a plop into the wide valley at the top of her ass-crack, and Nikki, who was taking a breath, squealed and shook her ass a little. "That's cold," she complained, but playfully.

Tony was concentrating and his movements were careful, almost like he was doing a very delicate craft, as he used a finger to drag a little bit of the lube down to her rim. He swept it around the wrinkled circle and went back for more, never answering or even seeming to have heard Nikki's complaint.

On the third time, he dipped his finger in, and it slipped in easily. He started to fuck her quickly with his single finger, and Nikki went back to sucking on Jack's cock - only after looking back up at him and making him shudder with a smile she delivered before taking him into her mouth again. The sticky sound of Tony's finger fucking her ass was the only sound in the room.

Nikki's throat vibrated with a low warble when Tony inserted another finger, barely slowing to admit it. "Baby, just push out, don't fight it or you gonna feel it," Tony said, and Nikki must have done that very thing because that was all he said.

Tony used his other hand to squirt more lube in the same place. Jack had placed his hand back on her ass cheek and was pulling them apart for Tony, Nikki's head rubbing against his abdomen and her mouth closed around his dick. He was close to coming and had to insert un-sexy thoughts into his mind to stop the reaction from tipping over - he wanted to have Nikki's mouth around his cock when Tony shoved his dick in, wanted to feel her howl with her mouth against his shaft, wanted the danger and the ultimate vulnerability and humiliation of having his cock between Nikki's jaws when a huge dick spread her ass wide.

Tony was spreading lube on his cock, one drop at a time, drawing from the wet pile he had dropped almost on her lower back, watching his fingers in

her ass. When he had coated his cock in lube, he pulled his fingers slowly from her ass, and Jack felt another warbled mewl against his cock.

Nikki stopped sucking and started to turn her head, but Tony wrapped his hand around her jaw, slipping the fingers that had been in her ass into her mouth and prying it open. "Nah, you're ready for it, you gonna wrap your lips around his cock while I slide it in," Tony told her. "Now, you gonna be a good girl and keep that mouth open? Can't have you doin' no biting."

Tony still held Nikki grotesquely, her mouth stretched open by his fingers like he wanted to see how wide he could get it. Nikki cacked an affirmative reply ("uck-uck") and he released her, pushing her roughly at the back of the head as he did. Nikki opened her mouth and took Jack into it, only about halfway, her nostrils flaring as her warm breath panted onto his stomach.

Tony lined his cock up to her eyelet. Nikki whined a little as he pressed forward, and her attention was obviously sucked away from her mouth and Jack's cock, because she surrounded him limply, saliva dribbling from her lips onto his thigh, her eyes open and staring straight ahead, her thoughts clearly on her ass and the sharp stretch she was experiencing as Tony worked his way inside.

"Mmm, ogh," Nikki choked, the vibration of her voice wildly tickling Jack's cock. Tony's shiny shaft was stuck for a moment, bowing slightly as he put pressure on Nikki's ass, but suddenly she gave way and his cock disappeared rapidly inside her with a wet crinkling sound.

Tony was watching himself slide into Nikki's ass, the pleasure he felt showing beneath his stern expression. "Get back to work on that, baby, show us what you can do."

Another moan from Nikki, her mouth open, and then she closed her lips back around Jack's cock, slid down the base, and got to work.

Jack let his hands slip away from Nikki's ass as soon as Tony's hips began to slide forward. He fell back in the chair, arms on the arm rests, which were narrow and made his arms slide off and hang from the sides. He barely noticed, because Nikki's mouth was sucking him hard and Tony was slowly fucking her in the ass.

His cum boiled at the base of his dick, he felt it surging and just stared at the scene in his lap, at Tony fucking his wife, letting it erupt with no warning and no sense of agency. His head fell back and he yelled, open-mouthed, as his cum poured into the wet cavern of Nikki's mouth and Tony began to slap against her ass. The orgasm was dizzying, spreading through his head like vertigo and blocking out the sound momentarily. A fleeting worry that he was about to have a stroke or a heart attack darted through his thoughts as his heart pounded like a fist against a door in his chest. He felt Nikki's teeth against the top of his shaft and the threat of them seasoned the second spurt of cum that he shot into her mouth.

When he tipped his head and looked down, Tony had Nikki's hair in his hands again and was tipping her head back slightly. He was talking to her in a low voice, saying something, but the blood was ringing in Jack's ears so loudly that he didn't know what Tony was saying.

He discovered soon enough as Nikki let her mouth fall open, her eyes straining to look up at Jack. Tony began to fuck her ass hard, her body absorbing the shock but bumping forward a little, Jack's dick rubbing at the roof of her mouth. With each thrust, a white gush of cum rolled out from between the loose, partial seal of Nikki's lips on Jack's dick. It rolled down to his balls, and the motion of her mouth on his dick delivered an intensity

he could barely stand so soon after coming. But there was no way to extricate himself; he had to simply endure the over-stimulation, his cock sloshing in Nikki's cum-filled mouth, while Tony fucked her like a jackhammer in the ass.

This particular segment of the scene played out for much longer than Jack might have expected - long enough for it to turn dark, for Jack to feel like he was outside of the scene, looking in. Nikki eventually let his cock slide from her mouth, almost out of it, while she rested her head against his thigh and stared vacantly at his opposite leg, absorbing the loud, wet smacks of Tony's thighs against her ass.

At some point, Tony reached for her head and pushed her face into Jack's groin. His cock had softened, but was sputtering to half-life as Tony fucked her. She took him entirely into her mouth again, and he felt himself lengthening, swelling in the wet liquid - though more because of the way that Tony grasped the back of her head and shook it a little, rubbing her face into his balls and pubic bone. Inside her mouth, his cock bumped painfully against the roof, her teeth, her throat, as it hardened again in spurts.

"Okay, baby girl, here it comes, honey. I'm gonna blow a big load deep in your ass, and you gonna take it. You gonna be real good for me?"

A weak murmur from Nikki, who was moving her tongue around on Jack's cock, trying to bring him to life. Tony leaned his weight on her head as he rammed himself hard, his own eyes squinting and jaw falling slightly slack as he groaned deeply and filled Nikki up, just like he had promised.

He continued to saw slowly, grunting as aftershocks ripped through him, for several minutes after he came. "Fuck," he breathed, at last, backing his hips away from her buttocks, his cock - still hard - oozing from Nikki for what

seemed like an impossibly long time. "Your ass is so hot, baby, I love fuckin' it. Nice and soft, so tight..." Tony dropped a hand to her hole and played with it absently, making a gurgle of cum sputter wetly. "Mmm."

He reached for Nikki's hair again and seized it, pulling her up to sitting on her knees, lowering her back against his thighs. He licked her from the collarbone to her ear and then tightened the fist in her hair, making Nikki's mouth fall open. Jack stared in a mixture of abject horror and envy: these were things he wanted to do, in theory, to Nikki, but just *couldn't*.

"You must be feelin' real ready, aren't you, baby?" Tony purred in her ear, making Nikki rock her hips and whine something that was incoherent but affirmative.

"You gonna thank me properly, then, for fucking you properly? Hmm? Yeah, you gonna thank me, 'cause if you do, I'll give you a little treat." Tony looked at Jack. "I'll let Jack here play with your kitty any way he wants to. You like that idea? I bet he'll make you come, 'cause he nice like that." Tony grinned and pulled Nikki's hair so that her head fell back onto his shoulder.

"Yeah," Nikki panted. "Yes."

"Yes, what?"

"Yes, I'm going to thank you," Nikki murmured, her eyes shifting to Jack's. "Thank you, Tony," she panted, when Tony didn't reply.

"Turn around baby," Tony said, gruffly. He rose up and settled his weight on the edge of the bed as he twisted Nikki's hair and head, so that she had no choice but to turn and face him. He pushed her by the back of the head toward the center of his spread legs, where his cock hovered in the air, buoyed by his "something" to keep the party going. "Give my cock a little

kiss, honey. Then get down there and roll them balls around in your mouth... nah, baby, get those eyes up here for that, I'll get it to your lips." Tony guided his cock with his left hand, still cradling Nikki's head.

Jack couldn't see what she was doing beyond the contortion of her body to get her mouth to Tony's balls. The sound came through loud and clear, though.

Tony watched this with interest for a few minutes, and then chuckled suddenly, pushing Nikki from his crotch. "Shit, that tickles, girl. That's good." His eyes shifted to Jack again. He was still smiling, the grin more sinister than ever. "Go on, get Jack here to give you your treat. I gotta go recharge, clean my dick up so I can fuck that pussy. You got me all kinds of turned around, baby." He pushed Nikki toward Jack, stood up, and walked at a leisurely pace to the bathroom.

"Send that girl in here when you done with her," he called back.

He didn't close the door. They heard the shower start and the toilet lid bang open. Tony started whistling.

Jack reached for Nikki's face and stroked her cheek. She was incredibly messy, her lips even puffier now. The scent of Tony's cum seemed to permeate her skin all over, mingled with the sweet smell of her pussy. "You okay?" he asked her.

Nikki rose to her knee, slipping a hand between her legs and pushing her fingers into her over-ripened lips. "I'm so close," she whined sexily. "Please, Jack, make me come, I need it."

There was nothing Jack could do but stare at her for a moment, flabbergasted, But her fingers made sticky sounds as they wriggled into her

pussy, and she writhed hungrily, pouting, so his instincts overcame him and he rose from the chair, pinched her shoulder between the fingers of his right hand and prodded her to the bed. She went, crawling, scrambling, all naked and wet and slippery, until she could scramble up onto the bed.

It was a jumble of Nikki's slippery bare flesh and Jack wriggling out of his clothing, as they writhed on the bed and Nikki rolled her head up on the pillows and clawed at them.

For a moment the scene was surreal enough that it seemed like the world around him shifted. The lighting of the room seemed fake, the patterns on the bedspread too garish to be real. Nikki was still Nikki: hot, his wife, blond hair, smiling mouth. But she also *wasn't* Nikki. For the duration of a few heartbeats that dragged on far longer than seemed possible, Jack felt so disoriented he wondered if someone had slipped him a drug of some kind.

Nikki stretched out on her back and twisted sexily into a number of appealing positions, before settling on spreading her legs open, her knees bent and her feet closer together than them. The invitation was clear just like that, but Nikki moved her hand – first to her thigh, which she seized the way Tony would have, and then to the center of her legs. She drew her fingers through her juices and spread apart her peace-fingers at the top, prying her swollen lips apart lewdly.

Between Nikki's legs, there was only flesh – in the shape of her vulva, sure, but so yawning and gaping and slick with mingled, mixing juices and fluids. Raw and pink, shiny with cum, patches of concentrated, creamy white streaked through the sticky coating.

He watched her fingers only a second, though it was the kind of image he knew he would retain in his mind forever, an endlessly repeating

pornographic video that never truly stopped playing somewhere in his mind. Vaguely, he recalled his aversion to a creampie; vaguely, he paid tribute to the idea that this wasn't exactly the same thing, and just as vaguely, every single one of those thoughts was flushed away by a surge of violent desire.

He lowered himself between her legs, putting his hands on her thighs to hold her open, and dove into the heaps of distended pussy, and all the slovenly wetness inside it. He tasted her juices, felt the rise of her hips and the strain of her muscles against his hands. He tasted her tang, acrid and unfamiliar flavors and textures, the chemical sweetness of lube. He found the pulsing, greedy, extremely fat bulb of her clit, and began to suck on it almost vengefully. He enjoyed the screeching, fever pitch of her voice as she strained against him and toward him all at once, her flesh soaked and dirty, her juices pouring over his chin and down to his neck.

Her hands went to his head and she pushed him against her pussy. He moved his jaw to scoop her flesh - the shapes blending together, borderless and unrecognizable - in his mouth. Her whole body went hard in his hands and pushed against him when she came, moaning and panting, and her pussy seemed to dissolve and tenderize into a gush of cum.

“Oh,” Nikki complained, as he kept going at her all through her orgasm. “Oh, God, oh Jack, please, you have to stop, oh, oh God, no, it's too much...” her voice trailed off into a mangled howl, because Jack ignored her – taking a page out of Tony's book – and thinking of the way Tony dismissed Nikki's sore pussy the night before, he carried on until she was shrieking almost hysterically. He even went beyond, until she finally relented and went limp in his hands, her thighs collapsing against the bed,

her abdomen turning to softened butter, her moans receding to incoherent howls that barely left her lips.

When he looked up at her, her eyes were still on him but had taken on the satisfying expression of retreat, or as Tony put it so deliciously, submission. Her fingers were still in his hair, but lifelessly, not even gripping him.

And yet he knew that his tongue was delivering pulses of intense pleasure to her, because her limbs occasionally jerked, against his cheeks, his hands.

“You done with her yet?” Tony called out from the bathroom, making Jack smile and lift his head to look at Nikki, who seemed intoxicated, she was so glassy-eyed. “Send Nikki in here, I got a thing I like to do.”

Jack rose up onto his knees, leaving his fingers between Nikki’s legs and playing absently with her pussy, feeling the slickness between her legs.

“That’s so beautiful, baby,” he said, absent-mindedly. He shifted his eyes to meet hers. “Go see Tony,” he said.

He liked the way his words acted on her, the way she seemed to snap out of her stupor and light up, smiling a little and coming back from the distant place she had been taken to. He reached for her hand as she held it out to him, and he pulled her up to sitting. She climbed onto him and kissed him, before clambering over him toward the foot of the bed.

He followed her to the bathroom, partly because he didn’t want to miss a moment, and partly because she didn’t let go of his left hand while she rose to standing and started in that direction.

*

Tony was already out of the shower and was toweling himself off like he was in a locker room. He looked over at Nikki and his eyes traveled all over

her body, making his lips curl in a smile. The water was still running and the shower curtain was open. He barely glanced at Jack, just pulled Nikki toward him by the hand. "I got a thing," he said, and as it was with Tony, it was anybody's guess who he was talking to. "It's kinda a fetish. Get in there, get in that tub baby, I got the water all warm for you."

Tony turned to the sink and picked up a sample bottle of soap or shampoo, while Nikki went unsteadily to the shower and stepped tentatively in at the back, feeling the temperature with her fingers. Tony poured some of the soap into his hand and tossed the bottle with unnecessary force onto the counter. It bounced loudly and careened into the floor, which Tony paid no attention to at all.

"I got a thing for washing pussy," he said, stepping toward Nikki and taking her left hand, guiding it to the far wall of the shower. He placed it there and used the same hand to put her other hand up, and adjust her ass so that she jutted it out for him.

Nikki turned and watched, as Tony narrated. "I like it when they pussy all tender, just like this..." he trailed off, taking his palmful of soap and putting it on Nikki's ass, lathering it up with water and slow, sexual strokes.

He pushed his hand between her legs and started lathering her up from pussy to ass, massaging, probing, his eyes fixated on what he was doing. Nikki held still for him, watching his hands, and mewled when he touched a sensitive place.

"Yeah, it's kinda a thing," Tony narrated, still obsessed with what he was doing. "I just like it, washing it all up, *man* you wet girl..." Tony lathered Nikki some more, making her mewl. Tony reached for the shower head and directed it so that the water splashed onto her lower back, staring as the

soap washed away. He pushed it along, rubbing his hands possessively all over Nikki's body. "Mmm," he intoned, pleased. He moved a finger to Nikki's asshole, gaped slightly, and played with her rim a little, before slapping her hard on the right buttock and smiling again.

Just as abruptly as he did everything, he turned, grinning, and walked toward the door, where Jack was standing, transfixed.

Jack edged out of his way, and Tony gave him a poignant stare-down as he exited - still smiling, somewhat friendly, but packed with the implicit message that had not escaped Jack's mind for a moment: he was also still *in charge*.

Nikki rolled up and moved the stream of water back to its normal angle. She closed the shower curtain, probably out of well-embedded instinct more than anything, and rotated slowly under the stream of water with her arms crossed over her chest, smiling.

"Don't *get* that hair wet," Tony called out, striding toward the mini-bar. Jack started to walk into the bathroom when Tony called out. "Hey man, you one of them advanced paramedics. Give it to me straight, am I gonna die, I have a drink of this shit?"

Jack looked at Tony, who was inspecting the drink bottles and was, Jack was fairly certain, not going to do anything one way or the other based on Jack's answer.

Still, paramedic protocol kicked in and he began The Speech: "Uh, it's not recommended, because it can counteract the drug effects," - Tony laughed heartily at this - "and cause side effects to -"

"Man, I just wanna know if it gonna kill me or what."

Tony was already pouring a whiskey down his throat by the time Jack looked over at him.

"Uh, yeah, well. Probably not, but you didn't hear that from me."

Nikki had stopped turning in the shower and was trying to hear their conversation. "What's he doing?" she asked, her own paramedic instincts kicking in. "Alcohol?"

Jack shook his head and stepped into the bathroom, closing the door behind him. "He'll be fine," he said, mildly annoyed that Tony had such a competitive edge on him - in the form of Viagra or whatever he had taken - even if that competitive edge was playing into Jack's fantasies exactly.

Nikki looked for a moment like she was going to make a big, textbook case out of it, her eyes going to the side the way they did when she was recalling pharmaceutical information she didn't use on the regular.

She surprised Jack - yet again - by shrugging and continuing to turn under the water.

"Man, don't get in that shower with her and muck that pussy up," Tony called out.

"I gotta piss," Jack said, without thinking, lifting the toilet seat with his toe. Nikki leaned from behind the shower curtain and made a face at him: the interaction had the air of being teenagers trying to smoke behind the dumpster in high school with the football coach on patrol.

Jack peed and kicked the lid back down before flushing, and then took a fresh towel off the rack above it. He shook it out and held it for Nikki.

"Didn't say anything about drying you off," he told her, when she looked at him with a faux scandalized expression.

She turned the water off and stepped out of the shower into Jack's waiting arms. He dried her off, taking his time, all the way from neck to calves, and then embraced her from behind and wrapped the towel around her.

Nikki took over the handling of the towel, grinning - Jack always professed total idiocy about how to tie up towels on women, while Jack let his hands wander down to the tops of her thighs, then between her legs. "Are you still good?" he whispered. He didn't want the excitement in his voice - he *hoped*, more fervently than anything, that Nikki was still good - because he wanted a real answer.

A purr rumbled in Nikki's throat, vibrating against his chest through her back. She lifted a hand to his cheek and worked her fingers up from there to his hair while he peppered her neck with kisses.

"Still good."

CHAPTER 4

Tony was ready for Nikki again by the time she exited the bathroom, shiny and clean. He was sipping brown liquid from the water glass he'd unwrapped, and by the looks of it, he'd cleaned several bottles out to pour it. His eyes went to Nikki immediately, looking her up and down wolfishly, leaving nothing about his desires to the imagination.

Tony had plans for Nikki again, and they were filthy.

Jack followed, a towel loosely around his waist, though he didn't really know why he had bothered. He followed, falling back a little, watching Nikki's ass moving beneath the skimpy towel that barely covered it.

"Come on over here, baby girl," Tony said, spreading his legs out to display his ready cock. He stroked himself lazily as Nikki obeyed him, walking slowly, loosening the tie above her breasts. The towel slid open and fell to the floor, and she stood naked in front of him, awaiting instruction. Jack sat down on the edge of the bed, facing them, watching. It was Tony's show, after all, and he wasn't feeling uncomfortable with it at all anymore.

"Now," Tony said, reaching out for her as she stepped closer to him, "I'm gonna start in on the main meal." He grinned, laughing a little at his own joke.

Tony put his hands behind Nikki's knees and swirled his fingers on the sensitive skin there, making Nikki visibly shudder. Tony grinned. "All them ladies like that. Huh? You be good and I'll lick you right where you like it... right there?" Tony twisted his arm to make a small circle inside the back of her knee. "Yeah. But first you gotta get up here and give me some of that pussy."

He leaned back and looked at Nikki confidently. She climbed onto his lap, and he put his hands on her buttocks, cupping them, resisting her as she tried to lower down. He pulled her body toward him, until her mound was against his mouth. "I been thinkin' about this pussy all day long," Tony mused, staring at her navel, his breath hot on her mound. "I like her ass, I like her mouth. But I like this..." he moved a hand to her front, drawing his finger over her hipbone and to the center of her legs, slicing through her cunt with his pointer finger and grinning as her flesh opened for it and closed around it, wet and hot.

He used that hand to grasp his cock and point it straight up, dragging it through her lips, making it suck wetly at the tip. "She always ready, Nikki. Yeah. Just sittin' in that desk all day in those tight jeans and I gotta put this pussy outta my mind..."

Tony moved quickly, surprisingly, like a cat springing on its prey: he lined his cock up with Nikki's hole and moved his hand back to her hip again, then pushed her down violently, ramming himself into her deep. Nikki gasped, and the fingers she was resting on his shoulders snapped like a trap, clawing into his flesh.

Tony shifted Nikki with a series of mechanical, jarring movements, twisting her hips, shaking her and wrenching her to drive himself up and settle her weight to the base of his cock. He had to sit on the edge of the chair so she could get on him. In spite of his tunnel-vision of arousal, Jack had to marvel at the way the two of them synchronized to balance Tony's bulk on the chair, leaning forward and bracing themselves as if they had choreographed the whole thing for a porno.

Once she was settled on his cock, Tony worked them back into the chair and put his hands on Nikki's hips, his fingers wrapped around her ass. "Now

I want you to go nice and slow for me, little girl. Just roll them hips and ride that cock nice and easy. I wanna take a nice long tour of that pussy..." his words dribbled away, as even the great Tony succumbed to distraction with Nikki's hot sheath moving up and down his cock.

In the next excruciating ten minutes, Jack stared, still standing, as Nikki slowly rode Tony, her body undulating in each languid stroke - hips rolling forward and back as she rose and fell. His cock had lengthened to the ready, and he started to feel conspicuous, so, without taking his eyes off the scene, he climbed into the bed and clumsily arranged himself at the head, sitting up.

Nikki and Tony seemed to have forgotten he was even there, and the intimacy between them took on a surreal light. Jack felt like he was being sucked out of the room, more voyeur with each passing moment.

When Nikki started to moan and move faster, nearing another orgasm, Tony gripped her ass and slowed her down, growling instructions in her ear that only Nikki could hear. Nikki slowed her pace, but the building crest inside her pressed against the surface of her skin in her tense muscles and left her throat in mewls and moans that bordered on whiny complaining - sexily.

A change in her voice marked her orgasm, and Tony plunged her hard onto his lap, sheathing his cock fully, his hands wrapped around her ribcage. "Yeah, baby. That feels good. Tony likes that."

His balls, physically matched to his personality, squeezed like two overripe fruits beneath Nikki's stretched-open legs, and her juices rolled down them, making them shine. Nikki made incomprehensible, indescribable noises, some like the squeaks of a small mammal, others guttural and heavy, as though from the belly of a much larger, wilder animal.

Tony slapped her on the ass a few times, playfully, when she collapsed on his lap, seemingly spent. “Keep on going, baby. I wanted you to come so your pussy is sensitive, honey. So you gotta keep on riding me even though your kitty says to stop. That’s it,” Tony murmured approval when Nikki started to roll, moaning, on his lap again.

“You whining to me?” Tony said into her ear, chuckling. He pushed his fingers into her hair again and pulled her body close to his chest, fingers wandering all over her backside. “You know I like that,” he told her, like he was revealing a surprise gift. “I like it when you start whining about your pussy.” Tony pushed her hair to one side and contemplated her neck and the side of her face. He played with her lips as she leaned against him, crumpled, and ground against him, very obviously oversensitive. Her toes curled and she twisted her ankles in discomfort.

“Your pussy hurting?” Tony asked her. “Tell me about it, honey.”

“Tooonnnnyyyy,” she whined, making Tony grin in satisfaction. “Please, I just want a little break... it’s so... I can’t do it... anymore...” Nikki had her arms at her chest and her face against Tony’s shoulders now, but if she really couldn’t do it anymore, she showed no signs of stopping her hips from delivering the opposite message.

In Jack’s chest, cold, raw pain bloomed and then dissolved into searing heat as he watched for another long ten minutes as Tony made Nikki ride on his cock. She began this way – reluctant, overstimulated, whiny – but soon her own desires had started gnawing at her and she was bobbing on Tony’s cock with her own need.

Nikki came again. Her legs shook and she sobbed into Tony’s shoulder. When he drew his finger down her back along her spine, her body twitched

violently and Tony grinned. He did it again. Then he looked at Jack. “Now she really sore. Ain’t you baby? And the only thing gonna make your feel better is a big load of cum.”

“Tony...” Nikki panted. “Oh, oh, oooohhhh,” Nikki whined, as Tony rose to standing with Nikki wrapped around him, as if she weighed no more than a feather. “Drop them feet,” Tony told her, and she did. “Now get on that chair doggy-style.” Nikki obeyed, mewling and squirming, but without real protest.

“I like this,” Tony commented, lining himself up behind her. “Tip that ass up, Nikki, yeah. Good girl.” Nikki tilted her ass up and looked behind her, clutching the chair.

Tony had to tip his dick at a downward angle to get it into her pussy, and Jack remembered the evening before, when he had seen Tony’s cock roll beneath the skin of her stomach. Nikki howled when he entered her, and Jack knew the same thing was happening again. Tony, stretching the limits of her body, drilling deep, pushing out.

Nikki howled, then started to scream, as Tony began a blitzkrieg of fucking, rapidly slamming into her at the downward angle. When he came, it was a huge bellow and a deep thrust, and Nikki whimpered when he drove in.

But Tony wasn’t done. He rested for a bit, panting, smiling, his fingers moving over Nikki’s body, dipping into her ass, slapping her butt occasionally, very playfully.

He picked her up by the hips, lifting her easily and planting her dangling feet on the ground. Nikki started to lift her torso and Tony ran a hand down her back to her neck, pushing her down again. Her knees buckled and she went to the floor, as Tony pressed on her head. His cock flopped out of her

pussy as her body lowered, and he worked his way around her with his hand on her head, back to sitting in the chair.

He seized Nikki's hair with both hands once he was settled, and held it above her head again, this time playing with it like he was a beautician deciding how to cut it. Then he ordered Nikki to open her mouth and swung her head gently over his still-hard cock, letting her tongue graze it on each pass. He held his dick with his left hand and pushed her face toward it. "Clean that all off for me baby," he ordered her.

Tony watched Nikki for a bit and then looked up at Jack. "She gettin' real tired," Tony said, smiling. Nikki was lapping at Tony's dick, her head swinging like a plaything in his hands. He let her hair fall from his fingers and her head sank into his lap.

He put his big arms out, as if he expected a huge booth to rest them on, and waved the fingers of his right hand toward the fridge. "Grab us all a coupla them drinks. Put some ice in it." He tilted his head and looked at Nikki, who was diligently sucking his cock.

"I like a cold mouth on my dick when I take them pills," he said, and yet again, Jack didn't know if he was talking to Nikki or him.

Tony stroked Nikki's cheek with one finger and twisted her head so his cock was pushing out against her cheek and into his finger. He gathered his fingers into a pincher and applied it to the shape of his cock pushing out through her skin, stroking himself through Nikki's cheek in a long, unhurried sequence as Jack poured some whiskey into the glass with ice. There weren't enough glasses, but he decided Tony didn't need that detail reported to him.

Tony took the drink without looking up from Nikki's face, and Jack stood behind him, staring. Nikki's eyes were heavy with sleep, and empty of thought, fixed on something to her left. Tony's cock pushed her cheek out and then ducked into her mouth. He started to move her head this way and that, seemingly trying on the different angles he could fuck her mouth from: and it did become *that* after a while, as opposed to Nikki sucking him.

Then he fished an ice cube from the glass and held it above Nikki's face. Nikki looked up at it and let Tony's cock slip from her lips. Tony moved the cube to her mouth and drew it over her lips, then between her teeth. "Let that melt in your mouth, baby. Then get my balls in there."

Nikki took this moment to look at Jack, but Tony's finger shot out to her chin and he tipped it back to center. "Nah, you lookin' at me, honey. Get that mouth nice and cold." He absently splayed his fingers across her face, playing with her lips, fiddling with her like she was a blow-up doll.

Nikki rolled the cube around in her mouth, playing Tony's game exactly as Jack imagined Tony wanted her to. Her mouth was a big, sloshing, wet churn of tongue and ice cube, panting and murmurs that screamed in Jack's head: his wife was performing like a seasoned porn star, and he couldn't quite get his head around it.

"Now get my balls in your mouth, baby girl."

Nikki tilted her head and stretched her mouth open, while Tony held his cock to his stomach so she could sweep his whole sack into her wet lips. Jack's own balls felt like ice as Tony's disappeared into Nikki's icy-wet mouth.

Tony tipped his head back and groaned in pleasure, which seemed to travel through Nikki and activate her even more: her jaw moved enthusiastically

to roll Tony's sac in her puffed cheeks. Tony tipped his head down to watch her and lazily played with her hair, the whiskey in his hand largely unsipped, suspended next to his cheek with his claw down over the top.

Jack had made his own drink in a plastic glass - more because he needed something to do with hands than anything else - and had returned to the bed to sit and watch the show. He edged back into place against the headboard, close to the wall, clearing the way for Tony and Nikki - if Tony ever tired of feeding her ice cubes and making her suck his balls, or lick his cock, as he moved on to next.

It was late, and in spite of the stimulation before his very eyes, Jack felt his eyelids getting heavy. Nikki never stopped working on Tony for a moment, but the sucking sounds slowed to a steady rhythm and Jack started to feel sleepier by the second.

His eyelids started to close for longer periods, and he would flip them open in a panic, jolted awake by the snuffle of a really wet slurp, or a plunge into a nightmarish dreamscape - the startled jolt felt a lot like being in the military again, jolted awake by nothing but the circuits of his own mind coming back to the same idea over and over again: something dangerous was out there.

He was just recovering from one such jolt, watching Nikki's ever-slowing head and tongue wriggling in Tony's lap, when Tony himself seemed to get a little sleepy. He pushed Nikki's hair from her face - she was now lying with her cheek against his thigh, her tongue making languid sweeps over his balls and the root of his dick, a faint smile on her lips, her eyelids very heavy.

"Go get on that bed, baby doll. Take a little break."

He helped push her up. Nikki crawled over to the bed and rolled herself up and into it, stretching out alongside Jack, facing him on her side. She met his eyes as he touched her lips, an absent-minded gesture, born of some desire to feel them between his own fingers, maybe get a feel for their puffiness, to smear Tony's ever-seeping precum on her tongue, or because her mouth seemed so sexual in that moment; like her pussy, it appealed to him just to play with its rubbery, objectified sexiness.

Nikki reached toward Jack and moved her fingers over his chest, but she was so sleepy by then that her eyes were already falling closed.

Tony made himself another drink and stood ominously by the desk near the window, watching them over the rim of the glass. When Nikki's hands went still, he emitted a soft snort through his nostrils and downed the remaining whiskey.

He set the now-empty glass down on the night table and exhaled loudly, the way an actor would in a commercial for a soft drink. His eyes, almost as grabby as his hands, moved over Nikki's body, lingering on her ass. The expression on his face was a window into his thoughts; to Jack, it was almost as sexual watching him look at her like that as watching him actually fuck her.

The huge man was moving, so slowly Jack didn't notice it at first, to the foot of the bed, surveying with obvious pride the thorough job he had done. At the foot of the bed, he twisted his back toward the wall and lifted Nikki's feet so that he could position himself beneath them.

Nikki stirred, and her heavy eyelids struggled against her exhaustion to open. Then she purred and closed them again. Tony was massaging her feet

- his huge, brutal hands working on them intensely, driving his thumb into her sole. He inspected her feet as he did this, approval in his eyes.

"She like havin' pretty feet," Tony commented, but this was an observation that he seemed to feel needed no further explanation, because he kept rubbing her feet silently, eyes moving back up along her legs to her ass.

When his hands started to follow - moving to her ankles, then to the back of her knees - making Nikki murmur something incoherent - Jack's pulse accelerated and he started to worry. "I think she's all worn out," he said, very quietly. Tony was his intended audience, and Tony registered his remark with a slow-moving, sly smile.

"Yeah," he said, after ignoring the comment for a bit while he made a swirl in the soft center of Nikki's knee socket. "But I ain't done."

He slid out from under her feet and climbed onto the bed. His mission was locked in now: Jack could see it set in his eyes as surely as if a switch had been flipped. He knew this single-minded look, a blend of sexual predation and soldier-like fixation: any man of a rank-and-file system like the police or fire, or the military - where Jack himself had learned the features of the mindset first-hand - possessed this switch.

And almost any man possessed the sexual obsession switch.

It was somewhat terrifying to see them together on a man of Tony's size: Jack looked to Nikki for signs of protest, praying silently she wouldn't. Other than an outsized dose of ketamine, it didn't seem like much was going to get between Tony and whatever he had set his sights on.

Tony was straddling Nikki, his hands moving over her bottom, enjoying the smooth expanse of taut skin over firm muscle. Jack edged out of his way,

danger still flickering in the back of his mind. Nikki was still sleepily stirring, her eyelids heavy, her mouth open slightly. As Tony worked his fingers into her ass, dipping and feeling, stretching and probing, a series of high-pitched moans straight from a porno track left her lips.

But she didn't *move*, and she didn't protest, so Jack stared, transfixed, and did nothing to intervene. It was more awe than anything else: he couldn't believe that Tony was going for it again.

Tony lifted an arm without taking his eyes off Nikki. "Gramme that lube," he ordered, and there was little question who that order was for. Jack crawled to the foot of the bed and walked around them, staring, to where the lube had been tossed by Tony. He dropped it into Tony's upturned and waiting palm.

Nikki's hips wriggled between his legs. "Mmm," she intoned, sexily, "Tony..."

Tony poured a significant helping of lube into his palm and tossed the bottle to the bed. Jack was returning, moving slowly, hoping Tony didn't notice him or tell him to stay in the chair. But Tony's mind was now centered on Nikki alone, as far as he could tell. He stroked his ever-ready cock to lube it up.

"Baby, I just gotta have it one more time. You ain't gotta do nothing but take a load of cum in that ass." He finger-fucked her, adding another finger every minute or so until he had three inside her. He twisted his wrist, so his palm was plastered against the crack of her ass, and leaned over her, holding himself up in basically a one-armed plank that looked to be exerting him as much as taking a nap.

Then he lay down on top of her as he sank his cock into her ass. Nikki was still inert, lifelessly letting herself be almost fisted. Her eyes fluttered open as Tony entered her, and she looked at Jack, who was climbing back to his place on the bed. In her eyes, the vacancy of her total submission had set in, leaving her as placid as a doll in every way.

Tony's bicep dropped between her face and Jack as he lay down, resting on his forearms, and started fucking Nikki slowly. Her eyes were squinted closed when Jack saw snippets of them in the movement, her mouth gaping.

Tony surprised him by looking over at him and grinning, just before he moved his right arm down Nikki's body to her hip bone. He worked his fingers beneath their combined weight, and Jack assumed he was searching for Nikki's clit, hoping to play with her until she came and the muscles in her ass milked his cum.

Instead, he shifted their bodies - through brute and extraordinary strength - over a few feet, toward Jack, who edged away, unsure of what was happening.

Then he rolled himself, and Nikki, very slowly to the side, his cock still embedded in her ass. Nikki turned her head toward him and opened her eyes, not saying anything, but questioning what he was doing with her expression. Tony was propped up on his left arm, and he dropped his hand to her jaw and held it, so Nikki had no choice but to look at him. He fucked her for a few seconds like this, his right arm sliding down her body to her right leg. He lifted it up and held it, bent at the knee, so that Nikki's pussy was spread open for Jack.

"She gonna like this. You gonna like this baby doll." Tony shifted his eyes to Jack. "Stick your fingers in there and rub all that skin, right along where

my cock pressed up in there."

Jack hesitated, even as his limbs started to move him into position.

"That ain't no gay shit, man. You givin' her the massage. Trust me, she gonna squeal like you ain't never heard."

Tony turned his attention to Nikki, then, and put the fingers of his left hand into her mouth. Operating them like a jack, he pried her mouth open and looked inside.

Jack reached for Nikki's pussy and felt around the entrance. Tony's grip on her body was so secure that she couldn't wriggle away, so she mewled when he touched her. Gingerly, he slipped a finger inside.

His fingertip felt the solid, thick column of Tony's dick, squeezing her canal into a tight, fleshy tunnel of silk. He ran his finger along Tony's slowly-moving shaft through the thin layer of flesh that separated it from his direct touch.

"Don't be a pussy about it, man, get a couple in there at least. She'll like it."

Jack slipped a second finger in and used his thumb to rub her clit, pleased with how Nikki's body tensed anew, and she wriggled slightly. Tony was dipping his fingers into her mouth, and Nikki was sucking on them as he pulled them out.

"You gonna come for me one more time, baby?" Tony asked Nikki, grinning before he even finished. "Yeah, you are. You like that, don't you? She gettin' hot, she gettin' close," Tony continued.

Jack moved in time with Nikki's building orgasm, overwhelmed by his senses: Nikki's vacant stare, her mewls, the scent of her pussy, the squelch

of Tony's lubed-up cock, the feel of it moving beneath Nikki's silkiest flesh: his own cock was by now so hard it hurt, precum pouring from it in a steady stream.

"Open your mouth, baby," Tony purred, as Nikki started to squeak. "Open it wide."

Nikki obeyed, and Tony stared into her mouth for a moment before pursing his lips, hovering directly over her mouth, and letting a big drop of saliva gather in the center of his mouth, grow, swirling in the light, and then drop, right into her throat.

The effect of this action coursed through Nikki's body, making her pussy quiver and squeeze. "Oh, oh, Jack, oh, don't stop," she breathed, her hips starting to wriggle. She was pinned by Tony, so this amounted to nothing, and Jack kept working on her steadfastly. But he was torn: a part of him wanted to keep her below the threshold, so that he could keep finger-fucking her. He wanted to kiss her mouth when she came, but Tony had her head locked where he wanted it, and there was no way to her lips.

Nikki's hand went to Jack's hip and she squeezed when her body shuddered, her mouth open in a soundless scream. Her pussy poured hot liquid all over his hand.

Tony *chuckled*. "Don't you let up on that," he instructed Jack, without looking at him. "I like it when she all wiggly."

"Jack... Tony..." Nikki panted, "I'm so sore, Jack, please..."

Tony was grinning. "Yeah, I like that. 'Member I told you that, baby? I like to make a girl like you whine... and beg... you keep that up. Tony likes that."

"Tony..." Nikki complained, but when Tony reacted by thrusting his cock in deeper - Jack could feel the pulsing throb Nikki's whine had elicited, her complaint warbled to a gurgle in her throat and she went silent.

"Keep on strokin' that pussy, man, what you doin'?" Tony growled, and Jack obeyed command without hesitation. "She ain't gonna break, she just gonna start sayin' it's too much." Tony leaned over her and shook her very minutely by the jaw. "Ain't you?"

"I'm... Tony... I can't... it's too much... it's..." Nikki's voice fell away into squeaking gasps. "Oh! Oh, Jack... please, Jack..."

Another sinister chuckle from Tony. "Jack ain't gonna be no help, baby doll. Nah. He gonna keep feelin' that hot pussy and makin' you squirm." Tony nuzzled Nikki's ear. "You wanna be done? Hmm? You need a break?"

"Yes," Nikki panted. "Yes, Tony, please... please... I need a break... oh, Jack, oh my God..."

"Nuh-uh," Tony said, when she tried to look over at Jack. "Nah, baby doll, you gotta beg Tony. Tony in charge. You wanna load of cum, baby? Hmm? You want to sleep?"

"Tony," Nikki said, and her eyes were getting wet, a tear forming in the corner of her eye.

"All you gotta do then, honey, is squeeze that ass. You gonna squeeze it around my cock. You ever milk a cow?" Tony laughed at his own question. "Nah, she a city girl. But you gonna do that for me. And then if you're good, you're gonna have all that nice hot cum in your ass. That what you want?"

Nikki was silent, mewling, as she moved her head in assent.

Tony thrust deeper into her, and pulled her leg open even wider. He used the same rough but minute movements now that he had used earlier in the chair, adjusting Nikki's body like it was exercise equipment, until he had her just where he wanted her. A glare at Jack advised him in no uncertain terms to move his own hand with Nikki's pussy and continue to make her body shudder with his fingers.

"That's it, honey," Tony growled. Jack felt her muscles contract and release, and Nikki moaned. "Do it again. You just keep milking that cock, girl, 'til Tony tells you to stop."

Nikki obeyed him, mewling incoherent protestations as she did. When Jack stroked her or his knuckle grazed her very swollen clit, her body spasmed, and she panted and squeaked, but diligently did as Tony asked. It seemed to go on forever, and Jack's cock was dripping so much cum he thought (and somewhat hoped) he might ejaculate like a wet dream, without touching himself at all. The pain was a tight fist punching upward into his abdomen by then, his balls so taut they felt like they'd split.

Nikki's body was going a little more limp with each pulse of her ass. "I... can't... Tony... oh, please..." she pleaded.

Jack shifted his ever-darting eyes to Tony and met his smirking gaze. "Tony, man," he said. "I think she's done..."

Tony obviously found this both amusing and utterly irrelevant, because he smiled and lowered his head to bite Nikki's shoulder without comment. He licked her from shoulder to neck and pulled her hair to tip her head back. "Look at me, little girl. Look at me while you massaging that cock... you tired, huh?"

Nikki mewled.

"You wore out now?" Tony asked. "That's good. That's what I want. But your hubby here got some blue-ass balls, little girl. Now what we gonna do about that? Hmm?"

Nikki rolled her head to the side, and Tony let her. Her eyes met Jack's, but the vacancy of submission and exhaustion had settled into them, and they were unfocused and distant. Tony chuckled again. "Yeah, she *done*. Almost." He nuzzled Nikki's ear again and murmured something into it.

As if a clockwork mechanism had been activated in Nikki's body, her eyes opened and focused on Jack, and she moved her right arm from where it had been flung between her head and Tony's muscle, and reached for Jack's cock. She seized him, wrapping her hand around his shaft and squeezing, then began to give him a hand job - a distracted, tired hand job, her eyes focused on nothing at all.

Tony began to fuck her again, and Jack's fingers went still in her pussy as she milked *his* cock, until they slipped from inside her and he was left in a supremely awkward position, half bent over and propped up on his elbow, one leg bent, his eyes on Nikki's hand stroking his dick.

Nikki reactivated a little when his cock flexed and the veins surged, just before he came. She pointed his dick toward her tits, and his cum sprayed all over her abdomen and across her sternum, a thick rope landing over her lightly bouncing right breast.

"Feed that to her man, let her suck it off your fingertips while I fill her up. Ah, that's *hot*, Nikki, Jesus, you a hot little slut, girl."

And so Jack, as hypnotized by Tony as his wife, obeyed this command, and drew his own splattered load from her chest to her lips. Nikki closed her

lips around his two fingertips sweetly, her eyes falling closed at the same time as if he had given her a sedative.

Tony started fucking her then, dropping her leg, which fell like a tree branch with a wet slap against her and his entangled thighs and legs. Nikki's body flopped and shook as Tony groaned loudly and hammered his load into her ass, rolling her onto her stomach as he came to thrust deep, one huge hand pressing her head to the mattress so heavily that half her face sank into it.

Tony rolled onto his back, edging Nikki's limp body over to make room for himself.

"Damn," Jack thought he heard him say. Nikki was lifeless, and her eyes closed in two slow, drugged-seeming blinks. Jack stretched out facing her, tucked a strand of hair behind her ear, and Nikki smiled very faintly, sleepily, and began to say something. But her mouth parted, and she fell asleep with it slightly slack.

Jack fell asleep at some point shortly thereafter.

CHAPTER 5

Tony woke up at some point in the early hours of the morning. The curtains weren't totally closed, and a blueish, crack-of-dawn light peered through the gap. Jack barely woke up; the shift in the bed when Tony hefted his weight out of it stirred him, and he watched with one open eye as Tony stood up, stretched, pulled the curtain back a little, and gathered up his things with surprising agility for a man his size.

Jack was sleepier than he had been in a long, long time, and decided to just let Tony leave. By the time he had even thought about whether or not that was the proper etiquette in a situation like this, he had fallen asleep again. Tony was gone the next time he woke up, and Jack didn't even remember hearing the door close.

The next time he woke up, Nikki was still sound asleep. He touched her hair, pushing it back from her face, and made a very half-hearted attempt to rouse her - but in truth, he was relieved she didn't wake up. Thirst gripped his throat in a rough, scratchy grip; his head was pounding; and after the night before, a very vague fear wandered through his thoughts, more fantastical than real, that Nikki was impossible to satisfy.

He decided to find some water and take a shower, and by then Nikki might have woken up of her own accord. Jack couldn't remember the last time that he almost hoped Nikki - or any woman - wouldn't wake up and pull him back into bed, her legs open and inviting. The thought was enough to get him hard in the shower, but not enough to be the instigator.

He ended up slamming several glasses of water from the tap - ordinarily he wouldn't have stooped to that, but he was so thirsty that the water, set on

cold, was a refreshing as something served on ice in a restaurant. He set the coffee maker up to brew some coffee, assuming the gurgling would wake Nikki.

The shower was pleasantly haunted by the memories of the night before. Tony's frank admission that he obsessed over washing pussy, and the images of him doing just that with Nikki, aroused Jack.

Nikki, however, was still asleep when he left the bathroom, in exactly the same position he had left her in, her legs akimbo and arms thrown out as if someone had tossed her into the bed unconscious and let everything land however it did.

He sat on the edge of the bed and murmured in her ear. "Hey sleepyhead."

Nikki stirred, smiled, and began a stretch with her legs, but it petered out halfway, and she went limp without extending her legs fully or moving her arms at all. She said something, but Jack couldn't understand it at all.

It was half past ten, and they didn't have to check out until one - he had thought far ahead and asked for the late check-out from the get-go. He sat for a while, weighing his options and competing instincts, before deciding to let Nikki sleep on. He set out for the Thai restaurant, moving slowly, hoping they would be open by eleven at the latest for the early lunch crowd.

*

"Okay, beautiful, I have to wake you up."

Nikki smiled without opening her eyes. It seemed like she hadn't moved at all, but she was already awake. Jack could tell by her respirations, as she could by his: it was an occupational hazard few people probably thought about. Very hard to pretend-sleep to a hardened paramedic.

"I don't feel like I can move," Nikki murmured. Her voice was low and charmingly craggy from sleep and exhaustion.

Nikki rolled up lazily to a seated position, folding her legs into a cross-legged position from elementary school assemblies, pushing her tousled hair from her face and smiling sleepily. She wrapped herself in a sheet as she did so, piling it loosely over her front, but not bothering to fix it in place. It clung to her breasts tenuously, taking up a great deal of Jack's attention as it slipped in microscopic advances with each breath or movement of her arms.

"I'm so thirsty," she said, hoarsely, and Jack had a huge bottle of chilled water waiting for her. He watched as she chugged it and waved a blue Gatorade in his hand so she knew he had gotten her that as well. He was pleased with the smile that crinkled her eyes, and unsurprised that she kept chugging the water. When she at last paused to gasp for air, a single drop of water escaped her lips and rolled from the corner of her mouth. She reached for the Gatorade, her eyes lighting up. "You are my hero," she said, wrenching the top open and laying into the Gatorade as if the liter of water had never happened.

Jack handed her the take-out box and watched her as she opened it and took in the sight of her favorite Thai noodles - the ones she had hoped to order the night before. "Oh, my, God!" she squealed with delight. "This is perfect." She looked at him for a moment, chopsticks poised in her hand. She looked up at him, smiling. "Were the same people there as last night?" Then she grinned mischievously. "Are we eating in bed, Jack?"

He jumped into bed with her, opting not to deliver the one-liner that immediately occurred to him, which was that the sheets really did need to

be changed anyway, so why not? Leaving that part out projected a carefree version of himself that he liked better.

Also, he didn't really care at all. Having food in bed or out of it was the last thing on his mind.

Nikki was already wolfing her take-out down. "I'm so hungry," she explained, laughing. "Don't try to stop me."

Jack had never seen Nikki - or any woman, for that matter - eat like this, and he wanted to tell her she was safe from *anyone* interrupting the process. She was taking her meal down the way an adolescent football player might, and he felt an equivalent sense of danger about interfering with her food.

She polished off the noodles in no time, lurched abruptly to kiss him on the cheek, and then hopped out of bed, saying that she had to pee like a racehorse. She caught sight of the time as she turned to say this, and her eyes went wide. "Oh my God," she whispered. "Are we late checking out?"

Jack shook his head. "Late check-out," he explained. His voice was already moving on to a seductive tone, his eyes already wandering over Nikki's body, hungering to touch her. "Get back here right after you pee," he told her.

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"I want to know," he began, settling in next to her when she returned, after tossing on a pair of panties and an undershirt and jumping onto the bed to lie down next to him with a twinkle in her eye. He was stroking her hair. "What you're thinking."

He touched his fingers to Nikki's breasts, plumped together by the way her arm lay over her chest, causing the fullness of her breasts to spill from the

low cut of the camisole, almost to the nipple. He stroked the nub of her right breast with his thumb and Nikki squirmed and giggled, moving her arm to nudge his fingers gently away.

"I'm too sensitive," she complained, and Jack groaned in mock complaint, pulling her close to him. When she said things like that, it re-ignited his lust, and he could feel his cock twitching with excitement.

"Seriously," Nikki laughed, half-heartedly slapping at him playfully. "I can't."

Even if Jack had really wanted to, he was pretty sure that his own equipment was down for the day. He rolled partially onto Nikki's body anyway and studied her face, touching her lips, stroking her earlobes. Feeling the ripple of discomfort and arousal that passed through her with every caress was intoxicating. "I just like teasing you," he told her. "But I think I'm done for at least a few hours."

Nikki smiled as he positioned himself next to her, facing each other on the pillows. How long had it been since they had done this? It seemed like forever, probably since before the kids were born.

Nikki touched his face, her fingers lingering on the rough hair of his stubble. She bit her lip. "I like this," she told him, wriggling her body closer to him.

"The beard? Or something else?"

Nikki played with his chin, watching her own fingers, and smiled. "Both," she said, finally. She lifted her eyes to meet his. "But I was talking about *this*." She moved her finger from him to her and back again, pointing, before intertwining her fingers with his. "That's what I'm thinking about."

She leaned in to kiss him. "It's weird, isn't it?"

"What's that?"

Nikki shrugged, but the way she was lying on the bed, half-naked, thoroughly exhausted, her body full of cum and her skin redolent with sweat, it seemed more like a sexy invitation than a shrug. "Just that... I feel like we're closer than ever, after that. It seems... too good to be true. You know? I was worried about it." Her expression changed suddenly, a bit of darkness creeping into her face. "I almost chickened out, at the last minute, the first time, because of that."

Jack stroked her cheek. "Really?"

Nikki nodded. "I guess I didn't really understand what... like what *appealed* to you about it. I couldn't imagine it."

Jack kissed her fingers. "But you were willing to try?"

It was beneath this particular rock that the truth he most deeply wanted lay, though who knew how far buried. The "why" to everything that Nikki did. Why had she remembered him from their first meeting? Why had she married him? Why had she indulged his fantasy, finally?

Because Nikki had answers to all of those questions.

Back when they had first met, after they had slept together, he ventured to ask about the first one: why, of all the people she ran into every day, had she even remembered him after that first scene?

Nikki had been taken aback by the question. "I mean, I don't know. Why did *you* remember *me*? It was just such a crazy coincidence."

"I thought you were hot as fuck, so I asked around and went to the bar in the hopes of finding you," he had confessed truthfully, in response.

"Oh," Nikki had laughed. "Wow. Really?" And then she had marveled, with childlike naivety: "That's a very romantic story."

She had been very pleased with that story. She had acted like it didn't happen to her all the time, giving off a very realistic impression of it actually seeming "romantic" and "sweet."

It had been Jack's first taste of the fountain of guilelessness within Nikki, the guilelessness that paired so oddly with her no-nonsense, sardonic wit; her paramedic street smarts; her finely-tuned intuition into human nature. It was difficult to believe in it, and yet it was always there, manifesting itself like that.

Wow. What a great story about something that no one else would ever, ever, do if they saw me on a call.

Why had she married him? It was a question he'd asked her point-blank, sometimes in the heat of an argument, sometimes after drinking too much, sometimes in a tender moment like this one.

"Because I *love* you."

Nikki had her reasons, but they were all imbued with the same unbelievable guilelessness: she liked that he came looking for her that first meeting, as if Jack were the only man who had ever done such a thing. She liked that he thought she was the most beautiful woman he'd ever seen, as if Jack were the only man who thought that on the planet. She liked that he was family man, she liked his hair or the way he ate peanuts. She thought he was smart

and funny, she had somehow gotten the impression that he was a hot-shit paramedic.

She didn't know what made her *love* him, it was just a collection of things, but she knew that she did.

That was her most common answer, anyway.

Why did it never satisfy him? Why did he keep digging for more? Was it because he wanted her to say something more akin to his own thoughts? After all, *he* would never give the raw, honest details of his love for Nikki - that his mind and heart had somehow been consumed in a single gulp by the sweetness of her pussy, that he couldn't think about anyone else or anything else once he had made love to her, that so much of his feelings did in fact revolve around that very part of her. So how could he expect Nikki to say something equivalent to the thoughts he kept secret?

"I don't know, Jack," she would sometimes say, becoming slightly annoyed if he kept pressing. "How do you explain a feeling like love? You're... you. It's just everything about you."

Leaving Jack to suspect things, and doubt things, to always assume that something dark or unpleasant lay beneath the water.

And so now he was here, with this latest question burning inside of him: why had Nikki been willing to indulge his fantasy? Especially if she hadn't entirely understood it, especially if she had been unsure about it bringing them closer.

He knew the answer he wanted to hear, even if he wouldn't have been able to turn it into an elegant sentence. He wanted to hear that she did it out of love for him, to turn him on, to give him what he wanted.

He also knew the answer he feared, and wanted to hear in a perverse, destructive way - a way that would confirm his suspicions and doubts about Nikki, a way that would settle, for once and for all, in a believable way, the mysteries of the "why" to Nikki's behavior. He feared - and this fear had lived beneath his skin throughout their marriage - that Nikki knew he wasn't good enough for her, and so she had finally seen an opportunity to go after something better.

Back in the here and now, Nikki was moving his fingertips over her lips, smiling, her thoughts turned inward. "I have to be honest," she said. "I don't think I would have done it if it hadn't played out the way it did."

Jack inhaled, his chest getting cool with raw excitement again. "The way it did...?" he prompted.

"Yeah, like... if you hadn't *been* there, or if Tony hadn't talked me into it at the bar the way he did..." She scrunched up her nose and tipped her head bashfully to cover her face. "I was planning on just *pretending* that I tried it, actually, and then telling you I chickened out." Nikki grinned. "But not even actually trying."

"Seriously?"

Nikki nodded, and then looked up from her tipped crunch into his chest, her eyes wide and alluring. "But then... you were there, and at first I was really shocked, and if I hadn't have run into Tony, I was going to go up there to your room and like... I don't know. Bust you or something."

"*Bust* me?" Jack laughed, incredulous.

Nikki made her fingers into guns and said, endearingly, "Pew-pew."

Then she laughed. "Not - okay, not *bust* you. But I was going to be like, hey, what the hell are you doing? I was actually sort of glad, I thought it was a... like you were planning to surprise me. And I really thought it'd be... I don't know. Until I was in the bar, and Tony was talking me into doing it, I really thought, still, it was kind of a pretend adventure. You know? Like, we were acting it out, up to the line, but both of us were kind of chickening out."

Jack was intrigued. This was exactly what he had been dying to know - and they were the kind of details he hadn't really believed he would get out of Nikki. "So... what did Tony say to turn the tide? That I didn't say?" He added hastily: "Just for future reference"

Nikki looked at him and grinned sheepishly. "You know Tony kind of like, does this? This... what is it called? Bull thing."

"I *had* guessed something like that."

Nikki giggled, stroking his fingers nervously, She wormed her way to his chest, so that when she spoke her breath tickled his skin. "He just... God, I don't know how he said it exactly. He just painted it like:" Nikki launched into a ham-fisted impression of Tony, using a booming, low voice and an exaggerated black accent, "Your man's just makin' sure you're having a good time, but he wants to watch it, it turns him on, so everybody wins..." She broke with the accent. "I should be happy you're letting me have an adventure... you know, stuff like that." Nikki laughed at herself. "Okay, I did a really bad job telling the story. I don't know exactly how he said it. It was kind of hypnotizing. To be honest."

Jack could understand that. Tony had a hypnotic power.

But Nikki's enthusiasm did not come across as tentative as all that.

"I guess after that," Nikki said, almost as if Jack had asked her a question out loud, a question getting at exactly what he wanted to know. "Once things got going, I just... like I said, I *liked* it. I liked being the center of attention like that. Being... you know.... slutty." Her voice got low, and a warm, inviting light came into her eyes. "I like the way it seemed like it was making you feel." Her voice dropped to a whisper. "I liked you watching."

"Careful," Jack growled, moving his hips closer to hers so she could feel the power of her words, the way they made him hard.

"Like that," Nikki whispered, without taking her eyes off him. "I like that you're looking at me like that."

Jack rolled onto Nikki, his hands working their way up her body, kissing, scarcely believing he might actually be able to pull off yet another tryst. "You like that, huh?"

Nikki moved her head in a nod, her eyes slowly being consumed by lust.

"You want more of that?" His fingers were moving down, working their way into her folds, pulling her panties away from her body, not caring if they ripped or even came completely off. He moved them enough to slip his cock inside her, feel her body ripple and twist this way and that to accommodate him, her interior sore and used. "Because I do."

He moved his hand along her arms, pinning them loosely above her head, stroking the underside of her upper arm until he felt the tickle make her convulse around him as she giggled and tried to move her skin from his touch. He dragged his stubbled jaw over her inner arms, across her face, and let her body convulse around his cock and beneath him, hot, wet, and quivering.

The sounds that Nikki made as she squirmed beneath his body, each time his cock grazed some sore patch of skin or he started to move too fast in her abused pussy, were sweet and so sexy that he knew they would echo in his ears forever. He had to fuck her very slowly, his own cock aching and his desire burning even hotter with each languid stroke. The final few minutes of gentle fucking, as Nikki whimpered and shuddered with her own orgasm, were the most tortured and insanely hot of his life: slowly and painstakingly fucking his used-up wife, her pussy so wet he glided through it like it was a fleshy tube of lubrication. His orgasm built up so slowly he thought it might never come, and yet with such urgency he thought he might go blind from the screeching pain of its suppression.

It was only after he came, again, and they lay exhausted in the bed, that Jack's elation started to dilute, and dark thoughts began creeping again into his head.

The depravity of his desires was one thing, a thing he had learned to deal with, back when they were no more than desires.

But Nikki acting out those desires – those depraved and filthy ideas, Tony's depraved and filthy ideas, some of her own apparent perversions – that was a different psychological beast entirely. His heart rate was fast, keeping him wide-awake, as he flipped through the images of the preceding evenings with Nikki asleep next to him, aroused and surrounded by slow-creeping vines of horror and possibility.

Because in all their talk, one thing was implicit and needed no discussion: if Tony summoned Nikki again, she would answer the call. And Jack would want her to.

Even if he also feared it.

CHAPTER 6

Nikki leaned provocatively against the counter in her pre-shift getup, which was her usual fare and the standby of all the firefighters and paramedics at the AESB: jeans and a shirt of some kind.

It was in this arrival-at-shift outfit that a lot of information was transmitted: low-cut, tight-fitting shirts in bright colors like red on the ladies meant they intended to hit the bars after work; something more formal meant they had a PTA meeting or a financial adviser looming at the end of shift. The old timers, always men, usually skated close to and over the edges of the dress code with paint or concrete- splattered work clothes, according to their side business jobs.

Nikki was usually somewhere in the middle; a regular t-shirt, a tidy outerwear jacket that said: I'm going to pick my kids up or maybe hit the gym after this.

Everyone, universally, received a round of jeers if they wore something outside their norm: Angie had showed up once in a dress after coming straight from picking her mother up from the airport, an event for which she had donned a skirt for her conservative-minded mother (Angie introduced her as Mrs. Borelli, but referenced her as June Cleaver).

Angie had arrived in the skirt at the base almost two years ago, but the aftermath was still ongoing and slow-moving: her locker had been plastered with Hello Kitty stickers and sometimes she showed up at the bar - still, after years - wearing a tiara that kept floating in and out of her bunker gear. There was a tall tale forming in the annals of firefighter oral history - which operated a lot like war stories and fishing trips, in that the details only grew

more detailed and less accurate with every retelling - that she had led an attack team with the tiara still on her helmet. The story was of course bullshit for a million reasons (Accountability would obviously have ripped it off, even it had somehow survived getting put on her head in a hurry and the faceshield being lowered before entry, just to start), but woe betide anyone who wanted to nitpick a fun firefighter story like that.

Angie was also too bawdy, boozy, and fiery for the attempted nickname "Princess" to stick.

"It's unfortunate!" Angie had screamed, despite it not being very loud, to Jack across the table one night at the bar. "I really kinda liked that nickname! But it didn't stick because -"

" - you're too much of a fuckin' broad!" Hands had finished for her.

"*You're* the fuckin' broad," Angie had shot back. Then, in a confiding tone despite the volume, Angie had explained, pointing with a huge, sloshing two-pinter of beer in his direction: "*Because*: the fuckin' probie looks just like Meghan Markle in a hazmat suit!" Philosophically drinking from her enormous mug, she lamented: "Can't win 'em all."

Nikki was tempting fate, as such, wearing a red top - not *the* red top, but a tight-fitting new one with a low plunge that hugged her figure beautifully - and tight jeans, along with a pair of non-practical shoes with a heel that committed her to no particular activity after work, but definitely leaned into the "hot date" category. Her makeup was sparing, as always, but enhanced enough that it would surely get noticed.

It was seven am, and Nikki was holding a cup of coffee in one hand. The scene was surreal: Nikki's slightly-enhanced appearance was clearly the result of what had happened with Tony, and it broadcast - to Jack, at least -

the unstated hope that she would need such an outfit upon leaving shift. With no time to come home and change.

And the only unstated thing to hope for, that she needed to look hot for, was *Tony*.

And Nikki cared more about nurturing that hope, or having a hot outfit for Tony, than she did about getting razzed for it by the crew.

"Hmm," Jack said, sliding his hands around her waist and nuzzling the back of her neck. "This is a pretty daring outfit to wear to work."

Nikki grinned, turning her head slightly toward him. "You know what they say," she said, moving her hands to pour some cream in her coffee, but doing so in a way that was so saturated with sexiness it made Jack's head spin. "Always be prepared."

"Are you prepared for all the shit they're going to give you?" Jack asked, turning to lean against the counter and look at Nikki, who continued smiling and pouring.

She turned to him, her tongue running absently along her teeth as she grinned widely. "They won't *notice*."

"Hmm," Jack said, to this obvious untruth, as Nikki handed him the coffee mug. "This for me?"

Nikki smiled. "I'm off the cream." She turned toward the counter with the coffee maker, the double *entendre* evidently right over her head - nothing new about that, Nikki, like any woman, blew past all but the most obvious sexual references. But she paused mid-stride to turn her head over her shoulder, meet his eyes, wink (which she wasn't very good at) and say, "*That* cream, anyway."

Jack's eyebrows shot up. Other than that, he didn't have much of a reaction: maybe it was a fantasy of his, and he had to believe of any man, that his wife would finally start taking as deep, varied, and constant of an interest in sex as he did, and start inserting it willy-nilly into jokes and references all the time.

The reality of that fantasy was much more disorienting. He wasn't sure what it made him feel, but the idea of his hands slipping on something he was trying to hold onto surfaced constantly in his mind around this new version of Nikki.

She poured a coffee into a travel mug and turned back to him, leaning provocatively on the other counter. "So... what now?"

Her lips were closed but pursed in a provocative smirk, and something was different in the way she was standing. Jack lifted the mug, smiling and amused, provoked and feeling a tingle in his groin, wary, all at the same time. "Uh... you have shift?" he asked, but with a bit of whimsy to leave the door open for the question she was really asking - he hoped - to unfold.

Nikki looked back at him, amused. "What now about *Tony*?" she asked.

The temperature in the room seemed to rise suddenly, and the cool ache of desire throbbed in his chest. "What about Tony?" he prompted, trying not to sound too eager, or too overjoyed that Tony was on Nikki's mind at seven am on a Tuesday.

Nikki stalked sexily toward the island, where Jack was standing, and leaned on her elbows, her fingers playing with the travel mug, tracing sexual designs all over its surface. She watched her own fingers, smiling. "Well, what about if... Tony calls. Me. And wants to... you know. Hook up?"

Jack looked at his wife over the top of his coffee mug. It disturbed him a little that the first person - other than Tony, or his wife - that he thought about because of this question was Mike. He let a brief vignette play out in his head, in which he told Mike the whole, lengthy, wet, wild story. It flashed through his head, ending with Mike being wheeled away on a gurney after going into AFib.

"What to do if Tony calls you?" Jack mused, watching Nikki as he spoke. She squirmed a little, and her cheeks flushed beneath her foundation, splotchy and bright. "Hmm."

"Hmm," Nikki repeated, eyes glittering.

Jack leaned on the island, also on his elbows, and stretched his fingers out Nikki's, brushing over the tips playfully before selecting her ring finger and using two fingers to stroke it sensually from the webbing to the tip. "Why would Tony be calling you, you think?"

Their eyes met, and the air seemed to shimmer with the heat in the room.

Nikki leaned her head toward one shoulder and moved her fingers. "Maybe to go out for a drink..." she began, drawing the words out slowly. "Maybe something more..."

Jack growled.

"So. What do I do?" Nikki asked, her face suddenly a picture of innocence - believable, raw guilelessness. It cleaved him in the chest, because it was so believable, and yet Nikki had beamed it at him so transparently, almost as if she wanted him to see that she possessed this particular quality on tap. But why? He knew it was going to churn in his mind all day, maybe for the rest of his life: what was contained in that message, and how deliberately had

she done it? But he would return to that, like he always did with these questions - what his wife was like, really, privately in her own mind - later and alone.

He touched her fingertips again. "I thought we settled on... do what you *want* to do... as long as..."

"I *tell* you about it," Nikki murmured, also provocatively.

She stood up slowly and retracted her hand just as slowly, her eyes simmering with arousal and interest. She bit into her lower lip, and Jack knew this was definitely done for the exact reaction that it brought out in him: his cock throbbed to rigid life as her white, shiny teeth sank gently into her flesh. A hundred filthy images blitzed through his mind as he stared at her, heart beating loudly in his ears.

"Okay," she said. Then she moved her shoulders and hips to show off her outfit. "That's why I'm prepared." She grabbed the travel mug and hopped over to him, transforming back into her old self, kissing him happily on the cheek. "I better run," she said, before he could even reach for her, a desire to walk her back to the bedroom awakening in his muscles, moving his arms.

She squealed when he started toward her and wriggled easily away from his hands before he could grasp her. "I'm gonna be late!" she giggled, but like everything Nikki did now, post-Tony, her body left all kinds of bait in its wake as she skipped away, and Jack was left with the impression that Nikki wouldn't mount a full-force objection to his desires.

He started to round the island, walking after her, but Nikki grabbed her bag and picked up the pace. "Seriously. I gotta have a clean record, reviews are

in a month... I'll text you. I love you..." she stopped, leaned in with her torso far from him, and blew him a kiss, before scurrying out the door.

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Tony didn't call Nikki immediately to service that shift, or even the next. But Nikki wasn't one to get down at the mouth about something like that, and whatever Tony had done – even if they never saw him again – he had definitely reactivated her libido.

She returned from shift very tired and quite late, shrugging with disappointment at Jack as she came into the kitchen. She snapped into full-mom mode so easily that Jack almost wondered if she wasn't actually relieved to be back home instead of out with Tony, and a process of doubt started up again: maybe he was asking too much of her, letting Tony get away with too much. Maybe he should talk to her about it again.

These thoughts were on his mind, heavy, brooding, as he made dinner and Nikki sat at the table with the kids – not a frequent occurrence, and everyone was at fault for that – genuinely, it seemed, listening, to their adolescent tales of woe and homework and assholes at school.

They disappeared right after eating, called away to a private place by a barrage of texts from their friends. Jack was doing the dishes, and had actually resigned himself to a not-very-adventurous night, since Nikki was being such a biblical Madonna up until then.

But as soon as both doors to the kids' rooms had closed upstairs and the familiar silence of their headphoned existences had set in, she popped out of her seat and walked over to him, twisting her hips invitingly.

He was frozen for a second, only by shock. Nikki bit her lip, obviously thinking he needed her intentions underlined.

But he didn't. The way Nikki was walking, hips forward a little, chest pushed out, fingers lingering on the backs of chairs, the counter, her own neck, as she walked, reminding him that she had fingers that liked to caress things, and a mouth that liked to open.

“Just because *Tony* didn't call me,” she said, in a teasing voice, “doesn't mean I don't want a sore pussy.”

Jack was momentarily frozen. Then he slapped the dishtowel down and seized his wife, taking her back to the bedroom.

A man's gotta do what a man's gotta do, he decided.

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Things went along like this for quite awhile. Since, and in spite of the fact that, Nikki worked 48-hour shifts (that more often than not, ended up being 52, or 60 hours), she never tired of stirring up sex with Jack when she got home.

He wasn't complaining. She was insatiable now, and there was no denying that Tony was at the center of the cause of it. Her method of foreplay almost always involved recasting something Tony had ordered her to do back at the hotel as something she wanted Jack to do to her – only it was much more tame than that in the actual bedroom. Jack, for instance, wasn't going to actually “fuck her ass raw,” but he didn't mind her *saying* that's what she wanted just before plunging her hand into his boxers and gripping his cock fiercely while he was sorting through the mail.

The sex was hot. But he had two things still nagging at him: a lust to have it happen all again, and a gnawing fear that Nikki had become hooked on *Tony*. That even while she was fucking him and looking right at him, she was actually looking through him and thinking of Tony. That when his cock was inside her, she was lamenting that he wasn't as big as Tony, not filling her as much. That she wanted him to push her face into the mattress and lick it while he rammed her ass, which was all stuff he really just *couldn't* do to her. What if she asked for it? What if he was never able to actually satisfy her, ever again?

And what if Tony never called her up again?

This went on for many weeks, until finally one night Nikki started the same routine – suggestively strutting into the office in her yoga pants and sliding her hands from his shoulders to his chest, licking his earlobe, about to whisper some Tony-themed activity in his ear.

So it took a few seconds after she said it for it to actually register:

“Tony wants me to come to his place tonight,” she said, her fingers traveling down between his legs and finding the shape of his cock as it rose to attention. He could feel her smile against his ear and his neck, see the shape of her mouth reflected in the screen that he kept his eyes fixed on. His heart plunged through his feet and then back again, swelling in rapid, hot throbs that once again felt mildly dangerous to him. He opened his mouth and started to turn his head, but Nikki wasn't done just yet.

“I wasn't actually that late getting off shift,” she whispered, and then she waited, leaving him in a torturous, sexual purgatory for a few delicious moments while his mind ran wild, filling in the vast blank she had left for him with possibilities and filth.

“He sent me to the store for something,” Nikki breathed into his ear at last.

“What?” Jack struggled to even say this single word. He couldn’t have hidden his rampant, animal, unseemly lust if he had wanted to, so he didn’t try.

“He wants me to wear it over there,” Nikki whispered. She left this in the air, while Jack imagined pretty lingerie, slutty lingerie, stockings with lace bands that clung to her hips.

But then she breathed: “And I want *you* to put it in me.”

Jack rotated slowly in his chair, while Nikki backed away grinning, leaving her hand on his neck until the last minute, when it slid away and swung back to her hip as she turned, grinning, and headed to the bedroom.

It was eight pm on a Tuesday.

He pondered what he had just heard in a frenzy. On? Or in? Nikki wanted him to put it on her or in her? Which had he heard?

When he reached the bedroom, already pulling his shirt off, Nikki was already on the bed, curled up like a vixen, dressed in a black panty and bra set that matched and were also scandalously hot. The material covering her breasts and, presumably, her mound, was transparent. A fine black mesh that hid nothing very well, only cast a gauzy hint of anticipation over the skin it covered. Thick black embroidery was hemmed to the edges of the pieces, framing the shape of her breasts and the curve of her hips. Black, knotted embroidery that matched wrapped around her thighs, holding up nude stockings.

Nikki hadn’t worn a getup like this since their honeymoon.

So she had said “on,” Jack thought, closing the door with his foot and reaching for his belt.

Nikki smiled and shook her head, sticking her tongue between her teeth and biting it gently. “Tony said *no* touching,” she said. “So I’m sort of breaking the rules...” she slipped a hand under the pillow and pulled out an object that for a moment didn’t register at all with Jack: it was long, seemed like medical device, and was made of silicone, formed into beads linked together by a silicone chain -

“Is that what I think it is?” he stammered.

Nikki waved it like a whip, holding the largest bead and flinging the others to her thigh, where they emitted a sharp slap. Then she blushed. “I am *so* not ready for this yet,” she said, laughing, and slipped her hand under the pillow again. “Anyway, I just bought it... because I was there. *This* is actually what I want you to put in me...”

She held up a very slender butt plug. While not the same grotesquely pleasing filth as the anal beads, it still made Jack’s cock jump in his pants, which he was reaching for the waist of as he tried to wrangle his thoughts into some semblance of coherence.

Who was this woman? Nikki didn’t go shopping for sex toys, picking up something extra “just because.” Sex toys usually inspired her to laugh or comment on how such an item could go terribly awry if used improperly, something she knew for a fact because she had been called to transport the aftermath of just such misuse.

Now she was talking about them, talking about *using* them...

Nikki's eyes dropped to his hands and she looked like she was about to say something. But Jack cut her off. "*Don't* tell me what Tony told you," he said. He hooked a finger and beckoned her. "Come over here. Let me help you with that. But if I want to fuck my own wife before Tony gets his hands on you, that's what I'm gonna do."

Nikki liked this. And as the pleasure of his words spread over her face, it made him even harder. She shifted to her other hip, crawling forward, her eyes filled with mischief. But she also looked impressed.

She rose up on her knees when she reached the edge of the bed, and put her hands on her body, moving them over her breasts and her hips, undulating sexily. "But it took me so long to get into all this stuff," she said, and Jack couldn't even tell how serious she was. She hooked a finger under her bra strap and ran it beneath it, letting it slide from her shoulder after she released it.

"And I have to leave *very* soon," she continued. She was moving the butt plug down her ribcage now, sensually drawing it over hip. Jack knew her eyes were on his, watching how she drew his attention away from her face to what she was doing. She put the plug into Jack's hand, folding his fingers over it, and then turned to get on her hands and knees.

It was only then that Jack noticed that she was wearing heels, and it struck him as so absurd that he hadn't noticed them before that he almost did a double take. They were three inch heels, impractical and sexy as fuck, and his attention was drawn to them because Nikki kicked her feet up and stretched forward, arching her back and looking behind her. Then she pushed her ass back and lowered her chest with her arms stretched out in front of her, heels still kicked up high.

She sat like this as Jack stared openly, unable to recognize the woman on his own bed. She reached back with both hands, finally, and slipped the underwear from her hips, pulling it down to just below her ass. The material rolled up as she pulled it, peeling away from her mound to reveal her freshly-shaved pussy, only wisps of her hair trimmed neatly from her landing strip to her taint, her red gorge peeking from behind her porcelain skin, shining with her excitement. Above her slit, her eyelet was squeezed shut, wrinkled and fresh as if Tony's thick mass had never pummeled into her.

Jack's hand had gone to his own cock and he held it, aching, in one hand as he stood with the butt plug in the other, his fingers slowly rotating it as he decided what to do: risk Tony's wrath and fuck his wife before sending her over there? Or enjoy the tease?

Nikki made the decision in the end. "You can't have me before I go," she told him, and her eyes watched the reaction of his cock. Almost like she was testing a hypothesis, she raised an eyebrow and spoke, sounding like a kid trying something out for the first time. "You can't even... lick... my pussy."

Jack's cock, surging with a throb of lust, told her all she needed to know about her experiment, and Nikki met his eyes before turning her head again with a smile on her lips. She jutted her ass back and purred: "Hurry up, put it in me, I still have to do my makeup."

Jack leaned onto the edge of the bed on his knees, staring at Nikki's ass. Her heels bobbed and swayed as he shifted his weight onto the bed, but she otherwise was motionless, her ass shoved toward him, her panties stretched between her legs and rolled up into a rope of lace with vague hints of bondage as a result.

Still thinking, weighing his options. He had been dead-set on fucking Nikki, only a minute ago, but her obvious pleasure at telling him he couldn't even lick her pussy was hot, and it had him intrigued, fantasizing about doing exactly what she said - not for Tony, but for *her*.

He placed the tip of the plug at the weeping entrance to her pussy, dipped it in, and then moved it, drawing her juices along her taint and up to her ass. He twisted the small phallus at her eyelet for a moment, swirling it clockwise and then counter-clockwise. It rolled easily in her slick juices.

Nikki purred and pushed her ass back toward him, laying her head on the bed and stretching her arms out again.

Jack was overcome by something, and seized her thighs. He moved so quickly that Nikki didn't have time to react before his tongue was worming its way into her puckered asshole.

He had done this before, on other girls and once, when they were very drunk, on Nikki. The familiar metallic taste rose into his nostrils, and the hard rubbery ring of her anus pushed against him until it gave way to the superheated silk of her ass. He channeled his spit to his plunging tongue, rewarded by Nikki's squirming and mewling, but no resistance.

He entertained himself with this for quite a while, and then, not at all satisfied but enjoying the ache of his longing, he dipped the plug one more time into her pussy and plunged it into her ass, making her gasp.

Brushing his fingers through her swollen pussy lips, he rolled her panties back up and over her hips, arranging them neatly and then stroking her butt. He kissed her right butt cheek and ran a hand down her thigh.

“There you go,” he breathed against her skin, making goosebumps rise over her flank. “All ready for Tony.”

Nikki purred in pleasure tinted with disappointment, and it went to his head just like booze. She squirmed invitingly, looking over her shoulder as though daring him. It took an enormous amount of self-control - or self-abnegation, choose your adjective - to back himself off the edge of the bed. He held his cock in his hand and absently stroked it. "Fuck, Nikki. That's so fucking hot," he told her, hearing the words leaving his mouth before he'd even thought them.

Nikki flopped over to sitting and looked at him, seeing, he thought, that she wasn't going to trick him into fucking her. If that was what she really wanted, which he wasn't 100% about. She moved her hands over the bed, fluttering her eyes, and then she grinned. "Okay," she said, hopping up. "Get out of here, I have to put my makeup on."

She stood up and adjusted her panties, tugged at her thigh-highs, and, walking around Jack, trailed her fingers over his lower back and up to his shoulder as she headed to the bathroom.

Jack watched her from where he was standing as she took out her makeup and began applying it. Her eyes wandered to his face in the reflection, and a sensual smile turned her lips up before she went back to doing what she was doing.

He moved to the side of the bed, facing the en-suite, and watched her. He kicked off his pants and left his boxers at his knees, his cock hard and pointed at the ceiling between his legs. Nikki's eyes shifted to his dick and lingered there while she smiled, holding a tube of lipstick in her hand.

And then, pointedly, she leaned in toward the mirror with her mouth open and held the lipstick next to her upper lip, glancing one last time at Jack's reflection, at his hand stroking his cock. Her eyes glinted and her open mouth turned into a smile as she emitted a light, pleasurable laugh and started to smear red color on her lips.

She had to know, Jack figured, that she was bringing the video and her morning blow-job for Tony, to the forefront of his mind. That she was leaning over the counter with her butt-plugged ass jutting at him, framed in black lace, and smearing lipstick on her mouth while he thought of all the things she'd done already and would soon do again to Tony with that red-flavored mouth. She also didn't seem to care - in fact, she seemed to want him to - that he was blatantly masturbating to the whole sordid scene.

She *wanted* him to.

Nikki finished applying her lipstick and then looked at him again in the mirror, meeting his eyes. He was breathing heavily by then, his hand on his cock making the very singular and obvious sound of a chicken being choked. It was vulgar, filthy, and voyeuristic - the kind of thing he would have hidden from her, even as a thought, just a month ago, let alone doing it specifically so she could *see*, much less getting off on her watching him.

And he was getting off on it. Nikki tipped her head and let her mouth hang open a little, twisting the lipstick in her fingers and dragging it over her lip less to apply it than to give him the visual. Her expression was not disdainful, but rather interested, fascinated even - as though she truly never had a clue in her entire life that she could get a man to jerk off to her putting lipstick on.

The moment was hot with a jagged edge of terror: something conscious and empowered was taking shape in Nikki's head, and Jack really didn't have any idea what she would do with that power.

His orgasm was the kind of violent but unsatisfying orgasm a man gets from jerking off, and it spilled onto his hand but left his dick still at the ready. Nikki smiled, and then, as if nothing had happened at all, like she had chosen that moment for no other reason than that she was done putting her makeup on, she capped the tube and dropped it into her makeup bag. Then she pressed her lips together and posed for herself in the mirror, primping her loose hair a little, before zipping the bag up.

"Time to go," she said, walking past Jack and toward the closet.

He straightened himself off, tugging a shirt from the hamper to wipe himself off and feeling a bizarre rush when he saw that it said APD on it. He applied the crest right to his dick. It was adolescent and asinine, but he enjoyed it.

He was straightening out his boxers when Nikki appeared in her wear-to-everything black dress, which was designed like a big black shirt, with buttons all the way down and a thick matching belt that ratcheted the shape to her figure. It was made of a silky material that clung to her body and made the smallest curves swell in pleasant valleys of shadows and rounded peaks of shiny fabric.

It was a cute dress, acceptable at almost any function Nikki would ever be at - funeral, low-key cocktail party, holiday crap. She sometimes put a different colored belt on it to spice it up for something, but tonight she was all-business.

This all to say, it wasn't the *hottest* dress in the world, but it came across that way now, now that Jack knew all that was beneath it, and where all that was going this evening. Nikki had left the top three buttons open - zero was for funerals, one for holidays, and two for cocktail parties.

Three open buttons was scandalous. The rise of her breasts, the firm shape of them, was exposed and gloriously snatched away with every movement of her body.

"How do I look?" she asked Jack, posing with a hand on her hip.

Jack was staring openly at her.

"So hot," he managed to say.

Nikki stepped toward him like she was going to kiss him, but then swayed back, pressing her lips together and pointing at them. She touched him on the chest instead, drawing her hand down his stomach and over his boxers, turning as she did this. "Okay... I'm taking a cab," she said. She walked to the door. "Don't wait up for me. But *do* keep your phone on."

"My phone is always on and I will be staring at it all night."

A smile. A salacious, sexy smile.

And then she was gone.

CHAPTER 7

He didn't know what to do with himself. It set in almost immediately: a high-pitched wail deep inside his psyche, reverberating in his limbs. The long-forgotten feel of a surge of testosterone, channeling all his energy into his cock and making the most primordial and filthy of thoughts seep through every crack in his mind until he felt like an animal, like he was eighteen again.

But Nikki was out with Tony. She was out with Tony in her black dress with all the buttons down, and Tony was the one who would have his cock in her pussy, her lips on his balls, her sleepy eyes staring up at him as he twisted and turned her body, fucking her until she was a pile of wet, limp flesh.

He was glad that he had confided in Nikki about how much he liked the burn of her teasing, however surprised - and a little frightened, being honest - he was that she was so *good* at it.

So good at it.

Was it Tony's instruction, Tony's experience, that led Nikki to her uncanny abilities? Or was the raw material always in there, waiting to get out?

This new permutation of their relationship - Nikki going *to* Tony, doing what Tony wanted, being alone with Tony - made him uneasy. He didn't know why: there was nothing Tony could physically do to Nikki at this point that really *exceeded* everything he'd done so far, at least as far as intimacy or filth went.

His worry was less about that and more about the spell Tony might cast on her, once he had Nikki to himself. Was he going to ply her with drinks and

libido-inducing foods? Or get right to manhandling her, fucking her until she couldn't see straight, making her lick his balls until she fell asleep?

And then, beneath all that, a current of inferiority: sure, Nikki didn't *seem* to be obsessed with Tony's cock; she and Jack had made love even more than usual in the interim weeks. But was that because Nikki was lusty and deprived, and would take what she could get - thinking about Tony's fatter, longer member while she fucked Jack?

Tony told me to tell you he's making sure I have a good meal ;)

This was sent as a plain text, and so it was momentarily disorienting. What was with the winkey-face? Was this a reference to her eating his cock, getting fed a load of cum as soon as she showed up at his place? Or was it actually about food?

But a photo came about five minutes later.

Nikki was still in her black dress, her makeup still in place. Her face was flushed. A wine glass was on the table, half drained, red smears on the rim. A bowl of strawberries half in the picture, a plate of oyster shells in front of Nikki, their slimy, sexual meat sucked from them, the empty husks haunting the image, implicating Nikki's mouth in a wet, slurping vignette that Jack barely had to conjure to feel he had actually seen with his own two eyes.

Her hand was on her décolletage, a smile on her lips, mischief in her eyes.

Mischief for whom? For herself, about to do something very nasty with her big, black CO? For Tony himself, because Jack knew he couldn't be the only one of Nikki's lovers to question who was in control in this situation - even as Tony barked orders at her and she obeyed, it all seemed to have flowed through Nikki first.

Or was the mischief for Jack? Was she thinking of how she would tease him, dole out the details of this unseen tryst, making him beg her for more?

He thought about all this without even thinking once of her butt plug, so when he did, it hit him fully, like a belly-flop from a very tall cliff. His wife was sitting there with Tony, squirming in her seat with a butt-plug in her ass – that she had almost certainly told Tony about – and slurping oysters from the shell for him.

Nikki didn't send him anything else for a while, and Jack fumed silently – first in the office, then in the bedroom, then in the kitchen while he made himself a drink, which for the first time in a long time he really felt he *needed*: he had to pour something on the emotions roiling in his body.

Finally, empowered by a painful hard-on and a few snifters of whiskey, he had a talk with his own reflection in the mirror.

“There's no reason you can't send *her* a message.”

And there really wasn't. Tony had never said anything about that, and neither had Nikki. And this was, after all, *his wife*. A now-familiar surge of intense jealousy flared in his chest, and it squeezed something into his veins. Maybe adrenaline. Whatever it was, Jack picked up the phone and typed confidently, almost confrontationally:

What are you doing now?

The message sent, he indulged in a micro-fantasy: picturing Nikki, her mouth on Tony's cock, glancing over at a phone on a night table, shifting her eyes back to Tony's after reading Jack's name, a smile at the corners of her stretched lips.

Or were they in the car? Or still at the restaurant, eating more oysters?

But Nikki came through, almost immediately:

going to Tony's

I have an idea for setting up video so answer my call

Time out: 2130 hrs.

*

The call from Nikki came almost an hour later. Jack was ready, dry-mouthed, partially manic, sweaty on his back and scalp, phone held so tightly in one hand that a minor ache was developing in his grip. His cock was hard and painful, but he hadn't wanted to start something that might distract him from answering the phone: if Nikki really was going to try a video call, he doubted she'd keep trying if he failed to answer her first call.

She looked into the camera, silently, and smiled. Then a blur of moving light and shadow as she did something with the phone without turning it off. The picture stabilized into blackness with a hint of light, and then, after a bit of blurring, Nikki's chest and then her face dropped into the frame. She smiled again.

A sliver of red lipstick clung to her lower lip, but her lips were primarily the pink of her natural flesh, distended and used. Her hair wasn't disheveled, but neither was it the same neat look she had departed with. Nikki, quite clearly, had at least been making out with Tony.

But probably more.

Nikki adjusted the phone, leaning into the camera so that Jack got a nice view of her tits peeking out from the slipping front of her dress. "Okay," she said, in a breathy voice. "All set." She dropped her eyes to the camera.

“I muted you,” she said quietly. And then she mouthed: “I love you,” puckered her lips for an air-kiss, and stood up, turning around, so that all Jack could see was the back of her dress, the vague outline of her ass, and the yellow-green walls of what was presumably Tony’s apartment.

Music started up, low and inaudible, except for a persistent sexiness drumming through the beat. Shadows moved on the green walls, and Nikki’s silky dress shifted and moved forward, away from the camera.

Toward Tony.

She stopped, and Jack heard the low rumble of Tony’s voice. A few moments of what seemed like nothing, but the black silk seemed to rupture at the shoulders, Nikki’s pale skin bursting out of it, and then it started to slink down her body, catching on her curves briefly before slipping to the floor.

The way Nikki’s new underwear framed her buttocks perfectly, the thong nestled in her crack, her firm buttocks two full spheres on either side of the lace.

A rumble from Tony, and Nikki began to turn around, posing for him when she was facing the camera. Tony’s voice again, and Nikki began to move forward, slowly, until at the edges of her body the full picture of Tony’s room came into view: he was leaning on the edge of dresser, sipping a drink. The bed was to the left, neatly made, conspicuously bachelor-like in its appearance: plain black duvet cover, two pillows with matching cases, nothing on the walls to clash with.

Nikki approached him, strutting a little, and when she was within reach, Tony’s dark hands appeared, palming her buttocks after working their way smoothly up from her knees. His voice was rumbling again, even less

audible than before, and Nikki giggled, tossing her hair, letting herself be pulled roughly toward Tony. He turned her around and made her sit on his knee, which she did awkwardly at first but then relaxed into as Tony used the back of his hand to stroke her from the cheek down to her left breast, his eyes on her face, his lips moving. Only the faintest rumble reached Jack's ears: he was drowned out by the soft music.

Tony tugged at the strap of Nikki's bra after playing with the material for a bit, a pleased look on his face. He flicked the strap down her shoulder, pulled at the material, and then plunged his face into Nikki's chest as if he was suddenly overcome by a gnawing hunger. Nikki tipped her head back and emitted a sharp squeal that pierced through the music and made Jack's stomach drop through his feet, but the wide-open smile on her face reassured him that she wasn't actually hurt.

No, Nikki was not hurt, she enjoying Tony biting her nipple through her meager bra.

Tony chewed on Nikki's breasts for a bit, making her squirm some more, while Nikki's left hand dropped to his crotch and felt for his dick. Jack couldn't see the details in the dim light, only the stark white of Nikki's hand, moving up and down some indiscernible object that Jack knew to be Tony's dick.

In his mind, the whiny purr of Nikki's voice as she complained that her pussy was too sore rose to his consciousness, surfacing as a memory so visceral that he felt like he actually heard it.

Tony seized her and stood up, wrapping Nikki around himself – for that was really how it happened: Nikki held on to his neck but it was Tony who moved his hands to her legs and physically pulled them around his torso,

before moving them right back to Nikki's ass, which he held like two bowling balls, once in each palm, as he walked them to the bed.

He tossed Nikki onto the bed, and Jack was disappointed to see that he was only going to get a partial view at this angle. A pang of desire: the desire to see Nikki's face, her eyes glued to his own, her head dragging back and forth on the mattress as Tony hammered her.

Tony, though, was playing with Nikki, almost the way a cat would play with its prey. He stared down at her and swiped at the parts of her body he wanted to feel, or hold in place to look at, or caress. He tossed Nikki's legs open – first one, then the other – like she was, in fact, a mere mannequin.

He stroked his own dick for a moment after he arranged her like this, smiling.

He climbed onto the bed, one knee at a time, controlling Nikki now not with words but with his eyes. Nikki's body squirmed on the bed, but only a little – only as much, Jack figured, as Tony allowed.

Tony seized her right thigh with one hand, and while Jack couldn't actually see it from the angle he was consigned to, he knew that Tony's enormous paw wrapped easily around Nikki's thin thigh – however muscle-thickened it was.

He pushed Nikki's thigh up and open wider, just before doing the same thing to the opposite thigh. He lifted a knee to lay it on one leg while he freed his hand to reach between her legs, hovering over her body, pinning her in place.

He lifted the material of Nikki's panties, his low voice rumbling unintelligibly, and ran his fingers beneath the taut fabric, before letting it

snap back against Nikki's mound. He contorted his body to bend over her torso and lower his mouth between her legs.

Nikki's hand flew to his head, and her fingers dug at his non-existent hair, curling at nothing, as he worked his mouth between her legs in ways that Jack couldn't see, but heard the results of in the form of a panicky, panting squeal from Nikki. She slapped his head and attempted to writhe on the bed, to no avail.

It was as silly as anything could be, Nikki flailing against Tony: sure, she was fit, and feisty, but Tony had her pinned and her single flailing hand was almost laughable against his sheer size. Tony became annoyed by her hand when she slapped at his head, and grasped her wrist. All motion from Nikki ceased, but her hyperventilating loudly came through over the music, as well as the howls of disappointment when Tony (evidently) ceased licking her pussy before she was done.

"Tooo-ooo-oooo-nnnnn-yyyy," Nikki whined, when Tony – amused with himself, grinning – reared his head and rose back up to rest on his calves. "Please... Tony..."

Tony ignored her, even as she twisted her torso violently. His grip on her legs – his hand on her left leg and his knee on the right, were impervious to her flailing. Tony watched, letting her exhaust herself, his fingers hovering just above her pussy, one thumb hooked in her panties and pulling it tightly above her hips.

"Please Tony, please," Nikki begged, tossing her head side-to-side. Her eyes never left his cock, though, even as she protested that she couldn't take it a single second more.

Jack wet his lips and reached for his whiskey, aware, suddenly, that his mouth was excessively dry. He took a swig, his eyes glued to the screen, and prepared himself for the ice-hot blast of pain that would accompany Tony's dick sinking into Nikki's flesh. He could already hear her screaming in ecstasy in his mind.

Tony moved a hand to his dick after suddenly ripping the panties away with one unexpected and violent pull.

And then, just as Jack was getting ready to grab his own dick and jerk off to the next part -

the image on the screen seemed to warp for a moment, and then a flash of white – not light, but something else – a squeal from Nikki in the background, and then an opening to Tony holding Nikki by the ass, her ankles up by her ears, and Jack was readily absorbed and already forgetting the whole thing.

When a furry flash of white swung through the scene again, and the image warped and wobbled, before the screen blurred, and all went black.

The next hour was just sound: panting, wet slapping flesh, the murmur of indistinct dirty talk, Nikki's high-pitched screams and wails cutting through the low-fi music, a loud shout by Tony. The screen black, Jack unable to do anything but imagine what Tony was doing with his wife that made her scream like that.

He created a fantasy in his own mind and jerked off to it.

The phone cut off at some point, and that was all he got to see that night. He tried calling, but the phone rang and rang, and there was not much he could do about any of it except bask in the painful, erotic pleasure of it.

He slid his hand under his pillow when he reclined in bed, staring at his phone, contemplating his options, his mind going wild with jealous pain, when his fingers bumped into something.

It was a small box, the approximate size of a jar of expensive eye cream (or any of the costly little potion containers that Nikki told him not to touch – once, he had used some of this eye cream for a huge patch of dry skin on his hand, and Nikki had almost had an aneurysm about it. It was, evidently, hundreds of dollars an ounce).

He had a mild fear of boxes of cosmetic products of that size, for that reason, so he almost set it aside without pondering it any more than that – sure, it was weird, but Nikki was always doing weird shit when she went shopping, unpacking the bags and tossing things everywhere.

But when he pulled it out to set it on the night table and disregard it, he caught sight of a handwritten note, in Nikki's handwriting, on a tiny Post-it.

I'll need you to rub this in when I get home.

A series of x's and o's, and no signature, just an "N," were crammed into the remaining space.

Jack read the label:

Momotaro's Salve

He only made it to the first of the listed uses (vaginal tenderness) before his mind went wild with all-new fantasies, and his irritation at being cut off from the video was somewhat dampened by the prospect of tending to Nikki's assured vaginal tenderness with it while she filled him in on everything he'd missed.

*

Nikki texted him at ten am the next day, where he was at work, studiously staring at his screen to avoid eye contact with Mike. Mike, whose marbles had long ago rolled away on the floor for most things, did still have incredible instincts about anything remotely sexual in nature, and he had sniffed something out the moment Jack walked in the door.

“Guess what shit sandwich Air sent down here, good buddy?” he began, as Jack trudged through the door. It was Mike’s life mission, Jack had decided long ago, to ruin everyone’s day as quickly as he possibly could.

Mike had confirmed this. “My therapist says I do it to have company with me in my misery,” he said, jovial because he was at his most congenial when he was being a dick. (As to what Mike’s therapist was doing about this tendency, it was anybody’s guess, because Mike had been pulling this shit for years and didn’t seem interested in stopping).

Mike, as was his MO, looked up from his screen to see how this news would settle on Jack’s face. The vast majority of total bullshit came from Air Ambulance, so he was eagerly awaiting Jack’s annoyance.

But when he saw Jack’s face, his eyebrows shot up to the sky, his mouth froze wide-open, and then, after a thoughtful pause, he snapped his mouth shut into a shit-eating smirk and turned his eyes back on the screen.

And he had been smirking all morning long, his eyes occasionally darting over his screen to Jack, watching for a bit, and then moving back to his own screen. No doubt his grin was spreading slowly across his face, like a puddle of piss.

*Hi baby. I'm heading home after I take a shower. Tony let me sleep.
What happened with the phone? When I woke up it was on the table but
flipped over and it looks like only ten minutes of the call!!!! :(I dont
know what happened. Call me xoxoxoxo*

Jack didn't know what to write. He didn't *want* to write anything. A sharp pain knifed him in the stomach, his heart throbbed painfully, speeding up to sweat-inducing, and the ache of lust swamped all his senses except the sharp prick of Nikki's carefree words.

He wanted to go home, inspect his wife, pry the details out of her about last night. Rub the salve into her pussy, reclaim her by filling her up with his own cum. His cock was painfully hard.

Mike's eyes shifted over the screen again and his grin got so big it seemed to eat his whole face – Jack couldn't see below the middle of his nose, but his features were twisted in twisted amusement that affected the whole top half of his face.

“Good night, buddy? Or bad?” he chuckled.

Jack ignored him.

“Ehhhh,” Mike howled. “You can see it from here. I just can't tell which one it is.”

Jack's phone rumbled against his thigh, several times, but he waited a full ten minutes before taking his phone out and setting it on his desk. Three messages from Nikki, all of which he wanted desperately to see, but he didn't want Mike observing him as he did.

Mike's shifty eyes, though, proved no match for his lust, and so he broke after a mere twenty minutes, and swept the phone up to greedily read his

wife's messages.

I'm home

I see you found my present

I can't wait for you to come and use it on me

Jack exhaled loudly, just as another message came from Nikki.

I'm really, really sore

And just as he shuddered, another:

Can you come home early? Otherwise I'm going to have to do this all by myself...

From behind Mike's screen, a chuckle. He was shaking his head, which was tipped to look at something on his desk. He tipped it back up, his eyes moving on the computer screen, his finger clicking the mouse. He squinted, like he was really reading something – working, even – before he said, casually:

“Hey man, you having an *affair*?” He kept squinting at the screen, leaning in. “Because that is fucking *ridiculous*, man. Ridiculous. If you are fucking Nikki Hillier *and* some other piece of ass. You know?” Mike looked up at him over the screen, and his eyes crinkled with delight at Jack's expression. “You *can't* be getting that much quality pussy, man. You just... *can't*.”

Mike's eyes dropped to Jack's cell phone, and his jaw shifted in a rare display of uncertainty before he shook himself and laughed. “God, what am I saying?” he whispered, focusing on his computer again, leaning in, squinting. “You're a fucking... *dipstick* of a man.”

It was always tempting to shiv Mike with a nasty comment at a moment like this, because he really could be a shit. “At least I still have a wife, asshole,” was always at the tip of Jack’s (and probably, a few other people’s tongues). But guys like Mike, having cracked after seeing something so awful no one really knew for certain what it was (the default in emergency services was “microwaved baby,” but that was from the movies and everyone knew it – it was just code for “something just as, if not more, fucked-up than a microwaved baby”) got special treatment, and no one hit below the belt like that.

So Jack shook his head. “No affair.”

Mike nodded, smiling with his tongue pierced between his teeth, which meant he didn’t believe a word of it. “Yep,” he agreed, clicking his mouse. “Gotcha. Gonna have to go home soon though, huh? Got a stomachache? Maybe feel some covid symptoms coming on? You want me to look up what’s circulating right now, so you know how you’re feeling? I think it’s mostly gastro, this variant...” Mike clicked and grinned, and it was anybody’s guess if he was working or actually looking that information up.

But it did give Jack an idea, so he focused for a few minutes on pretending to work, then typed a message to Nikki, then did a few more things, before packing up his things and shutting down his computer.

Mike didn’t look away from his screen, just smiled. “It’s all about the stuffy nose, now, man.” He held a hand over his screen with his fingers shaped like a gun and clicked his tongue twice as he pulled his trigger finger. “Get some rest. Hope you feel better. I’ll take care of this Air Ambulance fiasco, no problem.”

Jack looked over at him, and lacking anything to say, muttered a “thanks.”

“All you gotta do is tell me your secret,” Mike said cheerfully.

“It’s not an affair,” Jack repeated, putting on his coat.

“Yep,” Mike chirped, as he walked out the door.

*

The phone had fallen to the floor because of Tony's cat, which they both found hilarious.

"A cat," Jack had repeated, when Nikki had filled him in on the story. "A white cat."

Nikki, however, was in the middle of her story, and didn't seem to picking up on the impossible irony of Tony having a white cat.

But Jack wasn't about to derail the story with that footnote. Because he didn't actually care how the phone had been knocked over, only what had happened before and after.

By the time he arrived at home, Nikki was already asleep in their bed. She was loosely wrapped in the silk robe from their adventure at the hotel.

He wasn't sure what to do, because he imagined that Nikki was exhausted after spending the whole night with Tony. But she *had* asked him to come home early.

He dispensed rapidly with his clothing, pulling it off with the hurried inelegance of a teenage boy about to score, as if the careful removal of clothing might close some window of opportunity. He crawled carefully onto the bed though, not wanting to shake Nikki immediately awake. There was a delicious morsel of sexiness to Nikki being half-awake and worn out

at the end of their lengthy experience with Tony, and he wanted to keep a little of that ambiance alive.

He lay himself out next to her and inhaled the scent of her body. He was a little disappointed that she had showered, but this was a particularly filthy penchant of his and he would never share it with her. She smelled like herself - no fancy soaps, no shampoo, no lotion - but she had definitely showered at some point between what Tony had done to her and now.

He moved his hand over her hip, over the smooth silk of the robe, taking some of the fabric with him and pulling it up and away from her skin to bare her bottom. Nikki barely stirred, so he lifted the hem of the robe and felt along her thigh, watching her face. No underwear.

Nikki smiled, without opening her eyes, and wormed her body around pleasantly, pushing her ass into the crook of his groin, her lips parting when she felt his erection against her thigh. She made a purring noise and stretched, the length of her lean muscles twisting along the front side of his body and making him dizzy with lust.

She rolled around and toward him, sleepy, opening her eyes and smiling. Everything about her was softened and languid: almost a complete opposite of her usual personality. He kissed her forehead as she folded herself into him, like complicated, fleshy origami. Her lips brushed against his chest and her hands wandered down his abdomen as she spoke to him, in a groggy voice.

"I'm so glad you're here," she purred. "I've been waiting... and waiting... and I fell asleep..." Her eyes fluttered open just as her fingers reached his groin and she discovered that he was naked. Her fingertips brushed over his erection and interest sparkled in her eyes. She surfaced from the shroud of

sleepy vacancy that clung to her eyes like a film, and animation returned to her limbs, like electricity, buzzing beneath her skin.

Jack gently guided her hand back to his cock, closing her fingers around it so she could feel for herself that he was ready. His cock was thick and swollen, teetering on painful. Nikki raised her eyebrows for him appreciatively, and bit her lip, rolling her chest forward and stretching again, as she played with his cock with her fingers and then gripped it tightly.

Jack moved in to indulge his own desires, though. He touched her lips, thinking of how they must have been closed around Tony's cock only hours before. He could smell the sweet mint of toothpaste on her breath, but the image burned in his retina. Nikki closed her lips around the tip of his thumb and sucked on it.

"Are you really sore?" he asked her, his voice shaking much more with excitement than he had anticipated.

Nikki nodded, her eyes open wide and full of - to Jack's view - a sexy, playful, mischief. She shoved her hand abruptly beneath the pillow and pulled out the salve she had purchased. "Can you do me a favor? And rub this on me?"

Jack took the small container without his eyes leaving hers. He unscrewed it and dipped his fingers into it, even as Nikki kept her own fingers in front of his, mingling together, her eyes alight with desire.

"What do I get in return?" Jack asked, biting her lower lip gently.

Nikki smiled the smile of a woman who knew perfectly well that she didn't need to give anything in return to a man for the task of rubbing something

gently into her pussy, but she played along, pretending to think.

"I'll tell you all about what happened," she said, in a teasing tone. "While you do it."

And so, while Jack tenderly smeared the salve between the lips of her pussy, and then pushed her gently onto her back and pushed her legs open to better access her, Nikki told him about her evening.

About the restaurant, where they had eaten, and Tony had watched her squirming with her butt plug in. How she found it exciting, filthy, demeaning, and erotic all at once, and hoped Jack didn't think any less of her for that.

How Tony had eventually slid a hand beneath her ass, palm up, and worked a finger beneath her skirt to manipulate the butt plug as she sat eating, her cheeks flushing with heat and the back of her neck getting sweaty.

"He did it to me for like, half an hour," Nikki purred, watching Jack's face, as his fingers massaged the salve gently into her most tender skin.

Occasionally, he felt her body react as he probed a particularly sore spot, stiffening and then softening, as the dull pain worked into a sweet, aching pleasure.

Nikki had begun to get wet as he rubbed her pussy, or maybe it was more from talking about what Tony did to her. "We left the restaurant," she said, and her voice dropped, almost like she expected someone to be listening in on their conversation. "And he, uh... drove me to his place..." Nikki paused, looking into Jack's eyes and biting her lip. Her eyes were growing wide with a sentiment he couldn't narrow down. A red streak began to spread from her jawline to her cheekbone, on her right cheek only.

Jack moved his finger to her clit, pushing the hood away with his thumb and making a languid circular motion over the bundle of nerves beneath it. Nikki shuddered. Then she smiled and leaned in, to whisper to Jack:

"I gave him a blow-job in the car," she said, and Jack had his mouth open to say something when she added, "While he was driving."

"Jesus, Nikki," Jack said.

This was a no-go zone for anyone who had ever cleaned up the aftermath of one of these adventures. But Jack, like Nikki, evidently, found himself less horrified by it than turned on. The danger of it, if anything, added to its appeal.

Nikki still had something to say, some detail that she hadn't shared, that she wanted to both bury and confess. Jack could tell: it was lurking in her eyes, excited and ashamed all at the same time.

Jack kissed her forehead again and slowly worked a finger into her pussy, which was so hot it didn't feel entirely real. Around his finger, the silken heat of her body squirmed and wriggled, massaging his finger and making his cock scream in agony. "What else did you do?"

Nikki's pussy pulsed around his finger, indicating her excitement, and she sucked in her breath, hesitated, squirmed, and then finally leaned her forehead against his to tell him:

"I did it on the highway, and I got on my knees in the seat, kind of like at the hotel, you know, he put his hand..." Nikki guided Jack's hand to her ass, "over the back of me, and started moving the butt plug while I did it?"

Nikki ended this as a question, her eyes now gazing down at her hand around Jack's cock. She could read his own pleasure, which parts of the

story made his cock jerk violently with arousal. Just as he could feel from the undulations and squeezing of her pussy which parts of the story made her most excited.

"...and...?" Jack prompted.

"...and it was... *so* dangerous..." Nikki breathed, her voice making it sound like she was scolding Tony for the danger, but this was momentary. "And it was *so* hot..."

The image was already burning into Jack's mind, without him even seeing it: Tony, barely fazed by the distraction, Nikki's head in his lap, her lips and tongue working up and down his shaft, one hand casually nudging the steering wheel, the other draped over Nikki's upturned ass, fucking her casually with the butt plug. He wondered if anyone driving by had looked into Tony's car to see this going on, if Nikki had even thought of that, if it turned her on.

But she didn't say, and he didn't want to stop her from doling out the details of the rest of the story.

Tony made her come before he did, and then he made her swallow his load and sit in the passenger seat, facing him, playing with her pussy so he could glance over at it whenever he wanted to.

Then Jack had seen the beginning, and heard the rest, for the most part. Nikki's details began to get fuzzy, and her interest turned to him, pulling him inside her, shifting beneath him, mewling softly because she was so sore.

Somewhere in the middle of all that, the story was abandoned, and Jack was left to let his imagination run wild with what he *had* heard, and seen, and

imagined, while he fucked Nikki slowly and gently full of cum.

It was hot: of this there was no doubt. Fucking his sleepy, crumpled, well-used wife as the story of her tryst with Tony dribbled from her mouth and then she faded away into her own dreams or memories, touched all the softest, rawest places in his own psyche he could think of.

But an unsettling vector had entered the game they were playing, and that was Nikki's willingness to do dangerous things, things she wouldn't have ordinarily dreamed of doing, with Tony.

Was it because Tony was like a fantasy to her, so much so that she didn't think of her actions when she was with Tony as real actions? Like a New York cab ride, famously feted in a Seinfeld episode, Tony was someone she could do anything with, consequence-free, in her mind?

Or was it because "Good Nikki" - Nikki who followed all SOPs and never wore her AFD shirt into a liquor store, let alone a bar, straight-shooting, clean-cut Nikki, Nikki over whose head all filthy jokes went flying - was actually not her authentic self?

Maybe she had been waiting all this time to be a bad girl, and now she would convert, and he would lose her? Was he exciting enough for the new bad-girl Nikki?

The possibilities were endless, and Jack could have played them all out, talking dirty to her while he fucked her respectfully, trying to glean the details of the inner workings of her sexual mind. But even if Nikki had turned her head inside-out for him, he knew that he would never really believe 100% in what she said - and it was, curiously but undeniably - where much of the agonizingly pleasurable force came from when his own

orgasm erupted, volcanic and disorienting, in his wife's sore and worn-out pussy.

He spooned her and played with her hair, as Nikki dozed. This was another incredible aspect of her sessions with Tony: at last, the Enewgizew Wabbit had run out of juice, and it was almost as strange to see Nikki exhausted, as it was to see her suck another man's cock.

And so questions lingered on his lips, unspoken, because he wasn't sure how to put into words what he wanted to *ask* Nikki.

As he drifted off to sleep, though, partially in the hazy logic of dreams, he moved his lips and murmured.

“Who *are* you?”

It could have been for dream Nikki or real Nikki, old Nikki or new Nikki. But it didn't matter, because he slid further into sleep, and Nikki never answered, anyway.

CHAPTER 8

Every vibration of Nikki's phone sent a tremor through him. A precursor to a rock-solid hard-on began to boil to the rhythm of the notification sound. The impulse was Pavlovian: he half-expected his mouth to start watering at the sound, fat drops of precum dripping down his cock.

He and Nikki had left things at "let's see how it plays out," with Tony.

It wasn't as if Jack could do anything about it anyway, and while he hungered for more encounters like their first, or even the table scraps of Nikki's solo date with Tony, the fact that Nikki wasn't overly desperate to hook up with him again had a reassuring effect for Jack.

Of course not every text Nikki received was from Tony – in fact, most weren't. But he salivated nonetheless, his whole body waiting on the edge, ready to spring into a painfully aroused state at a moment's notice.

After just one such vibration, Nikki slid her phone from her bedside table with a sexy glance in Jack's direction, and a smile on her lips. She seemed as hopeful as Jack that her messages would be from Tony, that Tony would beckon her to drop everything and go see him.

"Tony wants to know if I have a hot dress," she read aloud for Jack, her eyes lighting up. Nikki's features could not hide emotions like excitement, and Jack could see from her features that the request had stimulated her. Behind her eyes, excitement flared. He wondered what she was imagining in those moments, while she stared at Tony's words and waited for Jack to respond. She brought her fingers to her lips absentmindedly and touched them, smiling at the screen.

Jack leaned over, and since his hand was in the right place for it anyway, he stroked her thigh, which stimulated Nikki to slump, throw her leg over his, and turn sexily to him. “Do I?” she giggled. She moved her foot playfully, her thigh bouncing on his leg. “I don’t even know.”

“Ask him why,” Jack suggested.

He suggested it less for practical purposes, and more because he wanted his wife to extract some filthy, torturous idea from Tony so that they would have fresh fuel for sex, which he had been considering putting off for a bit out of exhaustion, but was now planning to have in the very near future.

Nikki diligently typed per Jack’s instructions. *Why?*

Tony did not immediately respond, even though both of them curled up together and stared at the screen as though they were watching a TV program. The bouncing dots at the bottom of the screen weren’t even moving, and yet they watched it, eyes fixed to the screen.

Jack didn’t know what was going on in Nikki’s mind, but his thoughts were wandering far away from the phone, the dress, and Tony’s reply, to dirtier, more visual memories and fantasies, and his excitement was building to the point of pain. Where he touched Nikki, her body rippled with sexual energy, coiling and squirming beneath his touch without her actually moving much at all. It was strange, how he could feel that beneath her skin – interest, arousal, a loving response that traveled to him via touch, and yet Nikki didn’t actually move any differently than normal.

Get yourself one. A little trashy.

Nikki raised her eyebrows and looked at Jack. “Hmm,” she said, smiling. Her purr seemed to originate in Jack’s own abdomen, from the nexus of hot,

sweating jealousy that swelled there. She settled a little more against Jack, holding the phone so that they could both see, and Jack was able to stroke her arms as she typed.

“What do I write?” she asked Jack, her thumbs hovering over the keyboard.

Jack rested his chin on her head and inhaled the scent of her hair.

“Whatever you *would* write,” he said, smiling. “As if I’m not even here.”

Nikki’s eyelashes, which he was viewing from above, closed and then fluttered open, and he thought he saw her lips turn up at the corner. She began to type, but deleted as quickly as she wrote, then touched the phone to her lips and looked up, sliding down his chest a little to tilt her head and look up at him. “I don’t know what I would say!” she whispered, grinning. “Uh...”

And then, suddenly inspired, she repositioned herself with her head on Jack’s chest, her posture improved.

Trashy like what?

What?

Trashy like a stripper, or trashy like High Park?

Jack laughed at Nikki’s question and kissed the top of her forehead. Tony wasn’t immediately writing back. Nikki laughed and held the phone in two hands. “I’m not going High Park trashy,” she said. “Not even for *you*.”

As her eyes moved and her attention shifted, from the phone to Jack and back again, it felt like a saw was being pulled through the center of his chest.

I better take you. You have shift tomorrow?

Nikki blinked slowly. Jack pushed her hair to one side of her shoulders and lowered his mouth to her flesh, bringing his fingers along her arm to stroke her collarbone and slip the spaghetti strap of her camisole off her shoulder. “Play hard to get,” he suggested, gently pressing his teeth into Nikki’s shoulder.

He wasn’t entirely sure why he suggested that. His mind was already whipping up a fantasy about Nikki trying on dresses for Tony, and if he was being honest, he wanted that scenario enacted sooner rather than later. But it was a tiny flick of the wrist, a way of making a tangible display of his hands on the metaphorical reins of this relationship.

“Well,” Nikki said. “No problem there, because I *do* have shift.” She typed quickly.

Yes.

Just tell me what it’s for, I can get it

no

Is Jack there?

Nikki shifted and looked up at Jack, her eyes wide. She wanted to know what he thought she should say. Jack was weighing his options, wondering what Tony’s game was with this, when Nikki seemed to decide on mischief. She typed simply:

No

As Tony's implacable "no" had done, this decisive response traveled like erotic electricity through Jack. He exhaled slowly, impressed, and Nikki

smiled, but her attention was on her phone, where she could see that Tony was typing an immediate response, and it was redolent with promise.

When are you free next? Daytime. For shopping.

“He’s definitely all-business,” Jack commented, impressed once again by Tony, even if he was disappointed by the response. It wasn’t easy to lead that man anywhere, because Tony just did whatever the hell he wanted to. There was something delicious and exciting about playing the game he was playing with Nikki, trying to get her to get Tony to do something, or have to change *his* plans.

Although that did seem like a long way off, given Tony’s reply.

Nikki’s head moved on his chest. She was looking up at him. “What do I do?” she asked, and they shared a look, each of them marveling at Tony’s knack for being bossy in all things. “I wonder what he even wants this for,” Nikki muttered. She started to type that exact question.

Jack put his hand out and closed around her phone and typing fingers, lowering them slowly to her lap. “Just... wait a second, maybe,” he said. “Let’s think about this.”

Nikki grinned and slipped the phone out of his grasp, resting it on his emptied hands, which he folded together so he could twiddle his thumbs in a sinister way. His cock throbbed against Nikki’s back, and she looked up at him again. “Ah,” she said. “You like that. But what is it?” She slid to the right so that she could rest her head in the crook of his elbow and look up at him more easily. “But what do you like?”

His cock throbbed again, and Nikki smiled. “Me playing hard to get? Tony being bossy? The dress -”

As soon as she said “dress,” Jack’s cock pulsed violently. Nikki’s eyes narrowed and her smile became playful with a hint of something that made Jack uneasy in it. She stroked his arm with one hand and held up the phone. “You like that Tony is going to...?” she prompted, but when Jack didn’t answer fast enough, she went fishing for the answer:

“Tony wants me to wear a dress?” Jack smiled: it wasn’t as if Nikki had never worn a dress before in her life. “That... Tony wants me to wear a slutty dress?” Nikki tried, but frowned almost immediately, sensing she wasn’t on the right track. “That Tony... wants to...” Nikki’s eyes were searching his, her lips forming a smile, her phone tapping gently against her lips between words.

“...take me shopping?” she asked, squinting like she believed it was wrong. But Jack couldn’t hide the reaction of his body.

“Really?” Nikki asked, incredulously, sitting up and re-settling herself in Jack’s embrace, like he was an armchair. She even scooted her butt side to side as she held his thighs and worked her way backward until her soft rump was wriggling against his cock. She held up the phone and typed – theatrically, speaking her words aloud slowly, and holding the phone so he could see.

“Will... you... take me... shopping... and then... I can try it on...for... you...” Nikki said, typing. She paused, and a sultry – but slightly terrifying – sound left her throat. “Huhn,” she intoned, still waiting to send the message. She deleted the “Will you” so that it was a demand, and then held her thumb just above the send icon.

Hastily, she deleted the whole message, and when John made a disgruntled noise, she smiled. “Don’t worry,” she said. “This is better. Take me

shopping.... and then... I can put it on... and... take... it... off for... you.” Nikki ended this sentence with flourish, waving her hand a little before tapping the send button.

Jack’s cock gave her his response, when it throbbed against her body. This made Nikki smile, which was hot, but not as hot as when her pink tongue slipped from between her lips to run along her upper lip as she read Tony’s reply.

You’re off Sat then. Meet me at Highlands Mall

Jack read the message and waited – Nikki often took the time to read things twice, no matter what it was. Force of habit. And then she made another noise that purred on Jack’s chest as if she was a cat.

“Saturday is the only day we have together,” she said. “For weeks. I think.”

Jack waited, not breathing. His fingers were resting on Nikki’s arms, her elbows worked into his palm, his thumbs on the soft hollow of her arm. He moved them, bilaterally, at the same time, trying to think of something good to say, a way to tell Nikki that there was no higher level of quality time with her than indulging in something to do with Tony. He was thrilled that she was thinking of him, though, and didn’t want to disregard it or make it seem like it wasn’t important to him.

But while he tried to settle on the best way to serve these two competing ideas to Nikki, Nikki decided to take things into her own hands. She started typing, and Jack peered over her head at the screen, his thumbs moving over her tender flesh, her ligaments stretching as she moved her fingers to type:

OK but Jack is coming too

They waited. Jack's cock ached for Nikki now, and he wanted to throw her onto the bed and start tearing her clothes away, but at the bottom of the screen, the dots jumped and then grew still, and then moved again, and he was privately very pleased that Nikki might have managed to knock him off his game.

Even while, if he was honest, he had to admit that he didn't want Tony off his game.

He wanted him right on it.

All right then girl

Bring him along. He can pay

What time?

I gotta see baby, wait for my text.

CHAPTER 9

“What about this?” Nikki draped a long red dress along her front as she lifted the hanger over her head and let it rest against her neck to display it on her body over her clothes. It was impossible to tell: Jack was realizing that he hadn’t been in a women’s clothing store, or even a mall, for so long that the whole place felt like it was from another planet.

Maybe it was just the situation, which the clerk – a lone female employee, hovering near thirty years old, attractive and aggressively bored – was eyeing with mild interest. They were the only people in the store, a high-end lingerie and clothing store with no visible price tags, which was causing distress in Jack’s guts. Everything looked extremely expensive, and he was pretty sure that by being here, he’d sealed himself into the purchase.

After all, there really wasn’t any other reason for him to be here.

Tony seemed amazingly comfortable in a fancy lingerie store in the whitest part of town. He looked at the dress Nikki was holding and sucked on his lower lip, shaking his head. “That’s hot. I want to see that. I want you to go put it on. But it’s too long. You need something...” he looked around, frowning, then waved the clerk over. “She needs something a little more, you know, trashy. This here’s a little too elegant.”

The clerk looked from Tony to Jack, then back again, amused and suspicious all at once. “More... trashy,” she repeated. “We don’t really -”

“Not actually trashy, girl. Just... a hint of trashy.”

“*What* is this for?” Nikki asked, for the fifth time, smiling and lifting the red dress over her head to replace it on the rack.

“She gotta look hot, and she gotta look like... she got a lot of money and no sense whatsoever.” Tony was still speaking to the clerk. “You hear that? Like a high-end escort.”

The clerk reacted strangely to this, a smile threatening to break out on her lips.

“Yeah” Tony said, directing his eyes to the dress Nikki had just hung up, taking it off the rack and lifting it back up and over her head to hand around her neck. “I din’ say put that back, honey, I still wanna see it.” He gently pushed Nikki by the shoulder and pointed her in the direction of the fitting rooms, and swatted her gently on the ass. Then he turned back toward the sales associate. When he saw her face he smiled broadly, his white teeth glowing in the bright store light. “You know what I’m talkin’ about,” he said to her. “And somethin’ red, if you got it.”

The associate went to work, smiling, turning all of her concentration to the clothing racks, thinking deeply about the assignment Tony had given her. Jack sat down on a very large, plump chair and tried to bite his tongue.

But Tony’s “mystery reason” for wanting a smutty – but also expensive – dress for Nikki was burning a hole in his mind, fueling fantasy after horrific fantasy, striking fear in his heart even as he enjoyed the cool burn of jealousy and the arousal of watching Tony “handle” his wife as if she were his.

They sat side-by-side, watching the whole scene while Nikki flitted about the store, selecting dresses and holding them up over the racks. Tony responded by either shaking his head or shrugging, and Nikki seemed to - unnervingly - know what these wordless gestures meant.

This was a mild irritant, and mildly arousing. That Nikki knew how to read caveman-like instructions from the grunts and roughly-hewn gestures of an emergency services officer was not surprising: that was a professional skill that made the difference between life and death in her job on a regular basis, and she had almost two decades of experience in that department.

Watching her do it, however, in the services of Tony's primitive sexual desires, however, was a different ball of wax, and it touched a nerve somewhere inside him. It was what he wanted, sure, and titillating as fuck, but it rubbed against some burning doubt inside him that even he didn't have his finger on and made it smolder.

The clerk directed Nikki to a changing room and advised her, loudly, so that Tony could hear, "We'll just get you started with these for now." Nikki followed, inspecting the sequins on a dress she had just picked up, seemingly guileless and oblivious to the havoc she was wreaking on Jack.

Until, almost at the small corridor of dressing rooms, the clerk way in front of her, she turned her head and smiled excitedly in their direction. Whether it was for Tony or for him, Jack didn't know.

Tony had a sinister grin plastered on his face, and it remained there for a moment. But in the sudden, alpha-cop way of his, which Jack was beginning to see was probably a deliberate tactic designed to keep everyone guessing (and effectively, he thought), Tony's face went completely serious, and he leaned in his chair toward Jack.

"Man, you gotta come clean with me," he said, and it seemed like a silent chuckle made his huge chest shake. It never turned into a smile, or a sound. "Y'all are *not* doin' this for the first time."

Jack didn't expect this or have an immediate answer, so he froze.

"Be real, man."

Jack shook his head slowly, hissing as he sucked air through his teeth. "Far as I know," he said.

He looked over at Tony, whose mouth was spreading into an amused grin.

Tony gave off a low whistle and chuckled. "Far as you know." He found this very amusing. He shook his own head and folded his arms over his chest. "Man, that is a *live wire* if you're tellin' me the truth."

The clerk came striding out confidently and looked over at them. If she found the situation confusing, she had recovered from it in the name of sales. "The black one is going to look *great* on her," she told them smugly, before hastening to the front, where new customers were entering.

"Yeah," Tony murmured under his breath. "Cool fifty says that's the most expensive one."

Jack looked over at him with some alarm.

Tony laughed. "It's cool, man." He patted his pocket. "Business expenses."

Tony waited, looking straight ahead, but something in his face cocked toward Jack, expecting a response.

Nikki appeared in the corridor then, and popped her head out, looking in their direction. Tony raised his arm and flapped his hand open and closed, summoning her in his authoritative way.

Nikki seemed hesitant as she approached, but whatever she saw on Tony's face worked on her like a drip of precisely calibrated alcohol. Her inhibitions peeled away with every step, until she stopped in front of them

and posed like a model, one hand on her hip, lips puffed out over a slight smirk.

"Them shoes gotta go," Tony said, and Nikki looked down at her feet.

She was wearing the clunky sandals she had come in with, and she posed her feet like she was a foot model. "Yeah, well I'm not walking around in bare feet on this petri dish of a carpet," she quipped. "So use your imagination."

Jack was focused on the dress - there wasn't much to it, specifically, that made it seem as expensive as it did. It was black, fit tightly against her body, and plunged at the neckline to frame the smooth mounds of her breasts and all of her sternum, every contour of her body flattered by the way it was cut. She turned slowly, and Jack's attention was drawn to her ass, which looked particularly firm and enticing in the getup.

Nikki paused again after turning, and lifted her eyebrows expectantly at Tony before smiling at Jack. "Well?"

Tony sat in momentary silence, his hands draped over the end of the armrests, surveying the scene before him like a king with big things on his mind.

"That's the one," he said, before lifting an arm and indicating that Nikki should twirl around again. "Lemmee see the back again?"

Nikki started to turn, and as she did, she directed her gaze to Jack. It was a brief glance, but direct and intense, accompanied by a smile that - to Jack, anyway - seemed almost conspiratorial. He noted with a mixture of approval and unease that she took pains to do it once she was turned enough around that Tony wouldn't see it.

"Yeah, that's the one," Tony said definitively, when she completed her turn. "But go put that red thing on anyway, I wanna see it." Tony looked over at Jack and smiled, folding his hands together in a gesture that was tinged with menace for reasons that escaped Jack.

Nikki sauntered off, and Tony looked thoughtful. "Kinda pale in that, though," he commented, looking pensive.

His eyes shifted to Jack, to take in his reaction. "What do you think?"

Jack cleared his throat and shifted in his seat. "Uh... yeah. But Nikki's pale. So..."

At first this statement made no impact whatsoever: Tony appeared to have retreated into some kind of planning room inside his own head. Without having seen Tony himself with this expression before, Jack nonetheless recognized: the face of tactical planning.

It seemed like now was as good a time as any to broach the subject, since Tony's mind was evidently on it. "Hey, man," he said, leaning on his knees to get closer to Tony. Jack was self-conscious of his body language around Tony (for that matter, all cops), because he sensed that the way he moved conveyed far more to Tony than his words, and if his experience with cops thus far in life was anything to go by, he was right. "You got something in mind with all these dresses? Or what?"

But as he asked the question, Tony began to smile broadly - so much so, and so out-of-sync with Jack's question - that Jack suspected Tony hadn't even heard his question at all. "Yeah, she a real white girl, ain't nothin' gonna make that look any other way." He chuckled and rubbed his head from the back forward in three quick, hyper-masculine motions. "She got some Russian or something like that in her?"

Momentarily disoriented, thrown off his game by Tony's seeming total disregard of his question, Jack squinted and scowled. "Russian?" he parroted, as the question caught up to him. "No... not Russian. Scandinavian... mostly... Czech, I think... maybe..." he trailed off, because Tony's interest had clearly waned. He seemed satisfied by something in Jack's answer and returned to looking in the direction of the dressing rooms.

"I got an op I wanna use her on," he declared abruptly, without looking over at Jack. This was a statement of the kind that did not leave a door open for further questions or discussion, and Tony issued it as a declaration.

Jack stared at Tony, who seemed not to notice or care for a beat, but slowly turned his head toward Jack. The look seemed confrontational, and Jack wondered what to say to it.

"It ain't a tactical team op," Tony stated, and then raised his eyebrows like he was waiting for something.

Jack had never been in any further legal jeopardy than a traffic ticket, so he didn't have any real idea what it felt like to be in an interrogation room with a guy like Tony hulking over the table, but his imagination suggested that it would feel very similar to what he was experiencing now. Tony seemed to be baiting him to say something, and Jack was almost disappointed in himself for being too dumbstruck to think of anything to say.

"Uh..." he began. He wasn't able to hide his frown. A feeling of terror wormed around inside him, vaguely reminiscent of the arousing, nebulous fear he liked to indulge when Tony had his huge cock inside his wife. But this terror was pure and distilled. "What, uh... kind of 'op' would that be exactly?"

Tony grinned smugly and settled back in his chair, which for whatever reason, made Jack continue on, his dander rising. "Nikki isn't trained to do -"

Tony waved this all away with a flick of his hand. "Man, I ain't gonna do nothin' to put your little girl in some situation she can't handle," he grunted. He made a very black sound, a click and a hiss combined, and grinned, shaking his head. "And I ain't talked to her about it yet, if that's your next question." He looked at Jack pointedly for a moment.

Peculiarly, his next move was to soften a little and lean toward Jack. By the standards of any human culture, Tony maintained a dominant stance toward Jack as he hulked over him, larger and discernibly taller even the chair, his face a sledgehammer of sorts, brimming with the kind of implied potential for violence that almost all cops seemed to have, even when they ordered coffee.

But there was a congeniality to his tone, however weird, as he lowered his voice like he was confiding in a good friend. "I don't dispense unsolicited advice," Tony said seriously, "but I'm gonna, because I like fucking your wife and all -" Tony paused to smile at this thought and retreat into some filthy images of his own - "but I also like your wife professionally, okay?"

As he did sometimes, Tony shifted his dialect from the clean, standard Midwestern accent he most often used, to a black vernacular that surfaced for certain topics (the pattern of which Jack was still working out). "Just bein' straight with you, man, but you gotta let them wings spread a little. Nikki bein' fuckin' *wasted* cleanin' up after guys pissin' their pants and forgettin' they insulin." Tony pointed in the direction of the dressing rooms without moving another muscle in his body, his eyes boring into Jack. "She a cool customer. She got talent." Tony grinned briefly at his own double

entendre but carried on seriously. "I ain't told her about nothin' yet, so keep it shut."

Jack eyed Tony warily. "This isn't some semi-legal thing, is it?" he asked, and was pleased that his voice came out steady and confident.

Tony also seemed surprised by this, because he tipped his head back to look down his nose at Jack, like he was possibly recalculating something.

A grin.

"Tsa gray area, man," he said, finally, smiling and turning toward the now-approaching Nikki. "Man" melted away into a rumble of sexual approval. "Damn," Tony said, his eyes moving up and down Nikki's body.

The dress was not much different than the first one, in Jack's view, except for being red and longer, with a saliva-inducing slit along the right leg that went almost up to her hip. Nikki was touching the straps on her shoulders and craning her neck to look at each of them in turn, her face screwed up in a cute display of annoyance. "It's hot," she said, adorably flustered, "but these straps are all over the place."

Tony's lustful perusal of Nikki's body - the v-shaped indentation where the fabric stretched across her proportioned hips and caught on the roundness of her athletic, well-trained thighs, the shadows in the valleys of this magnificent landscape hinting at the precise contours of her body.

Tony waved all of this away after seemingly enjoying the view for a bit. "Get them all, baby doll."

Nikki stopped in her tracks, her smile turning to confusion. "All?"

She looked alarmed.

But Tony waved her away. "Go on and get changed, we gotta get you shoes and I got shit to do."

Nikki's eyes shifted to Jack's as Tony pulled his phone out and looked at an incoming text. She raised them and shrugged, then spun away happily toward the fitting rooms.

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The same scene, more or less, was repeated at the shoe store, where Tony waved away sensible shoes and classy shoes, settling on several pair that looked like a stripper would wear them.

When Nikki pointed this out, Tony grinned broadly. "Perfect."

Nikki decided as she passed the food court that she had to pee, so she dropped all the bags with them and sauntered away.

Tony set down the bags and seemed happy that Nikki had left them alone.

"I wanna take her out," Tony said, as Nikki bounced away. "Alone. Talk to her about this op. I gotta wine her and dine her a little, you know what I mean?"

Jack was looking at Tony skeptically. This made Tony smile, genuinely amused. "Man, I already done fucked her every way I can," he joked, as if they were great friends. "What you worried about?"

Jack held his arms out from his body a little, the bags swaying with the momentum. "Uh... you talking my wife into some shady operation that you don't even have on the books... primarily."

Something about Tony at that moment became very scary. He looked down at his shoe as he kicked the toe into a stationary planter, seemingly to get

something off it, and his whole persona quieted - congealing into the coiled and dangerous silence of a large and powerful man. "Mm," he said, his tone neutral and his voice low. He looked up, into the distance, like he was scanning for something out there. "That there is an interesting fear."

Jack lost his patience. "What the fuck is that supposed to mean, Tony?"

Tony shrugged and frowned, but amusement played out in the corners of his features. "You let your wife get her brains fucked out by some nigger, let her run around in live fire exercises, maybe she ends up on some tactical ops, and now you got a problem with *her* judgment. That's interesting. 'Zall I'm sayin'." He folded his arms across his chest and straightened up, becoming noticeably larger, turning toward Jack. "Man, these two things ain't got nothin' to do with each other, what you failin' to understand. One is personal. The other is business. Professional shit. Now," Tony paused to loom even more over Jack, his eyes getting hard. "I fully intend to fuck her when we all done talkin' about it, because that's the personal. *And* I like that pussy. *And* you like me fuckin' that pussy. So set that aside."

Jack blinked, unnerved but strangely entranced by Tony's balls-to-the-walls confidence.

"Two, the professional shit." Tony held up one of his shovel hands and splayed his fingers, ticking items off by lowering them each in turn until he had a fist and then started lifting fingers. "I got an op I need a cool customer. I need a sexy gal. I need a gal who look like she sorta Eastern European. I need a certain amount of police training. I need someone knows how to use a gun if she gotta, and get the fuck outta the way in an orderly and timely fashion if she need to, without screaming and cryin' and fuckin' it all up. Now, I got lady cops comin' out my ass with all this feminist bullshit, but not a single one fits that bill." Tony swiveled his head in the

direction Nikki had taken off, his hand suspended near Jack's face with three fingers out. "She do, though. And that is some strictly professional shit. I'm lettin' you in on it, because me and you, we got a personal relationship that way. But *this*, this professional shit? That's between me, a cop, and Nikki, a police asset, way I see it. And man?" He turned back to look at Jack. "I gone through three wives, so I know what I'm sayin.' You try to smother a girl like that, a girl who wanna be the best at her job, take it to the limit?" Tony shook his head and chuckled. "Your call. But I gone through three wives just that same way and tellin' you personal, it ain't the best fuckin' idea."

Tony let this sit for a second, and Jack frowned, mind racing.

"You worried I'm gonna let her fuck some Russian mob boss, got the clap? That it?" Tony hiss-tskd in his very black way and shook his head. "Nigga' please. I stick my dick in that pussy, too, I ain't lookin' to have it fall off. And - and this professional, Jackie, so listen up: I don't let any these little girls get shot up under *my* command."

This last sentence was delivered with a very particular form of venom, as if Jack had accused him of that very thing.

"I'm not saying *that*," Jack objected. "But -"

"No 'but,' man. She a fuckin' paramedic in AFD, she climbin' into collapsed buildings and puttin' IVs in guys while they stuck in a fuel tanker hangin' off the side the overpass. How 'bout you let your wife decide what she gonna do, with her own damn training and her own damn talent? *I* ain't gonna twist her arm, she ain't into it. I don't need *that* shit." Tony paused, most likely to breathe, because he fired all of that at Jack like a machine

gun. "Man, you ain't even heard what it is yet, you already tellin' her not to do it."

"I need the details -"

"No," Tony said sharply. "No. You *don't*. Because that's some classified and seriously confidential shit. *Nikki* the only one gotta ask for details, and *Nikki* gonna be the one I give them to. She tell you about it, that ain't strictly kosher, but I expect that kinda shit. Shiiiit." Tony rubbed his face. "No good fuckin' deed, man."

Jack frowned. "You're kinda outta line, man," he stated, looking in the same direction as Tony. "It's my wife, Tony."

Tony snorted. "*You* outta line, man. Only reason you even hearing about this is 'cause I bangin' her with your blessing, so... it's man to man, courtesy, that kinda shit. *You* gotta separate these two things in your head." Tony shook his head again. "*Damn*, man. Go home, get your head straight. Right now, me, I'm gonna take Nikki out for a *business* meal, in that black dress and them shoes." He pushed off the planter, which he had slowly begun leaning one foot on.

When he rose up to his full height, Tony had two modes – one which emphasized his physical superiority to almost everyone around him, and one that downplayed it. He seemed actually larger than ever before as he loomed over Jack in “emphasized” mode, which Jack assumed was intended to have precisely the effect it was having: severe intimidation.

“I’m gonna fuck her, too. But not ‘til she already agreed to do what I want.” Tony smiled. “Just so you can’t be layin’ no accusations of coercion on me.” And then he kind of laughed and turned his attention toward the

corridor where Nikki had disappeared and was now exiting, digging through her handbag as she almost always was when she exited a bathroom.

Jack looked back at Tony, not really sure what to say. The calibration of Tony's statement was impossible to discern: was it all joke? Sarcasm? Partially serious? Intimidation? Did he care? Jack had no idea.

Nikki looked up and smiled as Tony walked toward her, and Jack, lacking any idea of what else to do, followed.

"We goin' out. You and me," Tony told her, when he was still a few feet away. He didn't break his stride. Nikki looked at Jack in momentary confusion. Jack nodded as imperceptibly as he could while still getting the message across: he wasn't fully committed, but he wouldn't stand in her way.

What else could he do?

He took Nikki's hand and pulled her toward him. Then he kissed her, very passionately, on the mouth.

It was the one thing he could do that Tony - at least supposedly - couldn't.

"Tony has something he wants to talk to you about," he said. He kissed her forehead. "Have a nice night."

Tony took the bags out of Nikki's hands and pulled her along with him, while Nikki raised her eyebrows and made a face of interest. She walked away, turning to look after her as they disappeared down the mall way into the crowd.

She looked excited.

CHAPTER 10

Nikki went home with Tony that night and sent a few empty text messages promising to tell him all about “everything,” and she came home for some clothes before heading to an early half-shift that she had been called into. So Jack had to wait almost three full days to see her again, and that was at Cole’s home wrestling match, which Nikki had promised to attend.

Nikki arrived late, but only by about ten minutes. She was wearing her best jeans, a pair that enhanced her figure and her specific curves, and a form-hugging plain navy t-shirt. Her hair was in a ponytail, and a few sexy tendrils hanging down were the only thing unusual about it (Nikki did not like her hair getting in her way, so she eschewed this kind of thing ordinarily). Her makeup was plain and sensible. She looked, in every way possible, like she always looked.

And Nikki had always been hot: even in her most determinedly anodyne variations of herself, she couldn’t suppress her natural beauty so much that no one noticed.

But as she walked along the wall of the far side of the gym to the bleachers, one hand on her handbag, the other swinging alongside her hip in a walk that seemed sexier than usual – she seemed, at least to Jack, *overly* sexy.

He knew it was probably all in his own mind. Or rather, it seemed like a sensible proposition to him: *he* had sex with Nikki on his mind constantly because of Tony, and so *he* had all the ingredients in his mind and coloring his view of her, her jeans, the way she walked, her tendrils of hair, the sway of her hips.

Nikki smiled broadly at someone at the bottom of the bleachers and paused to talk. Jack studied her with a mixture of pride and intense jealousy. In one arena of his mind, he was appreciating his good fortune, enjoying the sight of his wife and the way she made heads turn – even here, among a middle-aged crowd. The waiting athletes on the opposite side of the gym had been watching her the entire time, but getting high-school boys to be interested enough in a woman to gawk at her wasn't exactly a magic trick.

She sauntered up to the stairs and looked for him. When she found him, she bit into her lower lip and smiled before skipping up the steps and squeezing in on the row to sit down next to him. “Hey,” she said breathlessly.

“Did you have a good time?” he asked her, awkwardly. Of course she'd had a good time, of course she had done all kinds of things with Tony that he wanted to hear about – but they were at a high school gym for God's sake. For their kid's wrestling match. What was wrong with him?

Nikki gave him one of her widest smiles, but she infused it with yet another sexy, unfamiliar, unsettling and arousing tic: she ran her tongue along the front of the molars on her upper row of teeth. It was the kind of thing that couldn't be taken as anything else, to mean anything at all except to signal sex: the thought of it, the sight of it, the sordid details of all the taboo forms of it she had done with Tony.

And even though he had seen everything else she had done with him, and even though he knew she would tell him whatever he wanted to hear – this reference to that dark part of their sex life was particularly enthralling. It hinted at all the details he would never know, the truth that he could never be sure she was telling, the danger of what they were doing, writ large.

It was also so unlike her. Especially in this context.

“It was pretty nice,” Nikki said mysteriously, with a grin. She tossed her bag and leaned back on the bleachers, putting her elbows up on the row behind her.

It was body language that didn’t really match Nikki’s personality. She crossed her leg and let her foot – encased in a sexy, heeled sandal and not her usual choice of shoes (no open toes in public places, no heels, always socks, especially in a gymnasium used by adolescent boys for wrestling). She twisted it and looked out at the matches on the floor with some mild interest, but it seemed like she deliberately wanted to tease Jack.

Nikki’s presence next to him took on new dimensions suddenly. It felt dangerous having her next to him, because he sensed the way her outrageous posture and bouncing foot were distracting everyone around him. Even if they didn’t look over and gawk, they wanted to. He could see it in the furtive glances, the unease that boiled behind the eyes that jiggled slightly with the strain of not flinging themselves in her direction.

Nikki hadn’t answered, but she was looking at him with a smile on her lips and a twinkle in her eye. She seemed to be, Jack assessed, – even though he could hardly believe it – horny.

She sat up and put her fingers in his hair and whispered: “I did so many crazy things last night.”

As she spoke, someone approached, saying their names, but Jack only heard it distantly. Nikki’s words had gone off in his consciousness like a fireworks show and drowned out all sound and thought. Her lip was coated in something, probably Vaseline, that made it stick to the interior curve of his lobe as she moved it jerkily, responding to the approaching voice.

It was a parent of one of Cole's friends, a middle-aged guy who had a trophy wife and a Porsche, and whose name escaped Jack (like everything else) at the moment. He was beaming the broad, cheesy grin of a successful chiropractor, which was what he was. "To what do we owe the pleasure?" he was hooting, looking at Nikki, who had slumped back into her elbows-on-the-bench stance.

Jack looked at Nikki. The wet, slightly goopy kiss of her lower lip was still sending sensations through him, as if that part of his ear and his balls were directly connected. *I did so many crazy things last night*, Nikki's throaty summary of her evening, pulsing with promises, was still replaying in his ear.

Nikki didn't think much of this guy and she never had, Jack knew that. He was good-looking in a Ken-and-Barbie kind of way, and confident, and rich, but Jack had never worried about him because Nikki was so obviously unimpressed by him.

But he hadn't really known *why*, so the idea always bounced around in his head whenever he came over to talk to her at other functions: was she putting on a show for him? Was she secretly attracted to him? If she wasn't, was it because she was virtuous and good, or because of something else? The guy had more money than Jack, smoother moves, and was definitely better-looking by most measures – and so Nikki's utter disinterest had always seemed like it had to be false in some way.

"Oh, hey, Mark," Nikki said, and Jack was almost certain he heard some disappointment in her voice, but she smiled politely. Mark took a seat next to her without an invitation, because he was that kind of guy.

Now that they had begun this adventure with Tony, though, Jack could see why Nikki barely registered Mark on her radar. Nikki liked the Tonys of the world. Mark was like a timid house mouse, really, compared to Tony. Jack had a delicious thought, imagining an interaction between the two of them.

“You still working at AFD?” Mark asked.

Questions like this annoyed Nikki: “working at AFD” wasn’t something that people did casually and then bopped off to some other job. This was like asking someone if they were still playing in the big leagues, as opposed to just giving up and heading back to the minors for no reason whatsoever than that they liked the team colors better. But Mark seemed to somehow know this, because he quickly put his hands out and tried to smooth it over – physically, by waving at the air, and verbally, by blathering. “I just meant, as opposed to, say, what Jack’s doing -”

“Nikki joined a police tactical team,” Jack interrupted. It was an impish impulse, and it didn’t seem to come from his own mind as an idea – but he did *like* it as soon as it occurred to him, which was why he had said it.

Nikki’s eyes shifted back to Jack, brimming with complicit laughter. A smile was on her lips.

Mark didn’t know what to make of that. “The... what?” But he was, after all, a chiropractor, and had the kind of charm most chiropractors seemed to have. “*That* sounds exciting,” he said, and Jack was pleased that he sounded fairly silly. “Uh, not as a police officer -”

“No, no. No, I’m still a paramedic,” Nikki said cheerfully, putting her hand on Jack’s lower back and smiling. She flicked him playfully, although a bit painfully, in the center of his lower back. “But I get to use their guns

sometimes.” Nikki stroked Jack’s back with one pointed, deliberate finger as she said this, and very subtly arched her back, pushing her breasts out.

Mark, for probably the first time in Jack’s history of knowing him, was speechless.

Nikki let it simmer – or at least, it seemed so to Jack – before laughing. “I’m just kidding. Mostly we just crawl around on the floor and get all sweaty together.” Another tap, a delicious beat of silence. “What about you, Mark? Still crackin’ backs for the good people of Rose Heath?”

“Yeah,” Mark said, scratching his head, distracted. “Uh, so you, like... what? Assist the police?”

Jack was watching Nikki, trying to figure out what was so different about her. It seemed to reside inside of her, delivering the minute differences to the surface of her flesh. They manifested as the tiniest changes in her gestures: she seemed to give her hair a sexier toss, smile in a sexier way, wriggle inside of her jeans without moving at all. He couldn’t tell if this was all in his own head, something he was projecting onto her because of all the filthy things he knew she had done, or if she was actually – dangerously – behaving differently.

“Yeah,” Nikki said, but it sounded almost lewd the way she said it. “I assist them.”

Mark raised his eyebrows and his eyes shifted – reluctantly, it seemed – to Jack. “That’s... dangerous sounding.”

Nikki had her mouth open in a wide smile again, and she turned to Jack, her eyes glittering with mischief. Her tongue appeared on her molars again, running along her teeth, and Mark’s reaction to that was palpable. “*He*

thinks it's hot," Nikki said, hooking a thumb at Jack as she swiveled her head toward Mark again. And then she waited, mouth open, tongue paused somewhere in the pocket of her cheek.

Mark, always supremely confident like a politician or a car salesman, was discernibly knocked off his game.

"That's..." he began.

"Weird, right?" Nikki offered, suddenly changing her demeanor, smiling warmly and leaning forward to stick her arms on either side of the crook of Jack's elbow and snuggly up to him. "Anyway. What about you? Are you still in Rose Heath?"

Nikki engaged in a boring, typical conversation about Mark's practice, which slowly set him back at ease. But he was still looking slightly stunned and wary when he retreated.

"That was... hilarious," Jack said, as Mark walked away.

"Oh... I started to feel a little sorry for him," Nikki said, making the face she made for injured animals (which was considerably more sympathetic than her face for injured humans, who got nothing from her but a cold assessment and carefully worded assurances. Nikki, like any paramedic on the street, preferred her patients unconscious).

"So you *were* messing with him," Jack said, smiling.

Nikki bumped against him and rested her head on his shoulder, walking her fingers up his thigh. "Uh, mostly I was messing with *you*," she said quietly. She paused, smiling, while a tremor ran through Jack. "But let's get our heads in the game. What the hell is going on here right now? When is Cole up?"

And just like that, Nikki was back to her old self, an overworked second income mom in the suburbs, dutifully cheering for her son at a wrestling match she didn't really understand.

*

Nikki had played it cool all the way through the evening, which Jack had found a particular kind of maddening. Hot, maddening, dangerous, disconcerting. Nikki in her t-shirt and jeans made jokes at the table when they went out to eat afterward, at a Pizza Hut of all places. She bantered with the waitress, bounced around the salad bar, and told jokes over dinner.

Jack stared at her, and though he tried to do it with finesse, he was unable to pull off the full-scale acting job that Nikki was dishing up. Cole snapped his fingers in front of his face. "Wake up, dude!" he said, repeatedly.

There was no sign, whatsoever, from Nikki, to him or anyone else who saw her, that she had just spent the evening prior to her shift getting her brains fucked out by a black cop who incidentally had also asked her to be part of some special - dangerous - op.

No indication, from her, even to him - to Jack - that any of this lingered in her mind, or bothered her, or tormented her enough to so much as distract her from her ordinary, suburban life. Unlike Jack, she did not space out or get distracted by her thoughts. It was so much like nothing had even happened, that Jack almost began to wonder if he was going crazy.

But then, as soon as she closed the door to their bedroom, the "Bad Nikki" in her activated, all at once. She clutched the door with two hands behind her and crossed one leg over the other and gave Jack a look that was purely, dirtily erotic.

It was hard to say why it was, or what change in her gestures, her appearance, her body language, made her such an instantly different creature than the sunny mom-woman he had just dined with.

But it was there: a sudden, beautiful, exciting, but disconcerting change.

Jack actually took a step backward from her, his calves hitting the bed. Disoriented by his wife, he let himself fall to a seated position, while Nikki eyed him a little bit like prey.

She smiled, and Jack noticed her tongue running along her teeth again as she moved toward him. "I have been... *so* horny... all night..." she said, pulling her shirt over her head as she walked toward him. She removed her sporty-sexy bra with the same motion, and stopped in front of him.

His face may have been confused, but his hands were already sliding up the length of her body.

Dizzy, under her spell, he was pretty sure he said something like, "I want to know about this op," before Nikki tackled him, knocking him backwards, and climbed onto him, to begin a frantic, clothes-rendering session of fucking that was quick, dirty and violently hot.

But he wasn't sure, because it all happened so fast and he could barely retain the thought that the woman doing it to him was his own wife.

Yet the woman he lay next to, panting after their rowdy quickie, *had* heard the question.

"What do you want to know?" Nikki asked, rolling onto her side and propping her head up in her hand. Her fingers seemed to be everywhere all at once, playing with his chest hairs, enticing him to her own body by

tracing lines that he liked to lick, beckoning him back inside her body with every gesture.

Jack was squinting at the ceiling, trying to put the last fifteen minutes of adventure together in linear order so that he knew what Nikki was talking about.

Jack put a hand out and pushed her meandering fingers to the mattress. "Don't distract me," he told her.

Nikki grinned and left her hand on the mattress, but a twinkle in her eye told him that wasn't going to be his final warning. "You want to know about the op," she said, and bit her lower lip.

"Nikki..." Jack began, sighing. "This is hot as fuck with Tony, I like the teasing. But I'm serious right now."

A brief flutter of annoyance crept into Nikki's face as she sighed, but she pushed herself up and sat against the headboard, gathering her hair up like she was going to put it in a ponytail, and then, lacking a band, arranging it on one shoulder. "Okay. I'm serious. Let's do it."

Recalling Tony's infuriating - but on deeper reflection, very rational - lecture about keeping the professional and the personal separate, Jack sat up on his knees facing her, warily watching his wife.

Nikki seemed to have a handle on this split. She had a handle on it all night. Tony did as well.

Was he the only one who couldn't untangle them?

"Before you get started," Nikki said, pre-emptively, "I have to tell you that I seriously can't give you any details."

"Uh-huh," Jack said, annoyed. "That's what Tony said, too."

Nikki was looking at him incredulously. "Well, he would," she said plainly. "It's... a police op, Jack."

Jack frowned. "*That's* very convenient."

Nikki looked at him strangely, and then shook her head rapidly, dismissing his comment. "Look. I can tell you this much, okay? It's not even hard. It's not... I'm not a key player, I'm not a cop, Jack, I can't be. Slivovitz is undercover, right? And he's got to look the part. So I'm basically an accessory. I just have to show up and look pretty, pretend to not speak English that great, and be like, eye candy. Sit on his lap, whine when the meeting goes too long, some other very low-key stuff, and that's it. It's a public venue. Cops everywhere listening in."

Jack stared at her. "This sounds like an episode of fucking Chicago PD, Nikki."

Nikki became *ecstatic*. She reached for his shoulder, smiling with her mouth open wide the way she always did when an adrenaline rush was headed her way. "I *know*. But you haven't heard the best part."

Jack looked skyward. "Guess not," he said.

"I get paid for two weeks of danger pay and all that bonus pay, like I'm on the op the whole time, and that means... two weeks off. Two weeks off! Two whole weeks!"

"Nikki -"

"I only have to do the one night. Well, and the, like, prep for it." She balled her fists up and squealed.

Jack scratched his head.

Nikki looked at him and her face sank. "What?"

Jack shook his head. "Look. I know this is fun and exciting and all that, but it's... dangerous, Nikki."

Nikki blinked slowly, moving her open mouth in a shifty, dangerous, put-out way. "Dangerous," she repeated. "I mean...yeah, it is dangerous. But so is my job. The job I do every day. Extremely fucking dangerous." She dropped her hands to the bed in exasperation, and Jack saw a familiar frustration pouring into her bloodstream. Her cheeks flared with splotchy pink that quickly went red, and she bit her lip very un-sexily before throwing her legs abruptly over the side of the bed.

"Hey," Jack said, grabbing her wrist, but Nikki had inner-city paramedic spidey-senses and she twisted her wrist before he grabbed it so that her hand slipped easily from his grasp.

"Hey, yourself," she said, almost bitterly. She stood up and turned toward the bed. She was pretty fired up at that point, and naked, and Jack's attention was divided between arousal and the substance of the argument - which he felt was fair - but smart enough to feel a little guilty about that.

"What is it that you think is happening out there, exactly?" Nikki demanded. "I just..." she lifted her hand theatrically and waved it in the direction of the city. "... hung upside down into a storm drain to pull a fentanyl patch out of guy's mouth and Narcan him so he'd live long enough for Fire to pull his ass out, and he punched Miggs in the face when we got him in the bus. Could've been me. Last week two pit bulls tried to bite me in a drug den. I'm at the towers almost every day for a GSW with beat cops who just got minted as backup."

"Somebody punched Miggs in the face? About time -"

"Jack that isn't the *point!* The point is, this is my regular Tuesday. This is my job, every time I walk out the door it's a risk. Infection, gunshots, collapsing structures, traffic accidents. I'm not a.... fucking kindergarten teacher at Rose Heath Montessori, Jack."

Jack swallowed. "I know that," he said slowly. Tony's words at the mall were starting to play in his head on repeat. "But this is just -"

Nikki lunged toward him and plunked herself down on the bed to grasp his hand. "This is my chance to do something *else*. Okay? Besides drive the bus and pack gunshot wounds. I am good at my job, Jack. I'm one of the best paramedics on the AFD. I'm a fucking machine under pressure. I want a *chance* to keep my cool in a situation that isn't all about... puke and insulin, for once. I want to see what I can do." She squeezed his hand. Tears were forming in her eyes, looking more like desperation than anything else. She brought his hand to her lips. "*This* isn't about Tony. It's about taking a chance and *doing something* where it matters that I'm this good." Nikki reflected upon what she had just said for a moment, actively. "This is about me," she concluded. "About my job. Joining tactical was always about *the job*. What we have going on with Tony is... a sideshow."

Jack often wondered what the world would be like if women had idea idea what the hollow, cold wind blowing through a man's chest felt like in a situation like this. Worse? Or better?

"It's *dangerous*, Nikki," he began. "And it isn't even..."

He let his voice trail off. He had been about to say "your skill set," but something about that, in light of the whole evening of observing Nikki

smoothly operating like the perfect suburban mom after whatever torrid thing she had done with Tony, rang utterly untrue.

Nikki looked up at the ceiling and let Jack's hand drop. She was obviously trying to tilt her tears back into her eyes; he'd seen her do it before.

"I don't want you to be this upset -"

"I am *fine*," Nikki said icily. She stood up again. "But unless you can... I don't know, argue convincingly that posing as a ditzy hooker girlfriend in a public place with a tactical team watching everything and with no other task than to keep my mouth shut is more dangerous than half the shit I did this week - I was just there, at the towers, Jack, that kid who got shot and run over? *My* call -"

"Is he gonna make it?" Jack asked, more as a diplomatic tactic than anything else.

Nikki blinked. "No. No, of course he isn't! He's dead, we shouldn't have even gone to work on him! Dead from bullets. From guns. Which there about thirty million of in that place and most of them are in the hands of fifteen-year old thugs. Okay? So a little Serbian mob -" Nikki clapped her hand over her mouth and shook her head again. "This is comparatively," she said, with forced calm, "on par with, or below, the level of danger I see every day. And you..." she dropped her hands and looked angrily at the ceiling. "...*can't* say it's any worse. Because it isn't. I'm taking a shower."

She stalked off, a wake of almost visible anger rippling behind her in the air.

*

"You're right."

Nikki was under the shower stream, standing in it, still furious, and she hadn't moved even as he stepped inside with her. But his words worked on her body visibly, making her muscles relax and her shoulders soften. She turned slowly toward him.

"I was mixing things up in my head, okay?"

Saying this was hard. He had realized about thirty seconds after Nikki stalked off that she *was* right, and Tony was, too, which rankled. But he had already been over this in his mind a thousand times already, twisting and contorting his argument the best he could to make it sound - to himself, more than anyone - like she *was* doing something more inherently dangerous than her everyday job.

And he had never quite managed to convince himself, either. Because everything Nikki said was true: on any given Tuesday she probably had two calls - calls with no preplanning, no prep, in which decisions had to be made on the fly and the police who - if they showed up at all - were, guaranteed, much less capable than Tony or his team.

"It's not about the op," he said, the confession rolling off his tongue with ease now that he had gotten it going. "It's that Tony wants you to do it."

Nikki was pushing water from her face and rubbing it from her eyes. She looked at him when she was done, her mouth open slightly.

"Why?" she finally said.

Jack made a move toward her, cautiously, and rested his hands on her hips when she didn't react angrily. He watched his hands moving over her body as he spoke. "It's just... something about that. Okay? About Tony, being a

macho guy, he's black, he's a cop, he's Mr. Alpha, and he's fucking my wife -"

"You... *know* that, though, you're... it's a thing we're doing," Nikki complained, in an exasperated whisper. "So I -"

Jack looked up, and silenced Nikki with his expression. "I don't like it," he said, moving in closer to her. "I know it doesn't make any sense." He was very close to her face now, and Nikki was - gratefully - softening up quite a bit, the fury receding in her eyes and being replaced by something else, something friendlier. "I just... don't... like it." He kissed her shoulder and worked a hand up her back.

Nikki was looking at him, getting a little soft and pliant in his hands, her hostility being run over by her slightly disbelieving interest.

"But I'm not going to be a baby about it," he said, smiling, and relieved that this made Nikki laugh - not loudly, or even gleefully, just lightly, maybe with some relief. "I just... you know...." he trailed a finger over her hip and up to her belly-button, then to her sternum and on to her chin. "Needed to express my concerns."

Nikki's face, already softened, welcomed him even more generously. She kissed him on the lips: the kind of standard, married-couple, very *normal* kiss that he had grown to find boring but was now relieved to know still existed between them. "I know it's dangerous," she said. "But thank you for trying to see it from my side."

Jack smiled, going in for more, getting worked up. Nikki kissed him back. "I really want this," she said, quietly. "I really want to do it."

Jack touched her lower lip. Nikki was looking up at him, her head tipped, water rolling into her hair and dripping sexily from her chin to her breasts. She seemed to be saying this with a heartfelt sincerity, and more importantly, as though she cared what he thought: it wasn't so much a statement as a final question, a chance for him to stop her, and he could feel that energy as an electric, erotic pulse in beneath her skin.

He kissed her again, moving her to the side, pushing her back out and toward the bedroom, the bed his intended destination. "You know that if you want it," he said, between kisses, flinging his hand at the faucet handle to turn the water off, kicking the door open, "then you'll get it." He moved a hand to her pussy, working his fingers slowly into her flesh. "But I don't have to like it."

A purr left Nikki's throat as she smiled, and they made their way to the bed.

*

"So public place, huh?" Jack said, stroking Nikki's back. She turned her head up to look at him and smiled.

"Uh... why?"

Jack made a face and shrugged. "Just... wondering."

"I can't tell you any more than that," she said, sitting up. "It's *classified*." She waved her fingers like she did whenever someone told her about hair-brained nutritional supplements. "Also. I don't have the details yet."

Jack was silent.

"Ohhh," Nikki said, coming in for a kiss. "Don't change your mind now!"

Jack shook his head. "I'm not. I'm just, uh... I mean, Nikki. Be fair. This is a little worrisome. Okay?"

"I know," Nikki said, kissing him, her body moving sensually and - it seemed to Jack, though he was helpless to do anything about it - deliberately to distract him from the issue at hand. Jack rolled with it for a while and then pushed Nikki away gently and returned to his questions.

"So, are you going to have to pretend to be Slivovitz's... what? Girlfriend? Escort? What are you, in this scenario? You can at least tell me that, can't you?"

Nikki rolled over, sexily, and propped herself up on her hand. Her hair fell alluringly over her fingers and across her shoulder, backlit by the light. Her pale skin, golden hair, and flushed cheeks made her look impossibly young and angelic, but with the acrid scent of cum rising from her skin, and the tang of her pussy floating in the air, there was a double-edged filthiness to her heavenliness that gave a fierce kick to Jack's chest.

Nikki was transforming. Every day she was more like this, and less like the Nikki who had embarked on this adventure. Like a trainee, getting better every day, she was absorbing an assertiveness that only came out in people when they truly, genuinely, knew what they were doing.

Enough to play with it. To be fun. To make it look seamless and easy.

"I'm his *girl*," Nikki said, smiling. "It's like, a cross between hooker and girlfriend. I don't have to actually *do* anything with him, just make it *look* like we do..." Nikki's eyes sparkled and she became energized. It traveled under her skin, almost glowing it was so tangible. She moved closer to him, her limbs becoming liquid and sultry, her tongue running along her back teeth in her open mouth. "All the time. Every way he wants to."

Her fingers were moving down Jack's body playfully, but a predatory hardness was setting in in her eyes. She was turned on, very much so and almost too hot for Jack to handle. It wasn't stopping his cock from coming back to life, fueled by the bonfire of scenarios that Nikki had lit in his imagination.

"Uh-huh," he said, shakily, as Nikki kept crawling toward him, making him fall on his back. She climbed on him ravenously, her body heavy and heated, needy again. She was verging on monstrous, grinning. "So you don't have to actually... *practice* on him? Or do something with him in front of this mob boss or anything like that?"

His own voice surprised him. The question hadn't ended on a somber tone of warning; he wasn't leading her to say "exactly," and reassure him that nothing like that would happen. He ended the question on a hopeful note.

Please don't tell me you have to do something sexual with another man for this op.

Nikki settled her weight on Jack's thighs, her right hand between his legs, her left meandering all over her own body, almost like she wanted to point at her most hungry places, awaken them again, direct Jack to them. Collarbone, nipple, the faintest belly that swelled just below her navel and disappeared when she stood up. "Well, that's the thing..." she began, and watched him, hawk-like, for his reaction.

Whatever she saw told her to proceed, and proceed she did, leaning down to brush her lips over his chest. She bit very minutely into his nipple, taking only the tiniest piece of it between her teeth and nipping him hard. His cock throbbed and Nikki smiled, moving down his body, her head sweeping her hair over his chest, side to side, headed ever-downward. He felt each word

that left her mouth as the movement of her lips against his skin. "The *official* op is totally professional... but Tony told me it would go a lot better... if it looked... realistic..." Nikki paused, smiling, her lips just above his navel.

Her eyes shifted up to Jack's, and burned through him. His voice was caught in his chest and felt like a hard lump that would never be dislodged, so he didn't even try to speak.

Nikki moved her fingers again, tickling him, swiping his skin in feathery touches. "He thinks it's a good idea if I learn a few tricks..."

Jack's eyes opened wide in alarm. "On *Slivovitz*?"

Nikki smiled and looked up at him, but didn't answer, just opened her mouth and made a sound like a laugh. She shrugged after a while, moving down. "Maybe?" She smiled, and it was clear she was teasing, but it was still dangerously close to a real possibility, so it burned like the real thing. "Tony's pretty knowledgeable, though... he already taught me a few things..."

"Jesus, Nikki," Jack said, because his balls ached so badly after that sentence he thought he might vomit. He pushed up on his elbows.

Nikki had his cock in her hand and her lips close to the crown, but she smiled and sat up suddenly, tossing her hair and rising up on her knees. Her lithe body stretched out, her breast jiggling side-to-side until they were still, nipples hard. Her hand went between her legs, and like her previous motions, it seemed to be for the sole purpose of taking Jack's eyes to where it was going: her pussy. Just to remind him of it, the gushing, broken-open fruit of it. "Do you want to see the trick he taught me?"

Jack exhaled. It was all he could do.

Nikki interpreted this as a go-ahead, and hopped from the bed, excited. But this new excitement was different than even what she had just exhibited. It was her job-excitement, her learned-a-new-useful-skill excitement. It was abrupt and telling: Nikki may have had a deep *sexual* interest in Tony, but the excitement driving her now was her professional excitement.

"Okay, so pretend I'm a hooker, right?" Nikki said, leaning over to dig something out of her purse, which she had tossed in the corner of the room as usual. She stood up, her sexy-vixen act totally forgotten. Her new stance, other than being gloriously naked, looked much like the way she stood at the front of a meeting she was leading or a presentation she was giving: feet slightly apart (always be ready, her favorite trainer had told her at academy, to take a hit from a linebacker in any direction at any time. It was good practical advice that Nikki seemed to have sewn up into the fabric of her being).

She was ripping open a condom wrapper now, holding it up so Jack could see what she doing, exactly like she was teaching him a procedure.

But once she had it out of the wrapper, she looked at him and her eyes glinted. She walked toward the bed, each step sexier than the last. As she walked, she opened her mouth and placed the condom in it, holding the ring between her top and bottom teeth.

And then she crawled on top of him while he stared at her, transfixed and lost all at once. Smiling, she lowered her head, and Jack craned his neck to watch as she lined her mouth up with his cock.

He inhaled sharply, the rubber touched him first and then he felt the soft hard grind of her teeth sliding over rubber, over his cock, his shaft

disappearing into both the condom and the heat of her mouth at the same time. The ring rolled down, down, to the base of his cock, Nikki's lips right after it, the molten flesh of her mouth and throat on their heels.

Nikki worked her way back up his cock, released him with a wet pop, and sat back on her heels, admiring her work.

The condom was on his cock, textbook.

Nikki grinned at him and lifted her tongue to her teeth, pleased with her job. "Tastes a little weird," she said. She reached for his shaft and drew her fingers along the sides, stroking him through the rubber. "And I can't get all the way down on Tony..."

"It's a good trick," Jack said, staring at his cock.

Nikki tipped her head. "Thank you," she said, using her best Kyra Sedgwick voice.

"Are you going to use it on Slivovitz?"

Nikki smiled and met his eyes. Then she started to crawl up toward him, her breasts dangling, nipples occasionally scraping across his skin. "It might be something I have to do..." she teased. "At the very least, we have to make it look believable."

"Naturally," Jack breathed.

"And Tony thought it might be a good idea..." she continued, sitting back again and rising up on her hips. "To go out a few times with him. Supervised..." she swept her hand over Jack's chest. "Of course... and strictly... strictly... *professional*."

Nikki lined Jack's cock up with her dripping pussy and guided it through her flesh, trembling when she stroked him against her clit.

"What does that mean?" Jack asked.

Nikki shrugged casually. "Have some drinks. Practice hanging all over him. Establish some habits together..." Nikki slipped his cock into her pussy. Jack hadn't had a condom on in twenty years; the effect was thoroughly disorienting, the sensation tortuously fragmented: the heat of her pussy was attenuated, the wet all wrong, and yet something about feeling her through the latex was more stimulating than anything they had done before. She sank onto him and thrust her hips forward, driving him deep inside her.

She lay her body down on his chest and rolled her hips slowly. She moved her mouth to his ear and her breath tickled him, parts of his mind going insane - an insanity he could feel as it spun up, out of control and thrilling, piece of his mind reduced to pure barbaric lust - as she kept talking. "We have to have a few codes, some things I can whisper in his ear, things he can say in Serbian that I can pretend to understand... it needs to be believable that I'm just a pretty, witless... whore."

And that was the last thing she said until she made Jack come again.

CHAPTER 11

A week later, Jack found himself at Stripey's, sitting next to Tony, whose great big arms were spread out over the back of the half-moon booth he had chosen. It was a huge booth, and yet Tony took up almost all of it: beneath the table, his legs were manspread over almost the entire airspace.

The two weeks of "training" for the op had begun – to Jack's surprise – almost immediately. And almost immediately, he had felt himself in over his head.

Nikki spent her days going over what she needed to do, learning some basic Serbian phrases, getting practice with difficult situations that might arise. She was gone all day and often only returned very late at night.

She was reticent about details, which had already begun to burn in Jack's chest.

"I mean, babe," she had said, exasperated, one evening. "I just don't know which details I can give you."

"I just want to know," Jack had explained, pulling her close to him, "what, exactly, you're doing with Slivovitz. And Tony. While you're out."

And he wanted some control over it. He saw that now, he understood it. But there didn't seem to be any way to exert control over what Nikki was doing. He simply had to take her word for it, and Tony's, that it was strictly professional.

It was what Jack told himself, intellectually, he wanted: the precise demarcation of the professional and the personal, the job and the kink. Just as Tony had imperiously described it.

But he knew – in that dark place in his mind that he could never really quarantine or turn off – that he actually *wanted* Nikki to blur the lines. Keep pushing past all the boundaries – the few that remained – into darker territory.

But more than anything, what he really wanted was a front-row seat to all of it. And it infuriated him quietly – in that same dark place in his mind – that Nikki seemed so able to turn off her desire, to focus only on the job, to put the anal beads and lipstick marks and double-penetration out of her mind, and do a job that seemed to invite nothing but thoughts of those very things into the fray.

But Nikki surprised him on Saturday night. The kids were gone, Nikki had been for a half-day of training which she claimed was “purely linguistic and logistical,” but she stalked into the bedroom where Jack was returning and deleting low-priority emails on his phone while watching some hockey, neither of which he cared very much about.

Nikki was in her jeans and a tight shirt, looking very pretty with her hair down. She pranced a little when she came into the room, picked the remote up and turned off the TV, and then hopped onto the bed. “Guess what?” she asked him, excitedly, reaching for his phone.

“Nikki,” he said, moving his phone from her grasp. “My heart can’t take too many more shocks.”

This, at least, was something he was both sure of and sure it was true.

Nikki smiled and shifted her weight to one hip, her feet tucked under her. She threw herself onto the pillows next to him and extended a jean-sheathed leg into the air, playfully rolling her foot.

“Okay, I better not tell you then.”

Jack sighed.

Nikki grinned and turned her head to bite gently into his shoulder. Her hot breath, the soft prick of her teeth, reverberated inside of him as if she had made a slow circle around his dick with her tongue. “I have something tonight, in that case. To go to by myself, I guess.” She fluttered her eyes up at him. “If you’re not going.”

Jack was gripped by his fears and his fantasies again, rendered quadriplegic for a moment by the cold thrill slamming through him. He tossed his phone aside. “Well... maybe not so fast,” he countered.

Nikki smiled and extended her leg again.

“Tony wants me and Slivovitz to go out on, like, a mock date. At the bar. Try out our acting skills...”

Jack’s heart picked up the pace, and Nikki seemed to know that this was happening, because she moved her hand to his chest. “It’s just *flirting*,” she whispered into Jack’s ear. “But it has to look really *believable*. And you know how...” Nikki moved her hand down Jack’s chest, twisting it to slip it into his boxers and find his cock with her fingertips, strumming them on it lightly. “... I’m a perfectionist?”

Jack was staring at her hand moving beneath his boxers now, and he couldn’t think of anything to say. Even if he had wanted to claim some kind of indifference or displeasure to all that Nikki was doing with this op, his cock was telling her a different story. And that seemed to be what Nikki was listening to.

She squeezed his cock, smiling. “Well,” she continued, without waiting for his answer (she knew that he knew this about her, anyway), “I want it to be *perfect*, and something is *missing*, and Tony thinks it’s *you*.” She was stroking him again, her fingertips playing lightly on his tender crown, her thumbnail occasionally picking the raised ridge, pulling on it with a very slight nail, and then letting it go so it almost made a clicking sound.

Nikki was the only girl in the world Jack had ever known to do this. It was uncomfortable in the best of ways.

“And then I thought...” Nikki continued, because Jack didn’t gather his thoughts fast enough to say anything himself, “that I could do a really, really good job acting like a slut, if you were there, but also I had something to help me along...”

Now that he was at the bar with Tony, seated in a bench watching Nikki and Slivovitz together, Jack had the strange sensation of the preceding two hours never having actually happened.

Nikki had never stripteased for him (almost falling over when she tried to step out of her jeans, making them both laugh, spinning him into an orbit of charming normalcy for a brief moment).

That Nikki had never fetched her anal beads from under the bed, excitedly, dressed in nothing but her underwear, her feet kicking above her ass playfully.

That she hadn’t turned to him, flushed, and told him, as she fingered the beads in her hands, that she wanted to wear them all night while she did “the exercise” Tony had planned.

That she hadn't turned them on after putting them in his hands with a flushed face and an excited wetness in her eyes, the scent of her excitement rising from between her legs, to show him that they vibrated.

That when he had hooked a finger in the thick thong underwear and pulled on it gently, as part of a very unnecessary sequence of foreplay, his fingers had slid over the length of fabric that was next to her pussy all day, and in it he had felt her current moisture, but also the thickened, stiffened inflexibility of a fabric that had gotten wet and then dried, repeatedly.

It was much less believable than all of that, that he had done as Nikki asked, and pushed the ever-increasing in size string of beads into her, one by one, as she gasped beautifully and purred, her pussy dripping into the panties he had left stretched between her thighs while he filled her ass.

That she had asked him to fuck her while the beads vibrated inside her, and that her orgasm had appeared to make her very briefly lose consciousness.

That part of the surge that ushered his painfully large load of cum into her pussy was his own mind, quietly whispering: do you think her orgasm was that hard because of you? Or because she's thinking about what she's about to do?

But he wouldn't ask her that.

Because part of his own orgasm was surely tied not to Nikki herself, but to what Nikki was about to do.

And now he was here, at Stripty's, and Nikki was seated by Slivovitz at the bar, her ass full of anal beads that weren't vibrating, but could.

"So this is an exercise," Jack said, surveying Nikki and Slivovitz as they smiled and laughed at the bar together. Slivovitz was, to his credit, very

obviously explaining things to Nikki, and so their heated flirtations were punctuated by very jarring, real, and frequent interruptions to the ambiance, while Slivovitz held up a finger and pointed something out.

But Nikki wasn't exactly detached from him, and the way she touched his arm or thigh was not strictly professional-looking.

"The purpose of this exercise is twofold," Tony said, stirring his drink with the garnish sword and then tossing the whole thing onto his napkin and holding the drink in his huge paw without taking his eyes off Nikki and Slivovitz, who were at that moment standing at the bar looking like a fairly ordinary couple. "One, Nikki gotta get used to pretending she ain't understanding anything but Slivovitz, gotta learn a few quick phrases in Serbian, that kinda shit. And Slivovitz gotta see if she can do it. And they gotta have some chemistry, some familiarity, she gotta know he likes to stick his hand up her skirt and he's gonna be a real macho dick."

Jack made a face. "Not a far drive," he said.

Tony was watching them, and he emitted a lengthy, drawn-out "Nnnnnnnnaaaaaahhhhhh." Then he shifted his eyes to Jack. "This is a whole new level of asshole, man, these Eastern Europeans."

"Which kind of Eastern European, exactly, are we -"

"That there brings me to the second purpose of this soirée," Tony shot at him, as if he had expected that exact sentence to leave Jack's mouth at that moment. It was hard for Jack to look at Tony, because Nikki was giving her hair a toss and rubbing her hand on Slivovitz's fearsomely muscled forearm (approximately the thickness of Jack's bicep, and Nikki's calves) with her mouth open in a wide smile, impressed, or giving the impression of being so. Slivovitz himself was in full predatory mode, it was obvious in the way

he leaned toward Nikki, watching her face with obvious, arrogant pleasure as she inspected his assets one by one as he presented them to her.

But Tony held his gaze as if with steel forceps and dove in after a poignant pause, which seemed designed to test whether Jack could keep his head in the game or not. "The other reason you're here is to clarify a few things. One is that *you* don't need to know that shit. You don't need to know it, and you ain't gonna keep asking about it."

"Now, I'm fuckin' your wife, and so we obviously have to have a little... leeway, here, you and I. That's a gray area, if you get what I'm saying. And this op is also a gray area, if you get what I'm sayin'. But this here..." Tony gestured around himself, meaning, Jack could only surmise, the situation they found themselves in, "This here, is as gray as it gets. That clear to you, or you need more explanation?"

Jack blinked, stole a glance at Nikki, who was now being treated to Slivovitz drawing a shape on the back of her hand while she bit into her lower lip and giggling. "I do, actually, Tony, need more explanation."

He shifted his eyes back to Tony, who raised his eyebrows.

"Explain it to me like I'm -"

"Don't. *Fuck*. With my op."

Tony stared back at him, his face an unreadable and terrifying etching in stone.

"The *op* is *not* a gray area, man. Is what I'm sayin'. So you wanna sit here, watch your wife, get off on that, that's cool. But if you're sittin' here watchin' that, and you start to get some thoughts in your *big* head, you gonna keep them thoughts in your big head."

If there was anything to his buddy Mike's socio-sexual hierarchy bullshit at all, Tony certainly had Jack pegged as a delta. He was a keep-his-head down, do-his-job, be-reliable kind of guy. He was not an alpha, and he was not running around trying to be any alpha's right-hand man (beta, according to Mike). Most of the time, Jack was deferential to men like Tony, and while it left a mild distaste in his mouth, it felt like the way to behave: he was taking only the requisite amount of shit to not get decked, but you had to make it clear you weren't a doormat.

Every now and then, though - not very often, because they lived in a modern world, not a medieval Viking community - guys like Tony caused something inside him to spring loose, and Jack's instinct for survival got pushed aside by a sense of calm assertiveness. The feeling was practically chemical: a neutralizing agent seemed to spread through him, making him perfectly calm and totally unafraid of challenging a guy like Tony.

He had that feeling now.

"Tony," Jack said, sitting taller and then leaning forward. Even as Jack himself was just starting to feel out the change in his own attitude, he could see that Tony sensed it as well, because Tony leaned back and a smile flickered at the left corner of his mouth as he tipped his head back, like he needed a different view of Jack to confirm it was, in fact, him. "I'm not going to interfere in your op. But you're using *my wife* in it, and all I have to do is tell Nikki I don't like it, and she's out. That's *my* deal with Nikki."

Tony's whole body moved with a sort of silent huff and he grinned, folding his arms over his chest. "And?"

"And I don't know enough about this shit to know if I like it or not. That makes me default to telling Nikki not to do it."

Tony rubbed his lips together, still smiling. "And she gonna listen to you, I take it?"

"She will."

"That's the deal."

"That's the deal."

Tony looked up at the ceiling for a long time.

"All right." Back to Jack. A laugh. "What you wanna know?"

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In the end, Tony really wasn't able to tell Jack very much about any of it, but he was able to provide a good reason for not doing so – beyond his usual alpha shtick. Jack was filled in on the loose outline of the op – Nikki wasn't some critical component, but there more for believability than anything else: if Nikki could sell herself as Slivovitz's whore-girlfriend, believably, they believed they could snare their target's trust. Everything was supposed to happen without Nikki actually having to have sex with Slivovitz: this was the ideal outcome, Tony assured Jack, because then they wouldn't have to doctor anything for the courts.

"Meaning?" Jack had asked.

Tony had glared at him.

Then waved his big hand. "Look. These guys are all over legal loopholes, these fucking Russians. Right? So they know things like, no undercover cop gonna fuck a real hooker, because she might complain, get the whole thing bogged down in red tape and tossed outta court, if it ever gets there. No undercover cop gonna go in as a hooker, for obvious reasons. And no cops

gonna go in together for this kind of op, because it's too much exposure. These fuckers know a fake deal when they see it though, they test the waters, get guys to do things they can't do – but this is when they got doubts. Now, Slivovitz, he speaks Serbian, he got a great back story, he's movin' in slow on this -"

Tony cut himself off just as Jack started looking interested "You ain't gotta know, so you ain't gonna know," Tony bellowed. "He movin' in slow, but we were brainstorming how to grease these wheels a little and we thought of Nikki. She ain't a cop, there's ways to make her into an asset, and if Slivovitz gets in some tangle where he gotta actually fuck her – it ain't gonna come to that, so cool down – he can. And Nikki agrees she won't go bitching to the DA and spook them off the case if we ever get it together. Win-win."

All of this was delivered to Jack while Tony's hawk-like eyes were glued to Slivovitz and Nikki interacting at the bar. Jack couldn't read his expression for shit: he seemed at once greatly displeased and satisfied, and Jack wondered if that was the result of some similar tension playing out within Tony: between his job as a cop and his feelings - whatever they were - for Nikki.

"This goin' real nice," Tony said, after a while. He looked over at Jack, raising an eyebrow. "This goin' better than it has all week."

Tony said this with a tone that seemed almost accusatory and sent a frisson of fear through Jack for reasons he couldn't explain. He shrugged bravely, emboldened by his recent standing-up to Tony. "It gets her hotted up that I'm watching," he told Tony.

Tony's eyes shifted to Nikki, then back to Jack, a thinking grin forming on his lips. "Yeah," he intoned, disbelieving. "Nah, that ain't it, though, is it?"

Jack sipped a whiskey Tony had ordered for him and said nothing. He was starting to realize that what he didn't tell Tony, Tony figured out anyway. This was probably why Tony had been made a sergeant.

Jack shook his head a little and smiled, causing Tony to tip his head back a little in what Jack was starting to recognize as Tony's "reappraisal mode."

Which, Jack was loathe to admit, felt pretty good. Like catching a slipping rope, calming a wild horse, bringing something back under control in the field.

"Okay," Tony said, like they were playing basketball and Jack had just upped his game. "All right. So what is it you anglin' for here, Mr. Hillier?"

It was an unexpected turn. Nikki, as if she could have heard it from all the way across the room and did, tucked a strand of hair behind her ear and turned to look at Jack, smiling. Then she went back to "work" on Slivovitz.

Jack's mind moved at wild speeds, because the question wasn't one he had anticipated, because he suddenly had an upper hand with Tony that he had never expected to have, and because, at the heart of it all, he was torn between his own competing desires. The filthy ones, and the sensible ones. Danger and safety. Risk and reward.

He didn't want Nikki to sleep with Slivovitz, or suck his cock in a strip club, but that wasn't the main thing he wanted, or wanted to avoid.

The words were leaving his mouth before he even completed the thought about them:

“I want to watch the op.”

Tony’s reaction to this was to look at him, the same amused expression on his face, his own snifter of whiskey in his hand, suspended next to his cheek. Annoyance flitted around in his eyes, but his face didn’t change and he didn’t move a muscle.

And then, with a derisive snort, he tossed the whiskey back and set the glass down. He did so very carefully, like it was a precious museum piece and it needed to be arranged with surgical precision on the table. Even his eyes were on it, but Jack knew better by now: Tony was playing out the game in his head.

He abruptly lifted both arms again and spread them out over the back of the booth, his eyes shifting to Nikki.

“She got a real trashy sexual vibe goin’ on tonight,” he observed. Then he nodded.

Decision made.

“I’ll work somethin’ out,” he said.

And that, Tony indicated, with the hardening of his features all at once, was all Tony was going to say about it.

*

Tony eventually heaved himself up and walked over to where Slivovitz and Nikki were, waving his hands around, pointing things out around the bar. Nikki and the sandy-haired cop looked at him with rapt attention, their eyes brewing with the kind of dog-like loyalty a man like Tony evidently inspired in almost everyone he met.

Then he strolled back, and it was as if he had been a director on a movie set: Nikki and Slivovitz stood up and walked to the door, then turned around outside and walked in together.

The transformation was complete, at least to Jack's eye:

From head to toe, Nikki looked, very convincingly, like a real Eastern European hooker/stripper/girlfriend to a mobster. It wasn't just the trashy dress, or the trashy shoes, or the hair and garish lipstick: it was everything. Her unseeing eyes, conveying emptiness in her head. She draped herself on Slivovitz, her hands busy moving over his chest, fawning on him in the trashy and peculiar way that that kind of girl did.

"She coulda been cast in the Sopranos, this girl," Tony observed approvingly. He pointed at Nikki, beaming, eyes glued to her, but talking to Jack. "See that hooker walk she got? I taught her that."

"And the condom trick," Jack added, giving Tony the side-eye.

Tony chuckled, unfazed. "Taught her whole lot more than that," he said. He heaved his extremely thick arms up over the back again. "But that's all worst-case scenario. And Nikki always have an *out*. All she gotta do is hot the panic button and we extract her."

Jack turned to Tony. "I thought this was a strictly window-dressing thing," he said.

Tony lifted a few fingers and waved this all away. He cracked his neck and glared, intensely studying Slivovitz and Nikki now. "Yeah," he began, and then seemed to get distracted. There was a long pause. "But shit happens. She gotta be ready for it. And I'm tellin' you personal, man:"

Tony swiveled his great big head in Jack's direction. "Nikki wants to do a good job at this. She in it to win it." He paused. "So don't go fuckin' that up."

His warning delivered, mostly with his eyes, Tony brightened and shrugged.

"Worst thing gonna happen, she gonna suck Slivovitz's dick or some shit."

Jack must have had some kind of reaction to this, because Tony swiveled his head toward him again and smiled. "Don't *act* like you got a huge problem with it."

"Is she *practicing* that? In training?"

Tony shook his head and picked up his empty glass to scowl at it. "Brother, I gotta tell you somethin': I ain't into seein' that mouth on Slivovitz's cock at all, but what Nikki do when she leaves at night is her own thing." He held his drink up at a passing waitress who smiled broadly for him. "She is a bit of a perfectionist, though, so my guess is she at least know what it looks like."

Jack looked back at his wife, and Slivovitz, who was eating her up with his eyes over the rim of a beer glass. He wondered what Slivovitz knew: about Nikki and Tony, about Nikki's new sexual proclivities. Was he looking at her mouth and thinking of her condom trick, how to make it happen for himself? Or did he have a memory, as Tony suggested, of Nikki's fingers on his cock? Did he know that Nikki was the kind of girl who asked her husband to stuff her full of anal beads while she practiced sexualized flirting with dangerous men for a sexy, dangerous op?

Or did Slivovitz still think Nikki was the cute, energized good-girl that had applied for tactical team training as a paramedic, nothing more?

My guess is she at least know what it looks like.

Jack's head was spinning. Surely, surely Nikki would have told him if she did something with Slivovitz. It wasn't as if he would have objected. Would he have? He couldn't ask himself the question cleanly now, without his answer being tainted by what Tony had planted in his head.

When *had* Nikki come home from training this past week? Late, sometimes. Eleven, once. So late on Thursday that he had fallen asleep and didn't know. But would she have *lied* to him about Slivovitz? Omitted something? What was all this "other stuff" Tony claimed to have taught her?

His thoughts derailed as he sat back and watched the two of them flirting, to imagining Nikki with Slivovitz. Doing what? How did a guy like Slivovitz fuck a girl like Nikki? Which version of Nikki would he be fucking? What did they do together?

Tony looked over at him and shook his head at one point, like he had a wide, clear window into Jack's head and could see everything boiling inside.

"Don't over-think it, man," Tony said, and then he hefted himself up from the table and strolled over to Nikki and Slivovitz. The spell broke immediately, and Nikki turned back into herself. Tony dispensed his advice, whatever it was, and then he jerked his head to the right and he and Slivovitz walked over to a corner of the room while Nikki rolled her chair around and beamed at Jack.

Excited. On an adventure. Almost her normal self.

She smiled and picked up some drinks from the table, strolling over in her hooker getup with her normal walk, which looked strange.

"So?" she said, breathlessly, plopping into the booth. "What do you think?"

She scooted toward him, her limbs moving fluidly and sexily, like she was made of pliable rubber. She bumped her ass against his thigh playfully and grinned, before leaning in and whispering, "These beads are so fucking hot, I can't stop thinking about them." She closed her lips softly around his earlobe and then whispered, "They make it so hard not to squirm."

Jack exhaled, and with his breath, all of the questions he had been planning to ask Nikki escaped as well. Her lips were moving along his neck, her right hand creeping over his thigh, and anyway, his own head was sloshing full of thoughts about the beads and the way they must be moving inside her body as she crossed her leg and purred a little, squirming to adjust herself after the motion.

"God, Nikki," Jack said. A shudder traveled through him.

Focus, he thought to himself. You want to ask her about -

"Do you want to go fuck in the bathroom?"

He turned his head to look at his wife. She squirmed a little and smiled, biting on her pinky finger, her arm draped over the back of the booth. Her hand was feeling the hard contours of his cock now, her eyes glittering with the received information of his very solid erection and the small spot of precum that had oozed into his jeans since she had started whispering all of this to him.

Nikki waited only a moment for her answer, and that was the most terrifying aspect of her new personality of all: Nikki knew she didn't have to wait around for Jack's answer, because it was yes.

And even if it wasn't, if she wanted to, she could pick off any single man in this bar on her way to the bathroom, and get what she wanted.

This had always been true, of course, since the day they had met.

What was different now is that Nikki *knew* this.

And it seemed to Jack that she was *also* willing to act on it.

She smiled and stood up, moving her hips seductively. As she turned, she slid her fingers along her rump, beneath the fabric of the skirt, and deliberately lingered there, before tugging the stretchy material down over her ass.

Jack was still paralyzed, over-thinking, staring at this strange creature that inhabited his wife.

He reached out for Nikki's hand as she started to walk away, grabbing it, pulling her back toward the booth. She let herself be pulled back, put a knee up on the booth, and gave her hair a little toss.

"Nikki," he said, not sure himself what he was planning to say. The questions, what were the questions he had?

Nikki raised her eyebrows and waited for a moment. Then she shifted and moved her hips again. "Come on, Jaaaaack. I'm so *horny* after all that."

"Have you been sleeping with Slivovitz?" he blurted. "This week?"

Nikki looked shocked for brief moment - actually taken aback, as in, she leaned backward and a jolt traveled through her.

Then she glanced in Tony and Slivovitz's direction, her mouth open. A bit of healthy, pink outrage was climbing into her cheeks, and when she turned

back toward Jack, he expected to get unloaded on. The very suggestion!
How dare he!

But then a calm smile spread over Nikki's face, smoothing her brow, draining away the outrage. "No," she said, very causally. "But it wouldn't be a *terrible* idea."

She looked down at him. Jack was just piecing it all together - that Nikki hadn't taken his question as an accusation, or felt the need to defend herself against it - she had taken it as a *suggestion*. And he was too un-moored from - well, basically any mooring he ever had - to do anything about it except stare back at her, attempting to beam his conflicted feelings to her and hope she understood them.

Nikki tipped her head back, watching him. Her tongue began its journey along her back molars, a new habit for Nikki, very trashily sexual, very inviting and whoreish.

It was only in the microseconds that preceded Nikki clicking her tongue, dropping his hand, and turning on her heel, that Jack came to understand himself, and Nikki, and everything that had happened and was now in play:

He had always wanted Nikki to take the lead, for Nikki to declare for herself that she wanted something sexual, for Nikki to actually call the shots. In her relationship with Tony, he had been seeing it from the wrong angle: *Nikki* wanted to be fucked like a whore, worn-out and used. He had mistaken *that* desire for real submission, for Tony's control over her... and that was what had lingered, as a doubt or a dissatisfaction, however small, in their interludes with Tony.

But as she turned, her face imperious and full of raw sexual confidence (and mischief), he saw clearly for the first time what had probably been true for

much longer than he cared to admit:

Nikki was a badass.

All by herself.

She strutted a few steps, slowly, making sure to do it in a way that drew the attention of Slivovitz first. Because Slivovitz's face was hungrily telling and obviously distracted, Tony also swiveled his head -with a smile indicating that he knew exactly what he would see when he did.

Nikki walked over to them, leaned over the table, and whispered in Slivovitz's ear.

Slivovitz's eyes went wide, then shot over her shoulder to Jack, who took one of the drinks Nikki had brought with her - a shot, evidently of vodka - and slammed it.

Nikki trounced away to the bathroom. Four or five guys leaning on the bar had been watching this entire scene play out, and they looked at Nikki as she walked to the corridor, a woman in full possession of herself and her sexuality, and then glared at Slivovitz when he - admittedly, hilariously, somewhat unsteadily - followed her a few minutes later.

Tony shook his head, lifted a glass in a toast, but didn't even bother looking back to Jack.

He was grinning.

CHAPTER 12

Nikki reappeared first from the bathroom corridor.

Exactly nine minutes had gone by, but time had warped for Jack and it felt like several hours. However the magic of thinking worked, he managed to replay every detail of their night with Tony in his head, in slow-motion, as he waited.

Tony began a conversation with another cop, and within minutes he seemed to have the whole thing out of his head. He was gesturing wildly and saying “come on, man,” so loudly that Jack could hear it all the way across the bar.

More than a few guys had noticed Nikki go down the corridor – but it was hard to know how many of them knew anything about Nikki (like that she was married to Jack, who was sitting in a booth with an aching hard-on sipping vodka by himself), so their interest may or may not have lasted longer than it took for his ass to shimmy out of their eyesight.

A few eyes went from the corridor to Jack, and then back again, and then steadfastly on their own business, after Slivovitz followed Nikki.

Her legs appeared first, caught in some sunlight filtering through the wooden blinds on an old window that seemed to have been – yet again – shaken up by some kind of lurching fistfight. Her pale legs in the fuck-me pumps were surreal, emerging into light all by themselves for a moment, attached to nothing.

She strutted confidently to the bar, exchanged a *wink* with Tony, and then sauntered over to Jack. A low whistle erupted from a table near the bar, but it could have been for anything: dozens of sports were playing on dozens of

screens with no sound, or maybe someone was giving the gruesome details of a call.

Jack, of course, heard it as a low whistle for the brazen, slutty audacity of Nikki.

Nikki was perfectly kempt, looking exactly as she had when she entered the bathroom corridor. She smiled, her heels clicking confidently right up to the table, where she did a sexy tease, turning her hip to the side, and then plopped into the booth next to Jack.

She leaned her elbow on the bar and turned her head to Jack, still smiling.

Slivovitz still wasn't back yet.

Jack shifted, uncomfortable only because his erection was almost painful at this point, and maybe because he didn't know what to say. Nikki was driving the car, and she had been the whole time. He now felt a little like someone recovering from a smack to the head, piecing reality back together from the muddle of a flash-dream of unconsciousness.

Nikki touched a front tooth with her busy, sexy tongue, and grinned, leaning in. Beneath the table, her foot brushed deliberately against his calf and her free hand moved to his thigh. Her hand wrapped around his muscle and she rotated inward, toward his groin, her pinky finger flicking playfully at the contours of his cock.

Jack raised his eyebrows as a form of asking her to go ahead and do whatever she was planning to do. His attention was everywhere all at once: a shard of focus on the corridor, to see Slivovitz return, on the guys at the bar who seemed to be stirring now that Nikki returned, and with who knew *what* sentiments. On her fingers, moving over his jeans and sending

shudders of intense pleasure through his body. His balls hurt. The scent of Nikki's pussy was rising from beneath the table, and his eyes were searching her face for telltale signs of whatever she had done.

"That," she whispered in his ear, "wasn't as satisfying as I'd hoped for." She licked his earlobe.

Jack exhaled, and moved his eyes to the last dregs of his whiskey. His heart was racing.

"Don't you want to know what I did?" Nikki asked, squeezing his cock between two fingers, then moving her hand down to his balls and drawing circles on the taut fabric of his jeans. The sensation barely made it through the thick fabric to his balls, and he didn't know whatever to feel disappointed or thankful for that.

"Did you... what did you do?" Jack managed to ask.

Nikki pushed herself off the table and leaned in close to him, swinging one of her legs over her own lap and also his thigh, turning to face him. She rested her head on his shoulder and tilted it to look up at him. These gestures were all foreign, all hooker-playacting, but she did them convincingly.

"I tried the condom trick out on him," she purred. "And he liked it." A giggle. "And then... I sucked on his cock for a while, which he also... seemed to like... and then..." Nikki's fingers were picking at the button of his pants, twisting it through the hole, now they were working on the zipper.

Jack's eyes scanned the bar. No one was looking directly at them, but it was pretty obvious that plenty of people were attuned to what was happening there. Still no sign of Slivovitz.

“And then, because he was like, already going to come – his dick was *so hard* right from the start, and even a little bit of...” Nikki smiled as she twisted her wrist and stuffed her own hand into Jack’s pants, found the crown of his cock and swirled her thumb over the slick precum she encountered.

Even a little bit of precum.

Well, sure. Slivovitz and every fucking guy in the bar, except for maybe a handful of dudes with a lot of money on whatever sports game they were screeching at.

“And so then... nothing special.”

Nikki smiled, her eyes full of mischief. His cock responded to this tease by pulsing violently, and he realized that Nikki – as she usually did with everything – was not going off anything anyone told her. Not Jack, not Tony, not Slivovitz. Nikki knew that most psychological truths deposited themselves somewhere in the body, and so she was taking a reading right now, and she had the real answer to any question *she* might have been interested in.

No matter what Jack *said*, his cock betrayed that he was profoundly turned on by what she had just done.

“Nothing... special...” Jack repeated. He was adrift in his own mind.

Nikki flitted her thick, slutty-black mascara-coated eyelashes and smiled.

“Did you want to know exactly what we did?”

Now she had freed his cock, and it was wedged in the v-shape of his zipper, with his boxers buffering the teeth, but the discomfort coming through weakly, overridden by his desires but present, titillating. She formed a

cluster with her fingertips – like one would hold a ball of dough by all five fingertips, and started to move them over the crown of his dick, a motion reminiscent of jellyfish.

Slivovitz was strolling out of the corridor now, and Nikki didn't look back at him, even though she clearly saw that Jack saw him, because she grinned a little again.

“I put my hands on the wall... in a stall, you know... and he pushed my skirt up, and tugged my panties down...”

Jack had to close his eyes as a wave of pain and extreme pleasure collided somewhere in his groin. It was difficult not to groan.

Slivovitz stopped in his tracks when he saw Nikki and Jack, but whatever he thought of it, he recovered from it quickly and looked down at Tony, who was already looking up at him, smiling. Both men shrugged in their own way, and Slivovitz sat down.

He did, however, rotated his bar stool around slowly to watch the show.

“And he saw the end of the beads, so he tugged at them... and pulled one out, then pushed it in, and so, I asked him to keep doing that while he fucked me.” Nikki sat up brightly, tossed her hair as she looked over her shoulder, and then whipped it back to face Jack. “Which is why, probably, that was such a quickie...”

Jack's face felt sweaty. His neck definitely was. He could only bounce around to one thought at a time: Nikki's fingers, Slivovitz sipping a beer and staring at them like they were at a carnival, the image of Slivovitz tugging anal beads from Nikki's ass as she bent over with her hands on the bathroom wall...

It was all too sordid and yet not sordid enough.

“Did, uh... did you...” Jack stammered. Tony was looking at him now, shaking his head, grinning. “Did you, uh, come?” he asked.

Nikki bit into her lower lip. She seemed very amused by this question, and as soon as he asked it, Jack realized it was silly: Nikki, for however much she pretended to be – or once was – a submissive girl who waited for men to tell her what to do and get her off, was not the kind of woman (at least not now) to leave a bathroom fuck without getting off.

His question was really more about who had made it happen: was it more Slivovitz, or more Nikki?

Nikki grinned, and slowed her pumping of the top quarter of his dick to a tortuously slow pace. “Of course I *came*,” she whispered into his ear. “But now... I’m just more... worked... up.”

Tony and Slivovitz were looking at them. Nikki was smiling. Jack could hear nothing but his blood rushing in his ears, and he knew he wouldn't be able to for a while.

"I have to take you home then," he said, almost listlessly.

The pink of Nikki's tongue slid over a molar, and she tugged his zipper up halfheartedly. "Bingo."

CHAPTER 13

"Guys. This is Jack. Jack, this is Guy One, that's Guy Two." Tony pointed at the two techs so rapidly and dismissively that it would have been impossible to know who was who, even if that had been their real names.

Tony's big finger pointed to an empty seat next. "You. Sit there. If you talk, move, or do anything these guys don't like..." Tony's eyes moved to the seated cops, who appeared busy with what they were doing and not to be listening at all. "They have permission to shut you up, any way they see fit."

One of them smiled and exhaled a laugh, but didn't turn around to look at Tony or Jack. "Copy that, big T."

Tony glared at Jack. "You gonna fuck up my op?"

"Nope."

Tony glared for a few poignant seconds longer, and then slammed the door shut and gave it the quick, two-bang signal for ready to roll.

Only when the vehicle was moving did one of the guys - not the one who laughed - roll his chair around and lean back in it, surveying Jack with an amused expression on his face. His eyes dropped to Jack's crotch and lingered for a bit, and then he chewed delightedly on a piece of gum that Jack hadn't realized he had in his mouth. "Just checkin' out the size of your balls, buddy."

This made the other guy laugh again, in much the same way. He was busy adjusting something technical and didn't look away from it, but he slurred a "whooo eeeee," and then dropped into a Slavic-sounding language to mutter something under his breath.

Jack raised his eyebrows and the first guy let his chair roll slowly back to face him toward his own set of screens.

"Nico says it's not the size, it's the heaviness," the first guy said, amused.

"*Density*," Nico slurred again, without looking up. "It is density of balls that matters." He directed something at the first tech in the language, which made the first guy smile, clack a few things on his keyboard, and then shoot his fist into Nico's shoulder unexpectedly.

Nico ignored this but turned around abruptly to look at Jack. His speech was very lightly marred by a Russian-sounding accent. "So you are first civilian cosmonaut in my spaceship. I don't know what you tell Tony, and I don't know what Tony tells you. This is Tony's operation. But this is Nico's van. Okay? And if you fuck around in Nico's van, you will find out."

Nico raised his eyebrows expectantly and glared at Jack, who nodded and held a hand up, palm out, so Nico knew he did not intend to find out anything like that.

First guy was laughing silently but theatrically, letting it shake his whole body so that Jack could see it. "Ehhhh," he said. "Nico's only packing a taser."

"I am number-one boxing champion in weight-class and age," Nico said, stonily.

"Yeah, Nico? What's that? Featherweight grandad?"

Nico smiled without taking his eyes off Jack and held a hand up to his ear. "What's that, little sparrow? I don't hear so good. I hear you saying you want grandad's fist in your face. But maybe I am hearing wrong."

The first guy let his chair back swing back around, slowly, grinning at Jack, who was taking the stance he took whenever he found himself in the midst of a group of police anything, which was to stay out of the firing line as much as possible. "If you talk any shit to Nico," he said, loudly. "Make sure you do it on his left side."

Jack moved his head slowly - but clearly - side to side. "Not talking any shit about Nico."

A fat, gnarled finger stained yellow at the knuckle shot out of Nico's fist. "Talk shit about Nico!" he yelled, suddenly - and scarily - joyful. "I welcome the shit!" He was then deadly serious. "But don't fuck the shit up in Nico's van."

"Nope," Jack repeated.

Nico seemed satisfied with this and swung his own seat back toward his computers. First guy chuckled and then leaned on his knees with one arm out to shake Jack's hand, which Jack did warily. This van was a caricature of itself, and he could only half-believe any of it was really happening. "I'm Guy. Can I just say, I do not know *what* strings you pulled to get in here, but I, for one, am dying to know -"

"You pull at strings, I get shit on head," Nico mumbled darkly, tapping his temple. "Do not teach idiot to pull at strings, do not teach monkey to hold grenade." He added something to this in his language.

Guy shot him a look and swerved back to his own computer bank, still talking to Jack. "I'll give you my card, man. Take you out for a beer, see what you gotta do to lather up big T's -"

Nico let out a string of Russian just then and banged his fist on the wall separating the driver's compartment from the van itself. "You drive like shit, shit for brains!"

A series of taps in a cheeky tune followed from the driver's side, which made Nico grumble evilly in his native tongue, and Guy (as he appeared to actually be called) snort with laughter.

"This is going to be shit day," Nico said, after a while.

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It was many, many hours later, and two horrifying vignettes of Guy pissing into an empty water bottle, sealing the cap, and tossing it haphazardly into a blue bin, before the op was actually underway. It became clear during this incredibly long and boring time that Guy was more in charge of the van than Nico, technically, but Nico seemed to get deferential treatment for exuding Russian mafia vibes so convincingly.

Jack was deeply interested in Nico's "story" - he gave off the vibe of a spy - but he wasn't about to "find out" if there was such a thing as a featherweight grandad boxing class that had admitted Nico, who was not a featherweight or much of a granddad: he had white hair and a wizened face, but it was more of a hard-life look.

Jack was not interested in verifying this for himself. Nico looked like the kind of guy who faced fights of all sizes and shapes with his arms crossed and a stoic expression, and then ended them before they got going with one clean punch out of nowhere.

"Okay, we go now," Nico said, after a long lull and a sudden burst of radio activity that was so coded that Jack couldn't make anything of it at all. Nico

swung around one more time and pointed his finger again. "You. Watch from there. Use eyes for watching. Your mouth. It stays shut. Your feet and your hands, they stay -"

"Inside the vehicle," Guy quipped.

Nico looked skyward and muttered what seemed to be a short prayer in his language, and then wiped his face with his hand before affixing his frightening gaze on Jack again. "I am translator. I translate. Don't ask me 'what, what?' Okay? Because I hate this."

"It stresses him out," Guy affirmed. Nico looked over at him and Guy looked back. "What? It stresses you out."

Nico swiveled back around without verbal comment, but his face said enough for Jack to know that "getting stressed out" was not the reason Nico wanted him to shut up.

"I got it, Nico," Jack said.

Nico leaned in to a computer screen that was rapidly spurting out lines of incoherent code and lifted his glasses, seemingly absorbed. But after a few seconds, he said, in a low voice, "Maybe brain is dense, not just balls."

"That's a compliment -" Guy began, but the two of them reacted to something over the radio, simultaneously adopting total concentration and putting on headphones. Jack zipped his lips and peered at the screens, vowing not to ask for his own headphones even though he could see an extra set hanging between them.

For the next few minutes, everything was silent, and Guy and Nico became totally absorbed in their tasks, rapid-firing communications in neutral, efficient voices and flipping through screens with the kind of practiced,

effortless technical skill that Jack didn't know anything about but could recognize was the hallmark of highly competent people who were the very best at what they did.

Whatever that was.

What followed was mostly seen through the grainy black-and-white of their surveillance camera feed, and silent.

They had several cameras in the strip club, and for a while continued to cycle through the shots. It took Jack a while to figure out which of the glitzy, trashy women hanging on the arms men in expensive but sleazy suits was Nikki, and which of the suits was Slivovitz.

Jack had only *met* Slivovitz once at Stripey's, and seen him pass by, hollering like a frat boy, in the hotel where Nikki and Tony had begun their tryst, and distantly as the man his wife had blown in a bathroom. The whole time this op had been in the works, it had been very difficult for Jack to imagine how the bulky, loud, Slivovitz, who *radiated* the ethos of cop, even when he was just sitting in a chair, would fare undercover as... whatever it was he was undercover as.

But without color to guide him to her blood-orange dress, he had a hard time finding Nikki, and Slivovitz blended so well that until the team settled on a camera that had a view of what looked like a VIP enclave, where several rough-looking men in suits were arranging themselves, scantily-clad women in their wake, strippers fawning and taking orders, and muscle standing ominously all around them, that he identified them.

Nico lifted his hand and put a pudgy finger in front of Slivovitz, who had grown his dark blond hair out and slicked it back, hidden some of his mega-bulk with a cleverly tailored suit, and had adopted a smooth new walk and a

cagey sneer that disguised - at least to Jack - all indicators of his police status.

But Nikki was the real piece of work. Only after a few moments of staring at her, and repeating silently to himself that this was Nikki, did Jack fully understand that it was her.

In grayscale, the dress lost some of its trashiness, but not all: the papery texture of it was evident even through the poor resolution: it clung to what parts of her body it didn't leave bare, and very little was left to the imagination. She draped her arms and hands all over Slivovitz and sat next to and behind him, her face a believable mixture of boredom and cluelessness, just like a non-English-speaking whore/mafia mistress would probably act.

Jack watched the first fifteen minutes with no idea what was happening, and Nico and Guy went about their business without comment to him. It might have been boring, if not for the level of danger and the fact that it was his wife who was clinging to Slivovitz, leaning in to stroke one side of his face while saying something in his ear.

When Slivovitz fired up a cigarette, Nikki sat, looking bored, and watched the cigarette with longing, before wriggling her fingers toward it.

Slivovitz smiled at her and brought the cigarette to her lips. Nikki took a drag - smoking with no problem at all, which made Jack's stomach lurch; Nikki would have had to practice that - and Slivovitz's mouth moved, which made Nico chuckle and Guy smile. Jack closed his eyes to repeat to himself that he was not going to ask for the headphones, and when he opened them, Nico was passing them back to him.

"Slivovitz made good joke," he said, dryly. "He says he hates smoked cheese."

Jack adjusted himself to be able to have the headphones on, which was back-breaking and he knew he would pay for it later. A wild, cluttered feed filled his ears, and it took a few seconds to match the visual scene to what he was hearing. He supposed it was because the microphones were in very strange places, but he wasn't about to ask. It was only after this difficult arranging of himself that the punchline of Slivovitz's joke hit him, and his stomach hollowed out yet again.

Slivovitz and the others were speaking English - Slivovitz without an accent, the other male voices with heavy accents and regular breaks into what sounded like Russian. Nico didn't translate most of this, except to say, into a microphone that he had thus far kept hovering above his head, "Tango asks this guy to go get cigarettes for Nika." Nico chuckled and shook his head. "She snaps trap just like pro."

Guy glanced over at Jack at that point and raised his eyebrows excitedly. "He likes her," he mouthed more than whispered, and it was up to Jack to determine if it was Nico, or "Tango," or "He" that Guy was referring to.

Jack stared at Nikki while listening, comprehending nothing. They may have been speaking English, but it was all coded or references to things he didn't have any clue - or want to - about. Nikki's makeup was dark and showy, her eyes ringed by so much shadow that she didn't look like herself at all, and she had such a pouty face on that she was unrecognizable. If someone had pointed to the image of her and Jack hadn't had any context, he would have testified in court that the woman on the screen was not his wife.

Everything about her - the way she moved, the way she stared vacantly at her fingernails and reacted to nothing that anyone said to her, was masterful and almost unbelievable: Jack was filled with a perverse pride, and a swell of humiliation when he thought about how he had worried about Nikki's ability to perform her role. She wasn't just competently doing it, she was knocking it out of the park - if the goal was to look like a clueless hooker fresh off the boat.

The man - a muscle guy - who had been sent off for cigarettes, so presumably the "Tango," Nico referred to, returned and set the cigarettes down, opened and with one cigarette pulled out from the rest, in front of Nikki. This was evidently a very poignant gesture, because Nico murmured, "Oh, here we go," brightly, and chuckled, and Guy grinned. "What-is-gonna-happen-here?" he sang quietly.

A pit was developing in Jack's stomach all along, and it plummeted to his feet as he watched the screen. Nikki looked at the cigarettes hopefully, and one of the seated men - judging by the way he carried himself and the way the others scrambled around him obsequiously, the most important one at the table - leaned forward and nudged the box in her direction.

Jack didn't clearly hear what he said, but it was something about smoked cheese that made a few seated men laugh loudly, and Tango grin as he resettled himself like a gargoyle at the boss's side.

Slivovitz lifted his own cigarette to his lips and looked very Slavically peeved for a moment, staring at the jokester. Nikki did a wonderful impression of looking confused, and then looking to Slivovitz, who glared at the man who had nudged them to her before leaning over to her and saying something in - Jack supposed - Serbian.

"He says go ahead and smoke cigarettes, fuck."

Slivovitz lifted his hand and pointed at Nikki while he said the next bit.

"Enjoy, because you are off them tomorrow... what is this? Honey badger? Hoi, *idiot*"

Nikki looked uncertain. She was doing such a good job of looking perplexed and uncertain that Jack forgot, momentarily, that she was only pretending not to understand English - and so he felt a surge of fear that Nikki, without Nico's translation in *her* ears, wouldn't know what to do.

"Yes, good, she takes it slow..." Nico narrated. "Hesitate, good. She looks to idiot, thinking..."

Nikki looked from Slivovitz to the presumptive boss, and back again, before gingerly taking the cigarette and smiling. She leaned toward Slivovitz and whispered in his ear, shyly glancing at the boss guy.

Slivovitz yelled at her impatiently: "It's 'thank you.' Jesus," followed by a string of Serbian, then a look back at the boss. "She is so beautiful, but so stupid," he laughed, and everyone laughed with him while he lit Nikki's cigarette.

Nikki held the cigarette up, and, as if she were truly afraid of Slivovitz and also the man she was speaking to, smiled shyly and said, in a great-sounding accent, "Thankszzh you." And leaned back in her seat, looking bored again. Tango produced an ashtray from nowhere and she moved her lips again, but whatever she said was barely audible.

"She is good, your little medic," Nico said, to no one in particular, and possibly even to Tony. He said it through a microphone that he often put up, where it hovered in front of his forehead.

The men at the table continued to talk, and the whole scene had an air of extreme danger about it, even without Jack knowing what was being discussed. He in fact preferred not knowing what was being discussed, because it seemed like the kind of thing that could require witness protection services. It was all so surreal that he occasionally felt like he had been transported into a TV show.

After a few minutes, the various girls strewn around the tables like wilted cut flowers rose simultaneously, bidden, Jack could guess, by nothing more than a dark look from the head honcho. Nikki was looking admirably glazed over, so much so that Jack began to wonder if she hadn't slipped something to herself. She had finished the cigarette and put it out before yawning and staring off in the distance, slumped in childlike pose that made her seem almost twenty years younger than her actual age. She moved a foot - encased in the ultra-slutty heels Tony had purchased - lethargically and looked as bored as it seemed like she would have if she had really been the only one at the table who understood nothing.

The girls left after numerous men present had fondled their asses, and this activated Nikki to look around and then to Slivovitz, who said nothing, just leaned forward to ash his cigarette and have a mafia-guy stare-down with the other man. "Nika, baby," he said in English, lifting the cigarette pack and handing it to Nikki without looking at her, "Go take a walk, look at some girls."

Nikki took the cigarettes, her face uncomprehending. Fear raced along Jack's spine and gripped his balls, but it was once again misplaced. Nikki held the cigarettes, looking confused, blinking at Slivovitz, who didn't look at her immediately, then turned his head, looked her up and down, and screamed at her in Serbian.

Nikki's eyes went wide, and she jumped a little. Then she pouted and stood up, but as she did, the head honcho was saying something repetitive in Russian.

"He says calm down, calm down, calm, down, shit, this man is a real... country bumpkin," Nico translated dryly.

The speaker continued in English, with Nico "translating" right after him, seemingly unaware that the Russian had switched to English. Guy shrugged and smiled at Jack.

"You don't know how to treat a lady, Slobo, come here *myska*, I give you lighter and some money for girls. Tell her."

"He says: 'you don't know how to treat woman, Slobo, come here little mouse, I'll give you lighter and money for the strippers. He says to idiot, tell her," Nico murmured, monotone, on a one-second delay.

Slivovitz was already icily translating to Serbian, and Nikki made sure to wait until he finished to look back and forth between the two men, as if torn in her loyalties.

Which seemed believable, but what did Jack know?

Nico was impressed, smiling and nodding. "She thinks about it... she walks to him, this is very good supernumerary, this girl..."

"This is tense," Guy whispered, his eyes glued to the screen.

Nikki hesitated until Slivovitz, after grumping for a few moments, jerked his head in the direction of the mob boss and spat something in Serbian.

Nikki walked over to the boss, who leaned back to look at her lasciviously and put a hand on her thigh, squeezing it, then moving it up and over her

ass while giving directives to "Tango," who handed her a lighter and a thick wad of bills, with a stony face. Nikki looked terrified for a moment, and everyone sucked in their breath, even Nico.

"Thhhthank you," Nikki said, after seemingly struggling with remembering her language lesson.

She received two pats on the ass for that, and Slivovitz barked at her some more in Serbian while waving her away with a gesture that was decidedly foreign. The head honcho turned to watch Nikki leave.

"I like this girl," he declared to Slivovitz. Nikki disappeared from view and Jack started to panic quietly in his own heart, but Guy was fiddling with things and pretty soon had another screen filled with more grainy coverage of the strip club, and he pointed at Nikki's figure, strolling through. Into his own mic he said "I've got eyes on the cat and we're all clear."

Jack shifted his attention to Nikki, who walked toward the other girls who had been sent away. They had strewn themselves around the bar and were chirping away like birds, but glared at Nikki as she approached.

Nikki held a hand out.

Jack forgot his forsworn duty to shut up and leaned toward Guy. "What if these girls speak Serbian? Nikki doesn't -"

Nico turned and gave him a solemn, soul-crushing look.

Guy hadn't even turned around, just shook his head very quickly and subtly, almost like a tick. "These girls," he said, "don't speak." He lifted a finger to the screen and let it hover over a blob of a man standing near them and whispered. "This guy? This guy is the enforcer. If they speak Serbian, or

English, or too much anything, to Nikki, he's gonna drag them across the bar by the hair -"

Nico glared, and Guy snapped his mouth shut.

"It's not a worry," Guy said, after a few moments, during which time Nikki had pretended to need a lighter, and one of the girls had lit her cigarette after an icy exchange of pantomimes. Something transpired among them: a shy smile, an exchange of shared misery, something girly that Jack didn't understand any better than Nikki probably understood the implications of the cockfight at the table. Whatever it was, the Russian girls moved a little for Nikki to stand next to them and quit throwing such obvious shade at her.

But it *was* clear that no one was going to talk to her. And that the identified enforcer was the reason.

"Clever," Guy commented.

Nico lifted his left hand like he had just seen a bad call on a football game, highly annoyed, sighing audibly, and Guy murmured, "Cat is settled in, all green on Cat."

Nikki stood and pouted and smoked another cigarette, her eyes on the girls dancing on the platform. She fiddled with the wad of cash, which drew some looks from the Russian girls, and Jack wondered where she had stashed the lighter given to her by the mob guy. She leaned on the bar and crossed one leg over the other.

Nico was busy speaking into the microphone, saying he couldn't hear, cussing, and huffing on a vape pen he had produced from nowhere.

*

This went on for what seemed like an eternity, and Nico was translating only side comments in Russian, and not for Jack, Jack started to get not so much bored as anxious. The longer he watched the shady characters on the screen, and stared at his long-legged wife smoking cigarettes (cigarettes! Nikki!) next to the Russian chicks, the more dangerously surreal everything became. At one point, he had to actually tamp down an urge to jump out of the van (he had no idea where they were, in relation to the strip club, or anything else in town), and put an end to the op he had approved of and now wished to retract his approval from.

These guys were all crazy. And Nikki was in their midst, wearing nothing but a flimsy, skin-tight hooker costume and smoking cigarettes.

The men blathered, some strippers came over to the table and began doing lap dances - including to Slivovitz. Nico slapped his hands together when this happened and declared "Very good sign!"

Jack marveled at the men on the screen, behaving like they really were from the set of the Sopranos or some other mob drama. The alpha moves, the caricatured masculinity. The vices and showmanship.

"Ehhhh," Guy murmured, a few minutes after this. He pointed his right ring finger at the screen, hovering over "Tango" and making a swirl to a guy who didn't talk a lot, wasn't a bodyguard, but evidently was important. This man was leaning in toward Tango and saying something in his ear. "I don't like this," Guy said slowly, his finger still circling the two figures on the screen. "Tango's looking thinky."

"What is this, looking thinky?" Nico sighed, leaning over to look at Guy's screen, even though his own showed the same image. He seemed greatly annoyed.

"Something's not kosher here," Guy said.

Nico was no longer sighing, but squinting. He put his glasses on his forehead and leaned in to the image. Then he went back to his own station and started flipping switches and muttering in Russian.

"What? What is it?" Jack asked, but even as he did, and before Guy looked over at him uncomfortably, willing him to shut up, he knew he would get no answer.

"Can't isolate... this one is sneaky like rat..." Nico was saying.

To Jack, it didn't look like much was going on, but he was feeling tension building in the van, also in his own muscles, and that made the scenes on the screens *look* wildly dangerous. The ambiance seemed to have shifted. Everyone was suddenly deeply in action - Guy, Nico, the voices ringing tinnily in their headsets. Radio traffic, coded and unintelligible, picked up.

Jack looked at Nikki, whose attention had shifted to the VIP room, where a ribby stripper with black hair and impossibly large tits was giving Slivovitz a lap dance. Slivovitz was watching the dancer with what seemed like practiced disinterest, and Tango and his right-hand man were occasionally exchanging words in each other's ears while staring impassively in the direction of the dancer. But even Jack knew this was some kind of size-up of Slivovitz.

"Okay, okay, okay," Guy whispered, his eyes only inches from the screen now. He was absorbed in whatever he was watching, his eyes moving rapidly, his foot tapping under the desk. "What's she gonna do?"

"This is where boys and men go..." Nico said, rubbing his hands together and then spreading them apart in different directions, with a whistle. He

waved his finger at the screen and started talking into his microphone.
"There is something he's not liking, this Tango," he was saying.

A pause.

"Okay," Nico said. He flipped the mic up again and pushed his glasses onto his forehead, then selected a phone from several that were charged and labeled in some kind of convoluted code and began typing.

Guy didn't look up. "You pullin' the plug?"

Nico typed. Jack stewed and actually had to bite into his tongue to keep from talking. Everything that had been exciting about the op was now turning to dust, and all he could feel was terror for Nikki - even if he didn't know what was going on, exactly. Nothing super dangerous *seemed* to be happening.

Nikki, on the screen, suddenly plopped a purse that Jack hadn't even seen until then onto the bar and dug into it, dumping what looked like a variety of lipstick and makeup containers onto the bar before retrieving a phone and tapping it. She did all of this very clumsily and with zero stealth. Jack felt a jolt of panic and leaned forward.

"Are you getting her -" he began, and Nico snapped his fingers in Jack's ear to cut him off, the sound as loud as it seemed humanly possible for two fingers to snap. He hissed violently and pressed his headphones to his ears.

Guy was nodding, almost smiling. He stole a glance at Jack. "It's good, it's cool, it's okay. She's doing everything right."

The "enforcer" Nico had pointed out did not seem to think so. He snatched Nikki's phone and started screaming at her - but the audio was not coming through on Jack's headset. Nikki waved her hands and her mouth moved,

and the enforcer stared at her screen and then tossed her phone aside, dug through the contents she'd deposited on the table, and then glared at her with a finger held up in the air.

"She says, mother, mother, mother... sounding very good, Slivovitz is good teacher of tongues... yes, now she reads message... and now show is up to her."

"What message?!" Jack demanded.

Nico held up a hand. "You shut up now."

Nikki stuffed her things back into her purse, somewhat unhurriedly, and then looked at the message again. Jack held his breath, the pain building almost immediately in his lungs, but he wanted it.

Nikki leaned with two elbows on the bar, looked side to side, appeared to be getting quite *angry*, glanced up at Slivovitz, fumed visibly, dug in her purse again, turned around to the bar and ordered a drink, looked at Slivovitz again, and fumed some more.

Guy grinned.

Nico said something like, "Ehhhhh-i-yo-yoi" and put both hands on the back of his head, leaning back. "You have team ready, yes?" he said, into the mic he lowered while rubbing his head. "I don't know. Which way is this going to go... which way, little mouse - "

"Cat is moving."

"What she is doing?" Nico asked the screen, leaning in.

Nikki was stomping, in quite an evident tizzy, back to the table where Slivovitz's stripper was now taking a seat on his lap. She stomped right up

to them and folded her arms impatiently in front of Slivovitz, tapping her foot.

Jack stared. "*What* is she doing?" he demanded of Guy, in a whisper.

Guy was dumbstruck. He shook his head slowly, his face the picture of awe. He looked over at Nico, who looked over at him, and then they turned back to the screen.

"We are in woods now," Nico said, but the man was now grinning.

He evidently liked the woods.

Jack was freaking out inside, and he was about to do something stupid, he could feel it.

Nico turned to him eerily in time with his thoughts, and pointed at his headset with one finger. Jack just then noticed that Nico had two headsets overlapping each other, one on his right ear and the other on his left ear, their brackets piled over the top of each other like an obvious pro. "A little voice in my head saying, 'tell motherfucker not to fuck with my op.'"

Nico turned back to the screen and started doing something on a keyboard very rapidly. "This is Tony saying this," he said, wryly grinning, as if he knew that Jack could not have been confused about it in any way.

Jack stared at the screen. His vision was blurring slightly, and he knew it was the effect of his extremely high blood pressure, which he could hear pounding in his ears. His eye stung suddenly and he feared the worst – an aneurysm or the final moments of consciousness before he went into full cardiac arrest, but he blinked and a twinkling drop of sweat splintered into his eyelashes and clung to them, just as another drop of stinging water fell into his other eye.

He wiped his brow, felt sick, and then realized that it was excessively hot in the van, no doubt because of all the computers humming away on full blast.

He couldn't make any sense of what was happening on the screen, or what anybody thought of it. Nico and Guy seemed to be holding their breath, glued to the screen. Not much talking was going on in the headset, and Nikki wasn't speaking anyway.

But the picture began to clarify, as Nikki glared at the stripper viciously, then folded her arms forcefully and plopped into the nearby bench seat where she had been sitting before, her face a mixture of raw, believable anger and pouting – so believable, in fact, that Jack was almost caught up in the drama, feeling jealous of Nikki's jealousy of Slivovitz.

Nico made another noise. "Heeeehhh," he said, in a joyful tone. "She is Russian hooker in past life, no?" He lifted a finger to the screen and moved it between Nikki and Tango, who was watching her with interest, while Slivovitz patted the lap dancer on the ass and said something in Serbian, tucking some cash into her g-string while she held up her hair and smiled.

Nikki pouted, took out a cigarette, and started to light it, feigning infuriation and an ability to hide it very, very well. She wasn't being dramatic, she was keeping herself to herself, not overly obvious in anything she was doing.

In Jack's ears, he heard the click, click of the lighter, and on screen Nikki appeared to be unable to use the Bic lighter and be extremely frustrated.

The lap dancer left, and Slivovitz turned to Nikki, who glared at him and continued to attempt to light her cigarette. He waved his hands around and said a bunch of stuff in Serbian, while Nikki rested her elbows on her crossed legs and kept trying with the lighter, glaring.

“What the fuck have I told you about this smoking, I see, you’re doing this because you’re upset, is that it, you’re going to smoke and then what, don’t be like this, *myska*, you’re making a scene in front of this very important gentleman...” Nico was translating with the enthusiasm of a hungover teenager working at a petting farm on a 100 degree day.

Nikki at last lit the cigarette, and then triumphantly sucked a whole bunch of it up and threw herself against the back of the booth, her right foot swirling angrily as her left foot bounced. She blew smoke steadily in Slivovitz’s direction and glared.

“Mr. -”

“YOU NOT SUPPOSED TO HEAR THIS NAME!” Nico said loudly, though still unenthusiastically, running over some of Slivovitz’s subsequent words as he did. “ - disrespect. She’s from a small town, she is really some kind of cousin, I should not be fucking her but...” Slivovitz waved his hand in Nikki’s direction, which seemed to provide all the explanation anyone would need.

Tango chuckled. He was staring at Nikki with his hands folded over a fairly large belly and grinning. His interest in her was obvious, and a chill was beginning to travel along Jack’s spine.

Tango leaned back in his chair, his eyes shifting from Slivovitz to Nikki, the contents of his thoughts unknowable to all. He looked sinister, and Nico had fallen silent, squinting. Jack very, very much wanted to ask what was going on, but the threat of Tony lingered in the air: *don’t fuck with my op, man*.

Tango raised a hand and snapped his fingers. People started moving around, and terror gripped Jack. He was on the edge of the chair and started to fall off. He cursed and leaned toward Nico.

Nico held up a hand and nearly whacked Jack in the face with the back of it. “This is good,” he said. “Or maybe bad... I don’t know.”

Guy was tapping his foot rapidly and looked nervous. He glanced back at Jack with what seemed like incredulity and pity at the same time.

“She just has to give sign and we pull plug,” Nico said, for Jack’s benefit.

“What is *happening*?”

Nico folded his arms over his chest. “Eh... this man is big guy, but he’s not top dog. He likes idiot, maybe they make some inroads on Serbians, join forces, this kind of thing. Trade horses. But he needs to know idiot is real guy. So this is all...” Nico leaned forward, groaning, and swirled his finger around the images on the screen. “Dogs sniffing asses. First he seemed to not like the smell. But now he orders vodka, usually good sign. I think this Nika, she sells it.” Nico grinned like a new father.

“She should get out,” Guy said, shaking his head.

Nico turned very slowly to Guy and glared at him, then mopped his face with a handkerchief that he produced as effortlessly and inexplicably as his vape pen, which had disappeared. “You-are-not-Slav,” he sang, and Guy picked up the melody and the last two words, so he’d clearly heard it before.

They watched in contemplative silence after this as vodka was brought to the table and Tango made a big show of pouring it into crystal shot glasses from a crystal flange.

“This vodka is from region in my country,” Tango began, loudly.

“Oh here we go,” Nico said. “Vodka story...” he tipped his head back and made a snoring sound, very briefly, and with one eye open on the screens.

Tango finished the lengthy diatribe about where the vodka came from and how it had been smuggled over here. Guy murmured softly, “all vodka is chemically identical,” which made Nico roll his eyes and say something in Russian that was about vodka and some kind of idiot.

“Come here, myska, come and sit on my lap and try this vodka from my country.”

“This is test, idiot. Do not fuck it -”

Tango was holding the vodka out to Nikki, who was shifting her eyes back and forth from Slivovitz to Tango, looking genuinely confused.

“Don’t be idiot, Idiot.” Nico lowered the mic of his right headphone set and spoke quietly. “Alpha is ready...”

It was only then that Jack realized that Nico – or perhaps Guy, or Tony – had monikered Slivovitz with the codename “Idiot.”

Slivovitz glared at the vodka, glared at Nikki and shouted something at her in Serbian, which made Nikki’s eyes go wide. He then stood up, all bravado and macho posturing, reaching for the vodka. He took it, took a sip of it, and then handed it to Nikki. More Serbian, Nikki looking somewhat frightened, but more like she was realistically in the scene as a hooker/cousin/girlfriend from a Serbian farm than a paramedic who was in over her head.

Jack glanced at Nico, who seemed to be the best for interpreting this kind of thing. He had a finger to his lips and was scowling, but he pointed it at the screen after a bit. “Idiot is not such idiot, I am thinking.”

“What?” Jack said, exasperated.

“Listen to me -”

“YOU ARE NOT HEARING NAME,” Nico blared abruptly.

“ - come from, come here, Nika, baby...” Slivovitz was saying, waving Nikki over to him. She complied, uneasily, and sat on Slivovitz’s lap, while he talked to her in Serbian and Nikki warmed up, melting into him, putting her arms over his shoulders and even smiling – as though she were forcing it a little – and then tipped her head against his. Slivovitz drew a finger from her lips to her chin, down her throat, and between her breasts, all while speaking Serbian, before turning to Tango.

“... we share hot women, good fucks...” Slivovitz handed the vodka to Nikki, who took it and smiled, and held it, as Slivovitz moved his hand up her leg, beneath the dress, his fingers driving in deep. “Cousin, even...”

Tango was rapt with attention, watching Nikki as Slivovitz began to undress her a little, pulling one shoulder of her tight dress down, then the other – kissing her on the shoulder and speaking Serbian, which Nico was not translating. He was watching, enjoying the show. Guy couldn’t take his eyes off it either.

Slivovitz turned to face Tango now, pulling Nikki’s left shoulder down until her whole breast was freed from the confines of the dress. Nikki allowed this, looked bored even – at least, she made it seem like it happened all the time – and when Slivovitz left her breast exposed and put a hand around her thigh, turning her to sit fully on his lap and facing Tango, she moved in his hands like a puppet.

Or not like a puppet, Jack thought, as quickly as the word “puppet” had risen to his consciousness. She was not behaving like a puppet at all within five seconds – she arched her back, lifted an arm and put it behind Slivovitz’s head, smiled, her lips full and appealingly pouty the whole time.

And where Slivovitz had his hand up her skirt, between her legs... she spread them open. The result was that her very short dress rolled up her legs to her hips, and her lower torso – with no underwear – was fully exposed. Her pussy – bare as it could get – spread open for Tango, and Slivovitz slipped his fingers into her folds.

All the men watched, obviously enjoying the show. Slivovitz's gnarled finger slipping through the dark line of Nikki's slit.

“But we don’t share this,” Slivovitz was saying, patting Nikki’s pussy, “with just anyone. Only good friends.” Slivovitz patted Nikki again and spoke into her ear, and Nikki closed her legs and smiled as Slivovitz fondled her breast, twisting her nipples, and then slowly wrapped her flimsy dress back up her torso.

He took the shot from Nikki - who had held it in her hand without spilling it this whole time, aloft like a tiny teacup - and poured it into her mouth, then kissed her violently, grasping her hair as he did to mash her mouth against his.

“Holy shit,” Guy said. He looked over at Nico, as if for explanation.

Nico was staring at the screen, but his interest seemed far more professional than anything else. He was frowning slightly.

Tango watched this whole scene unfold, his eyes right on Nikki the whole time, smiling – but the sort of crooked, unreadable, inherently sinister smile

of a Russian mobster. Jack was jumping out of his skin, but since he couldn't think of anything intelligent to ask, and didn't know what the hell was going on, he shut up and stared.

Nikki had returned to tipping her head against Slivovitz's shoulder, and now Slivovitz was groping her casually, looking at Tango, who was still glowering with his menacing grin.

"Yes," he said at last, lighting up his own cigarette. He was looking at Nikki, not Slivovitz – this was obvious even in the grainy grayscale. "But you know, I am Russian, Dragan. We have similar custom. We are same men, Serb and Russian. Real men. You know I have this problem, my friend. I want more of these..." he made a circle with his cigarette as he searched for the word, "good friends." He took a moment to gaze at Nikki salaciously.

"But I have problem: everywhere I go, there are not-so-good friends, they want to be good friends, but I have to think... what if they are not such good friends? How am I to know? You know? I am a peasant, did you know that?"

Nico, along with all the men on the screen, laughed in their own way about this and murmured something in Russian. Slivovitz also joined in saying something along with them, nodding his head. Nikki smiled uncertainly.

"Is joke," Nico said, for Jack's benefit. "Country boys... eh, no time to explain."

Slivovitz stared at Tango, then reached for Nikki's face and very tenderly pulled her hair from her cheek, leaned in, and began speaking into her ear. Nikki tipped her head forward, so there was no telling what was being said, or what language Slivovitz was saying it in.

Guy crunched into a Bic pen, crushing the entire plastic sheath in his teeth and then, looking shocked, spat them onto the floor. Nico hauled on his vape, leaving it in his mouth without holding it in his hands while he busily adjusted something on his many, many control panels. Hastily, he pulled down the mic and spoke into it: “Hold it, hold it... see what she says...”

Jack felt like he was going to puke. “Are you -”

Nico snapped his fingers violently in Jack’s face, without looking away from the screen. Vape smoke was filling the van. Nico was holding his left headphone closer to his ear.

“He tells her, make the decision...” Nico said, into the mic from his right ear. "This is recognized code from idiot.... advise wait and see..."

Nikki turning her face to Slivovitz.

Slivovitz bouncing her a little on his knee.

Nikki looking tentative, unsure. Looking back to Tango.

A moment, as though time had stopped. The only indication that it hadn’t was the sound of Nico blowing a steady stream of vape smoke into the already cloudy van, and Jack’s own pulse, squishing in his ears.

Nikki stood up, tugging her dress down, but halfheartedly, like she didn’t really care if it covered her or not. She looked back at Slivovitz, who smiled and slapped her on the ass. Then she smiled shyly, and took a few steps toward Tango.

Nikki turned back to Slivovitz and said something in – evidently – Serbian. It was short, three brief words – and Slivovitz smiled.

“She wants to know, do it here, or somewhere else,” Slivovitz said.

“Holy *fuck*,” Guy whispered. leaving his mouth hanging open.

Nico leaned forward and flipped a few switches, which made lights go off on the equipment and then new lights begin to blink frantically. He took the vape from his mouth and leaned over to Guy. Pointing with the vape toward the back of the van, he said, “You have to take shit, yes?”

Guy looked over at Nico, then to Jack, then back at Nico, before clamping his mouth shut and rolling his chair around to face the back doors. “Yep.”

“This should be very long shit, yes, son? You ate too much cheese at lunch, I notice this.”

“Yep,” Guy said, his eyebrows skyward as he closed the van doors after hopping out, one final, longing glance at the screens.

But Jack hadn’t paid much attention to any of this, because the whole time his own eyes couldn’t have been pried from the scene on the screens in front of him with a crowbar.

Nico continued swiveling around, from his position facing the back door of the van to face Jack, but he was moving his feet in a slow shuffle and he didn't stop as he circled around. He was slowly rotating as he waved his hand in front of Jack's face.

"This is where op gets very gray," he told Jack. "Tony says again, do not fuck up. Tony says leave van if you feel like fucking up op. Okay?" He was facing the front of the van now, his head swiveling more slowly than his body. His straight-lidded Slavic eyes challenged Jack, then he grinned, then he shook his head and murmured away in Russian as he completed his circle and focused on the screens again.

Eyes back on the woman in the video. Nikki, but not Nikki.

She was standing in front of Tango, the name that would not be named for Jack, and the man had his hands on her legs now, slowly sliding up her skirt, reaching deep. His beady eyes were on her face, and though the video wasn't very clear, Nikki's face was calm, almost like she was content.

Terrifyingly, at least to Jack - she looked as *in* her element as she did laying stomach-down on the street intubating a patient with a crushed face.

She let the mobster feel her up, and Slivovitz watched impassively, but the longer this went on, he began to get agitated. He had taken one of Nikki's cigarettes and lit it up, and began coughing when he took his first drag, which made Tango tip his head to the side to look at him. His hand was still moving beneath Nikki's skirt.

Slivovitz coughed, "Fucking Russian cigarettes," followed by a string of Serbian, which made everyone laugh distractedly. But all eyes were on Nikki, enjoying the show, waiting to see where it would go.

And then, in a flash, the dynamic in the room shifted. Jack could see the change as it moved across Nikki's face: the dulling of her eyes, the setting in of the vacant expression that she had worn with Tony.

And it was only then, as Nikki twisted her hips alluringly, leaned forward to put her hands on Tango's shoulders and let him gaze into the cleft between her breasts, and opened her mouth to roll her tongue along her molars (something Jack couldn't *see* but knew she was doing), that Jack realized:

Nikki was a fake submissive, an elaborate trap for alpha men: she was no more out of it as she stared vacantly at the wall than when she was finding a vein in a crack addict. Whether this had always been true of her, or a dormant quality that had been unearthed and refined by Tony, or just Nikki's typical lust for competence in all things, would be forever debatable.

Maybe she had never known this about herself and only recently discovered it.

It made no difference.

She bent over to move her face down Tango's torso, and Slivovitz's eyes went to her ass. From the angle of the camera, the details of Slivovitz's view were not visible, but Jack could see for himself that her dress was snaking up her hips again, so he likely had a view of the reddish-orange crepe, bunched up right through the middle of her ass, her bare pussy glistening beneath the rounded shape of her buttocks as they spread out to form their appealing, bent-over splendor.

Down Nikki went, with no nod to decency or primness, her hands following her head, until she was contorted in the way that strippers became: a sexual pretzel, her ass jutting out behind her, the dress now well up over the round of her ass.

And then she bent her knees, and lowered herself to them, tossing her hair as she looked back at Slivovitz, who seemed to have been temporarily zapped into a state of forgetting who he was and what he was doing.

"This idiot," Nico said, "is going gongo looking at your wife's pussy... is very nice, idiot, but get head in game..."

Nico chuckled, seemingly genuinely amused.

Slivovitz shook himself, though, and his face transformed, from mesmerized and amused, to slightly annoyed and jealous in an instant. He held a hand up, saying, "Wait, wait, wait, wait, wait..." followed by something in Serbian as he fished into his pocket. He produced a small square of foil - a condom - and held it aloft, waving it. "Her brother, he will

kill me, you understand..." He stood up, opening the package, and Nikki turned back to Tango, smiling wickedly.

Slivovitz stood behind Nikki and she met Tango's eyes with her wicked smile, letting it sink into him, full of dirty promises. Her hands moved in his groin area, unbuttoning his suit pants, feeling for the zipper. But she tipped her head back, exposing her long neck and opening her mouth for Slivovitz, who placed the condom on her tongue.

A voice in Russian.

Nico shook his head and made the sign of the cross while translating, in his dry monotone:

"Hooker... this thing at mass... communion waffle..."

Tango tilted his head to the side while Nikki took his cock in her hand and tipped her head forward again, her eyes on his face, and bared her teeth - with the ring of the condom tucked neatly between them, before she lowered her head and proceeded to work her mouth over Tango's cock.

Jack felt the phantom sensation of Nikki's condom trick on his own dick as her face disappeared in Tango's lap and the mobster worked his fingers into her hair. He tipped his head to watch her as she bobbed diligently on his shaft. Slivovitz settled back into his seat and lit another cigarette, this one evidently causing him no trouble, and smoked, watching Nikki suck Tango off.

"She's very nice, your cousin," Tango remarked, lifting Nikki's hair and letting it fall through his fingers, as if he were examining it like a product he was deciding to vend.

Slivovitz shrugged, his eyes on Nikki. Smoke was leaving his open mouth, and a scowl was developing on his face.

Nico, who seemed capable of reading minds, stole a glance in Jack's direction. "He plays game. You remember, this is dogs sniffing asses, okay? He has to look like... he's not so happy cousin is sucking dick."

"But... he's the one who told her -"

Nico waved this away. "This is part of ass-sniffing. These mob guys, they make girlfriends fuck 'friends,' they get off on it, but then they go home and smack girl around to save..." he whirled a finger in the air, "...status." Nico had additional commentary about this, but he delivered in a low rumble in Russian.

Tango was leaning his head back, obviously about to erupt. His fingers dug into Nikki's hair, and she worked more quickly. Below the distant throb of the music and the other sounds picked up on the mics that flooded the headset, Jack distinctly heard a repetitive, slurpy moan that was coming from her throat.

Tango smashed her face into his groin suddenly, his head snapping forward. He folded over himself and Nikki's head like a man who had been kicked hard in the stomach, and his mouth was open when he grunted, which came across like a bark.

He gripped Nikki's head and shoved it roughly up and down his shaft a few times, before releasing her and flopping back against his chair, panting loudly enough to be heard above the music.

Slivovitz was staring at him now, smoking, squinting with his scowling face scrunched up. He blew the smoke out in a steady stream while Nikki fell

back onto her heels and let Tango's cock slither from her mouth. She opened her mouth wide and smiled, then brought a finger to the corner of her mouth to swipe away a stray glob of spit.

Tango was still for a moment, breathing heavily, his big chest rising and falling as though he were struggling with a heart attack. Jack had a brief moment of amusement as he looked at Nikki, who was still playing her role but, Jack could see - and maybe Jack alone - she was also watching the guy like a paramedic. He wondered if she would jump on top of this guy and start pounding on his chest if he had a cardiac arrest from this exertion.

It was an interesting question to think about, but there was no time for that. Nikki, still on her knees, looking vacant-eyed and bimbo-esque again, seemed to have decided that Tango would not die on her, and she wriggled her butt while she pulled her dress down, put her hands to her hair and fluffed it, and then turned to Slivovitz with an arm extended and a bored, empty-headed pout on her face.

"You are sure wife is American?" Nico mused.

Slivovitz glared at Nikki and blew another stream of smoke from the corner of his mouth before handing her the lit cigarette, as if this was an exchange - blow job for mob boss for a cigarette - that they transacted all the time. Nikki took the cigarette and turned back to Tango, who was now grinning, to take a drag.

Then she rolled herself up, neatly and gracefully, and sauntered over to the booth where she had been sitting before, feigning irritation with Slivovitz's hooker.

Slivovitz followed her with his eyes, something brewing in them that looked real enough for Jack to have yet another pang of fear for Nikki,

which subsided only when he remembered that Slivovitz was not actually a Serbian mafia wannabe - or whatever he was hawking here - but a cop, and Nikki his partner in undercover crime.

Tango was resting his arms over the back of his chair and grinning, his cock still out on his suit pants. He beckoned one of the henchmen standing around and barked something in Russian, while Slivovitz turned to Nikki and said something icily in Serbian.

"Go get Katia, Tango says, and Idiot is saying... I don't know what idiot is saying, something when he gets home he will ..." Nico stopped translating, because a lot of activity was taking place. Russian everywhere, Nico listening in, picking up on translating again.

Nikki rolled her eyes at Slivovitz and continued smoking. A lithe blond came with another flagon of vodka on a tray and a wary expression, her eyes darting around the group. Tango waved her over to him and she moved there reluctantly, and after a brief exchange, she leaned over and put her hand on Tango's cock, pulling the condom off.

Tango caught her hand and pulled her to him, and she gave him a look that seemed more annoyed than anything, but then smiled, and, holding the condom aloft in one hand, reached for a shot glass on the table. She bent her knees to reach it, her back erect, her dancing bona fides on view - she was clearly a ballerina in another life - and then, making even Nico's mouth fall open, she dumped the contents of the condom into a shot glass.

Jack stopped breathing. Nico held his hand up. Jack had moved his headphones off his ear to hear Nico's translations and now heard Tony barking loudly in Nico's headset, to which Nico was shaking his head.

"No no, don't pull plug just yet, wait, wait, yes, here he is saying -"

Nico became annoyed and swiped the headset with Tony's voice clean off his head. It snapped together loudly and clattered onto the counter, then to the floor.

"I grow up in small village," Tango said loudly. "We don't waste." He laughed grotesquely, and slapped Katia on the ass, prompting her to tip her head back and shoot the overflowing shot of semen. There were grotesque cheers, and Nikki lost her cool for a brief moment as her mouth fell open and her eyes went wide. Slivovitz smiled and then looked over at Nikki, glaring at her - but this time it was a warning to put her facade back on.

Nikki, unflappable to the end, blinked, and her features settled back into her bored, vacant hooker expression. She leaned forward and fished another cigarette out - Jack had noticed that when the attention wasn't on her, she was letting most of the smoke drain slowly from her mouth and then sucking only the tiniest bit through her nostrils. It had a sexy effect, but he knew Nikki was also trying to filter her harsh Russian cigarettes as much as possible.

Which, taken all together, made Nikki the coolest cucumber - in Tony's parlance - he had ever seen.

Another round of vodka was poured, more English talking in low voices and coded speech. Jack stared at his wife, and Nico pounded on the van. "Okay, Guy, get pants on, back to work now!" He tipped his head back without taking his eyes off the screen. "Recorder is working again. Miracle." Then he reached forward and flipped the switches he had flipped earlier.

Guy had a weird look on his face when he came in, and he averted his eyes from Jack like he was an elephant in the room. "Where are we?" he asked

Nico, putting his headphones on.

"Tango is making tentative deal, and good news for state apparatus: video begins recording again in the jack of time."

"Nick," Guy corrected.

Nico raised his hand without looking over at him and slapped him very lightly on the back of the head. "Am I correcting your Russian, shit for brains?"

Guy nodded and mouthed "yes," but not in a way that Nico could see.

Nico was very happy now. He murmured something and then sat back, both hands on the back of his head, fingers interlaced. "This cat, she has slipped Idiot under door."

Jack sat back against the side of the van and nearly knocked something off the wall, which he steadied before Guy could look back frantically at him.

"Oh!" Nico said, rolling his girth around to twist his neck and look at the floor, his hand sweeping around for the headphones. "I forget about Tony."

He put the headphones back on his head as he had them arranged earlier, but said nothing. He remained like that until, after several rounds of drinks and lazy conversation, one more stripper coming through for a lap dance, with Idiot and Tango talking over her hipbones, Slivovitz looked at his watch and stood up. He snapped his fingers at Nikki, a bodyguard handed him a phone, and the group dispersed, making slow headway through the strip club to the exit.

"And that is wrap for spy van, cosmonauts" Nico said, then clapped his hands together loudly, issued a few professional-sounding, coded messages

over his mics, and powered the whole thing down.

He rolled around to face Guy. "I think this Nika catches big fish for us."

They held up their hands to Jack, so he fist bumped them, but his mind was in million other places at once. And his balls felt like they were going to fall off.

CHAPTER 14

When the van door opened, Tony was standing outside with his hands folded over his chest. He was beaming - as much as a guy like Tony could be said to be "happy."

He nodded at Guy and Nico as they piled out of the van, reserving a glare for Nico, who stopped next to him and fished a pack of cigarettes out of his pocket, lit one, and began smoking, all of which took him under a second.

"You bark too much in my ear, Antone, this is irritating to me."

Tony was unimpressed.

Nico put a hand on his shoulder - a telling display of a relationship between the two of them - and patted him. "She had handle on things." Nico looked back at Jack, who was still sitting in the van because he wasn't sure how to get out and not fall over. "She breaks this case wide open."

Tony was unable to hide a tiny smile.

Jack wobbled out of the van, hoping he was doing a better job of looking like he had his shit together than he actually felt.

People squeezed past them and climbed into the van, collecting things and running checklists, while Jack and Tony stood facing each other for a moment. Tony finally took a step toward Jack and said, in a low voice:

"She did a real good job, Jack. Professional. She made this whole thing take off. Smart thinking, Gutsy. Exactly what I wanted -"

"You said no -"

Tony got up in Jack's face. "Listen to me, man. Whatever it is you think I said there wouldn't be any of: there wasn't. You feel me?" Tony let this sink in for a second. "But let's say there was. *Nikki* done made that choice: she had a way out any time she wanted it. We told her to pull the plug on it, and she ran with it instead, which is an operational move she was empowered to do. I ain't never seen anybody play nothin' like that as cool as Nikki just did. And now, I got this guy thinkin' Slivovitz is a real funky piece of shit who bangs his cousin and pimps her out to his friends. You can tell that kinda story all day long to these pieces of shit, and they ain't gonna buy it. They gotta see it."

Jack was still frowning; he could feel it on his face.

"Now. We gonna go debrief. And Nikki gonna be a fuckin' hero. But - and this is the thing, maybe you gotta understand - ain't nobody, *nobody* gonna be talking about this op anywhere outside them four walls. You hear what I'm saying? Because what's on the tape is the only thing that happened here, and *the tape* don't show Nikki doin' anything but smokin' cigarettes and lookin' trashy. And *the tape* ain't never gonna see the light of day. Only person watchin' that again gonna be Nico. And then it's gonna land on a magnet." Tony pressed a finger piously to his lips. "Hear what?"

"Tony -"

"Man, shit. Be fuckin' professional. Your wife professional. She gets it."

Tony leaned back, relaxing, maybe because he could see that Jack's tensions were abating somewhat - the idea of the tape getting out all over the APD had been his main cause of discontent.

He even smiled a little. Put his hand on Jack's shoulder and dropped his voice. "'Tween you and me: that only made me want to fuck that pussy

harder." Tony chuckled, and stepped away, about to break into his surprisingly fast walk. "Ain't they ever teach you paramedics to assess and adapt? Shit man, enjoy the ride." He shot an arm out to his right, like a weapon. "Exit over there."

*

The op, in a twist of mafia lore that had seemed unrealistic to Jack at the beginning, had been conducted on a Tuesday around two in the afternoon. The last rays of sun were still disappearing behind the dense cloud cover in the east when Jack - having been ushered through a security gate by a no-nonsense female uniform who seemed to have been expecting him to trudge up to her - walked back to his car, which was parked about three blocks away.

He drove home, because he wasn't very clear on how long anything would take. Tony had given him permission to be in the van, and he was only just now picking up on what an extraordinary measure it was (legal gray area, as Tony would say).

And now he was adrift, with a dull ache in his half-erect cock and electric pain coursing through his balls. No idea when his wife would be home, his head full of mind-blowing images and thoughts.

He went home to an empty house: the kids were now practically on autopilot. Cole had an away match and didn't want anyone there for it, and Rye had acquired a girlfriend and spent most of his time "at a friend's." Both had texted to say they wouldn't be home until late.

Nikki messaged him as soon as he was pulling into the driveway.

Just got my phone back.

We have some stuff to do here, I don't know how long it will take.

I'll call you as soon as I can. I love you xoxoxoxo

Jack tried to distract himself by tackling a procrastinated project for work, something he should have been working on that day, instead of hiding out in a police van watching his wife blow a Russian mobster. The words on the screen swarmed in front of him and turned into a soup of byte-sized letters that swirled into grayscale images of Nikki's lips around cocks, Nikki's bored expression as she smoked, Nikki spreading her legs on Slivovitz's lap.

He had so many questions, so many burning desires: was Nikki going to be a paid police whore now? Was she going to start smoking and doing lines of coke in strip clubs, sucking cock for the APD? Was what Tony said true, that only Slivovitz, Nico, Tony and Jack, would ever know that Nikki blew a Russian mobster? Or would it actually work its way around the emergency services grapevine, and the whole world would know that Nikki was a huge slut, willing to fuck anyone in, on, or around the police tactical team?

And how did he feel about that, if it *was* what happened? This had always been a razor-sharp edge of the double-sided knife that was Tony: on the one hand, it titillated Jack that his wife - the pristine, unflappable, good-girl Nikki Hillier, would have a reputation as a hotwife. Maybe he even liked the idea that she would have a reputation as a slut among the cops, because there was something in the brew of Tony's alpha-maledom and the weird respect/humiliation he conferred upon Jack, that Jack... maybe didn't like, but got off on.

And there was no denying that he fucking *loved* Nikki fucking Tony. He loved every barrier she crossed, even if he equally hated something about it.

But the thing that really kept him thinking was the paradigm shift that had taken place in the van: the abrupt shift of perspective, the realization that Nikki was now empowered with something she had never exhibited before. A raw, sexual power that she had always been in possession of, but never used.

Her guilelessness about her sex appeal was forever gone. Any idea that Nikki had always known of her powers and simply chosen not to deploy them was erased by tonight's events. And this change, Jack realized, was irreversible. No matter what he thought or felt about it, he was going to have to live with it.

Could he live with it? He really didn't have a choice, and, he realized, staring at the screen for the twentieth straight minute of listless meandering in his mind: he was the one who had hovered over Nikki and this Pandora's Box, his fingers tapping together with anticipation, his cock hard and dripping precum, his eyes lit up with eagerness.

Maybe Nikki had taken the plunge to open it. But he had helped her along, loosening the catch.

The minutes dragged by, the internal video of Nikki on her knees sucking Tango's cock, and splayed out on Slivovitz's lap while he fingered her, played over and over and over again in his head, but his stomach was a ball of molten lead, his heart was racing so fast he vaguely wondered if he shouldn't drop by the base station down the street and get someone to read his EKG, and he couldn't have masturbated the pain in his cock away with all that going on if he had wanted to.

*

This is Tony typing. We're going to Stripeys to celebrate a job well done. Nikki is going and it's an order. Show up if you want.

*

Stripey's was as full as Jack had ever seen or imagined it, which was weird on a Tuesday and made his heart plunge to the floor when he walked in. For a moment, he had the idea that the entire PD had come to celebrate Nikki being a slut and accomplishing whatever she had accomplished, and a frisson of violent revulsion shook him.

"It's always like this on Tuesday, man. What do you *want*?" the bartender replied, annoyed, when Jack inquired.

Slivovitz, Tony, and Nikki were installed at a cluster of tables near the bar with four or five other guys, none of whom looked familiar to Jack. They were all beefy Slivovitz-types. Slivovitz himself was in a baseball cap and sunglasses, even though it was already night, and Jack guessed it had something to do with his soft undercover status - but he wasn't about to ask.

He went to the bar directly and kept an eye on the table. They were all interacting much like they had been the first time he had entered Stripey's to find his wife with the military-grade robocops: eyes were on Nikki but in glancing blows, she was laughing at something a cop Jack didn't recognize was saying, propped up on slightly taller stool than anyone else like a pretty blond princess slut. She had changed into jeans and a t-shirt, and pulled her hair into a ponytail, and looked like she had just come off shift at the AFD.

Jack ordered a beer. No one had noticed him yet, and he was contemplating his approach.

"Jesus, what the fuck kind of bar is this, right?" A familiar voice was in his ear.

A well-toned, extra-long, tan arm reached over his shoulder and stabbed several cherries from the garnish tray, just as dark black curls tumbled over his shoulder.

Angie.

He turned to look at her. She bit at each cherry she had skewered like a snapping turtle, grinned, and chomped them down mercilessly. "Hiya." Then she slapped him - hard, as this was Angie's only slap-setting - on the back, and made eye contact with the bartender. "I need a huge fucking beer man. Any kind. And I'm here with those -" Angie lifted her arms and pointed with two hands at Tony's table, "fucking heroes, okay? So make it on the house. And don't give me piss water just because I'm Fire. I fucking hate that shit, man."

As almost everyone did with Angie, the bartender had a brief moment of disbelief that a pretty, six-foot tall broad with serious guns and cotton-candy colored fingernails and lipstick was ordering him around like that. Then, some internal calculations completed, he laughed and got to work on her beer.

Angie slapped Jack again. The woman would be great at a choking scene. "So Nikki, huh? I hear it went really well. Did it go really well? Can you tell me? Somebody's gotta tell me. That Tony guy is a real fuckin' piece of work, hey?" Angie looked over her shoulder and swiveled her head back after a glance, sneering. "Jesus. *Cops*."

Angie's drink was ready before anyone who had ordered before her, and she worked her magic on the hoots of disapproval like she usually did, lifting

her huge beer high over their heads and saying, "Yeah, yeah, gentlemen, the hot chicks always cut the line, easy boys, don't wanna piss y'all off, might need you to come direct some traffic around a real problem someday. Ah, cool your fuckin' jets."

"Borelli, go get yourself an old man, stop bustin' our balls," someone called from the other side of the bar. Angie lifted her beer to him before taking a sip of it as she spun off toward Nikki's table, where by now everyone had been alerted to Angie's presence, and therefore, also to Jack's.

Nikki was smiling at him. Tony lifted a hand to wave him over. Angie was already there, and evidently knew half the cops at the table because the first thing she did was set her beer down and make it splash on one of them before jumping on another guy's back and attacking his head with her knuckles.

Nikki worked her way out of the corner where she had been stashed, glancing at Angie with her usual look of exasperation, and approached Jack, smiling. She grabbed his hand and closed her fingers around it, standing on her tiptoes to kiss him on the cheek.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. "There was no way out of this." She plunged her hand between his legs briefly, excitedly. "And, it's fun."

"My *man*," Tony said, holding a beer up in Jack's direction. "Your girl here did some *amazing* work." Tony was speaking loudly, putting a huge hand on Nikki's shoulder as she worked her way back to her seat, one hand still holding on to Jack, pulling him with her. Tony shook Nikki a little, like she was a prop in a play.

As everyone always seemed to do around Tony - all men, anyway - everyone was now listening to the huge man with rapt attention. Angie

settled into the lap of her noogie-cop-friend, and slapped his hand when he reached for her ass, smiling for Tony.

"Course, it's all classified," Tony said loudly, "but let's just say that - and I don't like to admit this, so I ain't gonna own it if it gets out -" he pointed a finger at Angie, who crinkled her nose and pretended to zip her lip - "but... it's true, and again, I ain't gonna say it twice... but the AFD may have, may have mind you... saved our asses by loaning this doll out."

"You're welcome!" Angie replied energetically, picking up her beer to toast him.

"Ain't said nothin' like that," Tony replied. "And all the credit goes to Miss Nikki here, who is one *hell* of an asset."

Slivovitz, unusually quiet, lifted his beer and chugged it, seemingly needing to gag himself.

The tables disintegrated into the usual canned laughter for an event like this one, and then broke up into side conversations. The ambiance was jovial, rowdy, celebratory. No different than AFD after a grisly scene or a big fire: all the old stories were trotted out, everyone had too much to drink, shots were sent over from various clusters of cops in a steady stream.

Jack sat down next to Tony and it was business as usual for him. Once or twice it seemed like he was looking at Jack, sizing up what was going through his head. Jack tried not to stare at Nikki, who flitted around like a butterfly, returning to sit next to him and put her hand on his thigh, and then flitting off to participate in a story, add a detail, laugh at a joke, take a shot with someone, get a bear hug from a departing patron.

Jack eyed the group, saying nothing. Slivovitz was unusually subdued, his eyes wandering to Nikki and shifting over his beer mug. Jack thought he saw a kind of perverse jealousy burning in them, which was a problem he hadn't even considered. It settled like silt inside his torso, filmy and greasy, and ever-reminding him that it could be stirred up at any moment.

It wasn't the first time he'd had to sit through a bar scene, faking conversation and getting drunk, while dealing with the ebb and flow of arousal creeping into his cock constantly. People mingled; he got caught up in a conversation with Angie. Slivovitz continued to pout heroically, and Jack couldn't guess if this was a tough-guy act or what: firefighters had a similar thing going on after they made a save or did something badass on scene. It was part of a complicated system of signaling their unsung hero status.

As Mike would say: "At the end of the day, man, you see a guy doing something and it makes no fucking sense, guarantee you, every time, it's about status. And pussy."

Tony disappeared at some point. Nikki flitted about, always coming back to touch base and rub her hand on his thigh, wreaking havoc on his cool. She leaned over and told him she was going to the bathroom in the middle of one of Angie's stories.

She didn't come back for a long time, and Jack began to zoom out of the immediate conversation. No Tony, no Nikki.

He excused himself, saying he had to piss. No one was paying any attention to him, and this is what he repeated to himself as he approached the bathroom corridor: no one here had any idea what was going on between

him, Nikki, Tony, and also Slivovitz. This was an ordinary day in an ordinary world for most of them.

The corridor to the bathrooms was a long, narrow walkway. No one was in it. He moved toward the bathrooms tentatively, looking behind him. There was a deep recess to the right, midway down the corridor, where the last working pay phone, probably on earth, was stashed with some boxes about ten feet deep into another tight corridor that had a dark nest of shadows off the side, like a storage room. Jack had already seen it, so he was already thinking that someone could be tucked away there, and so he slowed as he neared it.

A look behind him, a look in front. Still no one. He pressed his back against the rough brick and edged close to the opening. He heard Tony's voice - not what he was saying, just the low rumble. A lilty giggle: Nikki.

Jack halted in his tracks and edged back until he was just peeking around the corner.

Tony had an arm braced against the wall over Nikki's head, his fingertips practically at the ceiling. Nikki was leaning against the wall, one foot tucked up to place her sole flat against it, and she was rolling her head side-to-side. Negative. She was smiling, tucking a strand of hair over her ear.

"Come on, baby," Tony was saying, moving one hand down the front of her shirt, between her breasts, to the button of her pants, which he tugged gently until they popped open. He leaned his big head in, turning the back of it toward Jack. He was probably murmuring something in Nikki's ear. Beneath her jeans, Tony's hand was wriggling, working down, rolling beneath the material right between her legs.

Nikki laughed, and pushed him away, pulling his hand from her jeans. She turned her head at that moment, and Jack ducked behind the brick wall, shuttling all of his perception to his ears.

No movement.

He dared to peek out again. Lust, he was thinking, made you do stupid things.

Tony had his fingers in his mouth and was sucking on the tips. Words were leaving his mouth in a low, insistent rumble. Nikki was smiling, but still rolling her head side to side. Jack stepped back, looked down the corridor, down at his pants, where his erection was obvious and strong, and decided to stroll past the open hallway as if he was headed to the bathroom.

He backed up and then went at a clip and saw Nikki and Tony straightening up like two teenagers caught in their parents' house as he passed.

He heard Nikki laugh, her voice saying something indistinctly, and then he was in the bathroom.

He locked himself in the only stall and exhaled sharply. He didn't have anything to do in there but wait for his erection to go away, which didn't seem imminent. He couldn't have pissed if he had tried, and he realized that he was probably in the stall that Nikki had fucked Slivovitz in, which wasn't helping his erection at all.

He stared at the door.

How did I get here? was scrawled in block lettering midway up the gray metal.

The door hinges squealed and the music of the bar filled the bathroom.
"Honey?"

Nikki. Jack stared at the door.

"You in here?" The door swung shut. "Jesus, this *bathroom*," she commented.

"Hey," Jack said, unlatching the lock. Nikki appeared in the doorway. She leaned on it, smiling. Then she bit her lip. She looked him up and down. "Look," she said. "I'm thinking maybe we should get going..." she leaned out and then walked to the door to the corridor, clicking a lock on it.

She returned, grinning, and walked toward Jack with one hand out toward his groin. She caught his cock and balls in her hand, cupping them, massaging his raw dick through the material. "Tony's trying to get me to go home with him," she said, stepping closer, flicking his button open with her thumb in a sophisticated trick that he hadn't been aware she knew how to do. She tugged his zipper down, her hips swaying seductively. Her eyes dropped to his groin as she tugged his jeans down and worked her hand around his cock.

Jack let her do all of this, paralyzed by disbelief and confusion, his pulse pounding in his ears. Her touch set his cock ablaze, and he actually felt the oozing precum squeezing from the end of his dick, into Nikki's busy fingers, which were massaging him while her other hand worked his boxers and jeans out of the way.

Her body was very close to his now, her lips glossy and pink, eyelashes thick with black mascara and the same dark shadow that had given her such a slutty appearance at the op. "Did you see everything from the van?" she

purred, smiling for herself, full of pride, in full possession of her hypnotic powers. "Or did they kick you out?"

She seemed to have the answer to this question already. She was already talking when Jack nodded.

"I know it was a little over the line... but..." she leaned in to him and growled in his ear, "I was thinking about you watching me the whole time, and it was *hot*."

Jack's cock, which felt so distended to him that it seemed like it might split open like an overcooked ballpark dog, reacted in Nikki's hand, telling her everything she seemed to want to know: she squeezed him back and her felt the shape of her mouth change to a wet, wide-open smile. "I'm so, so, horny," she breathed in his ear.

Then she was traveling down, down his torso, her eyes looking up at him wickedly from beneath the penumbra of her eyelashes, glinting with Nikki's new brand of mischief. She crouched, showing her old personality had not died inside her like an old star. Nikki was still a health-care professional, and she did not put anything but her feet on bathroom floors. She had to stick one leg out and spread her legs wide to line his cock up with her mouth. She seized it with one hand. "Do you want me to show what I did?"

But Nikki was not waiting for an answer. No sooner had she spoken than she was rubbing his cock over her lips, looking up at him, her eyes burning through to the very center, molten core of Jack's sexual soul - and then, his consent and approval implicit in his dumbstruck paralysis, she took him into her mouth. She braced herself with one hand against the wall and the other on Jack's hip. Her mouth enveloped him, and he put his arms up to hold onto the low walls of the stall.

His cock bumped against the back of her throat, and then she began to *suck* - actively, with harder suction than he thought even possible. She moved back up to the crown, and swirled her tongue around the ridge. A wet splutter punctuated the end of her journey, and then she dove sloppily onto his cock again, her tongue busy in her mouth, criss-crossing the underside and top of his shaft, its movement inexplicable, unbelievable, completely new.

And then again, with a pause on her second trip to breathe heavily with her mouth open and cream-stained saliva linking the tip of his dick to her lips. She curled her tongue to scoop a drop of precum from it and then dove in again, moving her hand down to cup his balls and roll them in her open palm.

All the while, full of an element that had never lurked beneath the surface, her eyes fluttered open to look at him, the eye contact punching a hole through his chest each time she made it. When she started to bob on his head enthusiastically, quickly bringing him to orgasm, Jack had to tip his head back and break the intensity.

Vaguely he heard someone pounding on the door as his cum boiled up from his balls and ravaged through the ducts of his shaft, swelling against Nikki's busy tongue. She pushed herself all the way down to his base and shifted her jaw to massage him as he erupted in her mouth. His right hand slipped from the stall wall, dropping to her head, grasping her hair in his fingers, but his limb moved in slow motion. Everything seemed to be in slow-motion: Nikki's lips, the stream of cum pouring into her throat, the movement of her hand on the underside of his balls.

Nikki swirled her tongue around his shaft as she let it slip from her mouth, licking up every drop of cum as she did. She paused with her hand wrapped

around the base, still crouching in the trashy, stripper-like pose, looking at his dick with what almost seemed like introspection.

Then she lay her tongue flat and licked his crown, wetly, and pushed her hands out to the stall to steady herself as she popped up to standing. The banging on the door resumed, a male voice annoyed because he had to piss. Nikki zipped Jack up, smiling. "Well, it wasn't exactly like that, obviously. But you get the idea."

Jack was just staring at her, open-mouthed.

Nikki leaned her forehead in to touch his. Her fingers played up and down his chest, over his shirt, their movement benign and yet charged with sexuality. On her breath the scent of sex, missing the sweetness of her pussy, jarringly dirty. A lingering wisp of tobacco. Her lips were no longer shiny, and a smudge of mascara had bled along her eyeline, looking like pencil gone awry.

She straightened him out, like he was headed to work in the morning, and then lifted a hand to wipe the corner of her mouth. Backed out, smiling, beckoning him to come with her.

She glanced in the mirror, primped her hair, gave him a glance over her shoulder, and grinned as she unlocked the door. "One more drink," she was saying as she did so, "and then we'll go home."

Slivovitz was standing outside the door. He looked surprised, then irritated, then looked over to Jack, then changed his expression again. He pushed his huge bulk in, making Nikki move to let him in, and with a swagger went over to the urinal, grinning with a locker-room grin. "And *what* is goin' on in here, hmm?"

Nikki met his eyes in the mirror and shrugged, smiling, then sauntered out of the bathroom. Slivovitz watched Jack in the mirror as he exited, grinning and occasionally looking down at his dick. "That is one fucking *crazy* beast you got there, man," he said. He pounded a lever and flushed. "Good luck drivin' that."

Jack didn't have any idea what to say to that, so he shrugged as well, and left with his hands in his pockets, following his wife out to the bar.

*

"All right," Tony said, when Jack sided up to the bar. Nikki had flitted past him, probably grinning, one hand sliding over his chest as she passed, and was now smiling knowingly at them from where she was sitting, listening to Angie tell an animated story. Slivovitz came around the corner, a scowl on his face. Jack was aware that he had a bit of a shit-eating grin plastered to his own, but he couldn't do anything about it.

Tony chuckled and lifted his own drink - whiskey now - to his lips. "Nikki bein' bad or good tonight?" Tony pointed to his drink and then to Jack, smiling. He dipped a finger into his whiskey and sucked on the tip of it, loudly. Whether Tony knew that Jack had seen him fingering Nikki or not, was a mystery Jack didn't really feel like solving.

The question lingered in the air, and Tony watched Jack, making it clear with his intense brown eyes that he wanted an answer.

Jack took the whiskey the bartender offered him and sipped it.

"Gotta tell you, Tony," he said at last, turning to look at his wife, who was, other than her streaked mascara, the picture of innocence in her bobbing

ponytail and wholesome outfit, laughing hysterically with Angie, clinking a glass together. "I do not know."

Tony chuckled and clinked his glass against Jack's.

"Yeah. She funny like that."

END

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